Meet Your Future: Experimental Evidence on the Labor Market Effects of Mentors*

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Abstract

After years of schooling, young adults in many countries enter labor markets that are difficult to navigate, often leading to discouragement and underutilization of human capital. Can workers a few steps ahead help them navigate this critical juncture? To study this question, we designed and randomized *Meet Your Future* among vocational students transitioning from school to work. The program connects students with workers successfully employed in the study sector for one-on-one mentoring sessions. Three months after graduation, mentored students are 15 percent more likely to work, more likely to hold jobs in the study sector, and 27 percent less likely to exit the labor force. While there are no short-run earnings gains, mentored students earn 18 percent more one year later and experience more stable and steeper employment trajectories. Using rich survey data and transcripts from mentor–mentee calls, we show that mentorship works not by expanding job networks or changing job search intensity or effectiveness but by combining belief updating with encouragement. Mentored students lower reservation wages for entry-level jobs while maintaining a positive outlook about medium-run earnings. As a result, they accept lower-paying first jobs, start working sooner after graduation, and accumulate sector-relevant experience that accelerates progression along the job ladder. The results highlight the power of encouragement paired with realistic feedback and point to mentorship as a scalable complement to workforce development programs.

JEL codes: D83, J24, J64, O10

Keywords: Youth Unemployment, Job Search, Belief Correction, Mentorship, Overoptimism

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1 Introduction

Over the next decade, 1.2 billion young people will reach working age in developing countries (World Bank, 2025). This demographic expansion has coincided with rapid increases in educational attainment, producing historically large cohorts of young workers entering the labor market with higher skills and expectations than previous generations. While a growing body of evidence suggests that returns to tertiary and vocational education in low- and middle-income countries are positive and long lasting, particularly when training quality is high, these returns often materialize gradually and do not insulate graduates from early-career instability, reflecting high churn and low-quality initial matches (Saavedra, 2009; Alfonsi et al., 2020; Jia and Li, 2021; Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman, 2023; Londoño-Vélez et al., 2023; Alfonsi et al., 2024; Agarwal and Mani, 2025). Graduates must still demonstrate their skills and build employer trust in environments where credentials are imperfect signals (Bassi and Nansamba, 2022; Carranza et al., 2022). When early job search efforts yield low pay, unstable work, or repeated rejection, workers can become discouraged and withdraw from active search, reverting to casual employment, subsistence activities, or inactivity (Belot, Kircher, and Muller, 2019; Bandiera et al., 2022; Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman, 2023). As a result, investments in education and training do not always translate into sustained career trajectories, leaving substantial human capital underutilized.

Supporting workers through this critical transition, when discouragement risk is highest, could prevent premature exit and preserve human capital investments. Yet providing effective guidance is challenging, particularly when expectations are misaligned with reality. Experimental attempts to correct overly optimistic beliefs about early labor market opportunities through standardized information alone have delivered limited or adverse effects among educated youth. Evidence from Mozambique and India shows that providing information on labor market conditions to overly optimistic university graduates and vocational students leads to selective belief updating in some settings and induces exit from training or placement pathways in others (Jones and Santos, 2022; Chakravorty et al., 2024; Bhatiya et al., 2026). Personalized job search counseling and advice have proven effective in high-income and technology-rich settings (Belot, Kircher, and Muller, 2019; Barbanchon, Hensvik, and Rathelot, 2023) yet delivering similarly individualized support in low-resource environments remains difficult, and human-led job counseling interventions have generally produced limited impacts (McKenzie, 2017).

In this paper, we study whether mentorship can recalibrate young job seekers' expectations about the labor market while sustaining persistence during the school-to-work transition. We design and evaluate Meet Your Future (MYF), a mentorship program that departs from traditional information-based interventions by pairing job seekers with workers a few years ahead in their careers, who exemplify attainable career trajectories and actively support persistence during the school-to-work transition.

We evaluate the impacts of MYF using a randomized experiment with 1,111 vocational students in three large urban labor markets in Uganda. The intervention consists of a one-on-one mentorship rolled out during the school-to-work transition, beginning approximately one months before graduation and continuing after graduation. Students are first randomly assigned to receive MYF or serve as controls; those assigned to MYF are then randomly matched to mentors, with each student paired with a single mentor while mentors support multiple mentees. We collect six rounds of survey data spanning two years prior to graduation and one year after. The pre-graduation surveys allow us to track the evolution of expectations, while post-graduation surveys capture short- and medium-run labor market outcomes. As part of a unique data effort, we record over 350 hours of student-mentor conversations. By capturing not only the substantive content of these interactions but also nuanced attributes like engagement and conversational richness this dataset allows us to directly examine the process through which mentorship operates and open the black box of mentorship.[1]

We begin by documenting large and systematic distortions in students' beliefs about entry-level pay prior to the intervention. We directly compare what students expect to earn before graduation, as elicited under incentive-compatible belief measures, with what they actually earn in their first job. By this within-person comparison, nearly all control students over-estimate their initial earnings. We also uncover an additional dimension of misperception: students hold distorted beliefs not just about the starting point, but about the job ladder itself. They underestimate the returns to experience and fail to see how early, even unpaid, employment is often a stepping-stone to better jobs. This is evident in their expected job trajectories: when asked where different pathways would lead, students assign similar medium-run outcomes to those starting with unpaid work and those starting with unemployment, despite differences in realized career paths. Our data reveal not just distorted beliefs about what is available now, but flawed expectations about how careers unfold, and how early steps shape upward mobility on the job ladder.

Next, we examine the short- and medium-run impacts of the mentoring program on labor market outcomes, moving beyond a static snapshot of employment to examine both immediate employment and career advancement during a critical adjustment period marked by

[1]The experimental design, primary outcomes, and core analyses were pre-specified prior to implementation. Specifically, the study underwent Stage-1 review at the Journal of Development Economics. The pre-analysis plan approved at Stage-1 is available at https://afosterri.org/jdepreresults/sample-page/. Online Appendix G documents deviations from the pre-analysis plan and reports additional analyses specified, all of which are consistent with the results presented in the main text.

short spells and frequent turnover. Three months after the school-to-work transition, we identify a significant improvement in labor market outcomes. Mentored students are 15 percent ($p = .00$) more likely to be working at the time of the survey, they have worked more in the previous month, and the likelihood of being out of the labor force, defined as neither working nor searching, is 27 percent lower ($p = .00$). Not only are they working more, but they are much more likely to do so in their training sector, reinforcing and building on their vocational skills. At the same time, short-run earnings do not increase, reflecting the fact that many newly accepted jobs are unpaid or low-paid entry positions.

These accelerated first employment spells enabled treated students to climb the career ladder faster. Within the first year after the intervention, they are significantly more likely to be promoted, both within the same firm where they obtained their first job (+23%, $p = .04$) and through job-to-job moves across firms (+21%, $p = .03$). One year after the intervention, treated students earn 18 percent more than controls ($p = .10$). Conditional on employment, earnings are 14 percent higher ($p = .06$), suggesting that these gains reflect progression into better-paying positions. These earnings gains, robust to multiple inference corrections and outlier-sensitive quantile treatment effects, are concentrated in the mentoring-only arm, where effects are both larger in magnitude and more precisely estimated.[2] While the labor markets these graduates enter are large and diffuse, we further rule out crowding-out effects using data on friendship networks within schools.

To guide the interpretation of our results, we introduce an extended version of the (McCall, 1970) job search model that incorporates subjective beliefs about entry-level wages and experience premia, as well as two key decision margins: the reservation wage below which job offers are rejected, and the decision to actively search rather than become discouraged and exit the labor force. The framework generates testable predictions for each of the four broad categories of support pre-specified in the study design through which mentors could affect mentees' labor market outcomes: (i) job referrals, (ii) search tips, (iii) information about entry-level conditions, and (iv) encouragement. We use the content of the audio recordings to verify that mentor–mentee interactions map into the four categories. We then bring the model predictions to our rich survey data and find that information about entry-level conditions and encouragement emerge as the main ways through which mentors affect workers'

[2]These findings are consistent with the limited experimental evidence on post-training work-based experiences in low-income settings. Most of the related literature focuses on wage subsidies targeted at low-skilled unemployed workers, rather than on graduates of vocational or other post-secondary programs. Two notable exceptions are Honorati (2015), who studies a post-graduation internship program in Kenya and reports positive labor market impacts 15 months after completion, and McKenzie, Assaf, and Cusolito (2016), who evaluate a similar intervention in Yemen and find positive effects five months after program completion, although further follow-up was not possible. Our results are also consistent with a broader body of descriptive and qualitative evidence suggesting that employers use early employment spells to screen for hard-to-observe attributes.

labor market success. Through the lens of the model, mentorship increases both job seekers' propensity to search and willingness to accept job offers. Mentors are particularly effective at correcting overly optimistic beliefs while simultaneously mitigating discouragement. Mentored students lower their reservation wages and become more willing to accept unpaid positions as first jobs, reflecting a revised understanding of the role of early employment in shaping longer-term career trajectories. Quantitatively, reservation wages decline by 32 percent ($p = .00$), and overall labor market participation increases. Treated students are 3 percent more likely to initiate job search after graduation ($p = .05$) and 23 percent less likely to reject a job offer while seeking their first job ($p = .06$), allowing them to secure employment 30 percent faster. We find no evidence that the treatment operates through direct job referrals or improvements in search ability. This conclusion is consistent both with the model's predictions and with our empirical results, which show that there are no treatment effects on detailed measures of search intensity, search broadness, search effectiveness, or reliance on mentor-provided referrals. These behavioral responses are mirrored in direct measures of beliefs three months after graduation: mentored students become significantly more accurate in their expectations, without exhibiting signs of pessimism or reduced labor market attachment.[3]

To confirm that MYF influenced labor market outcomes through learning about entry-level market conditions and encouragement to persevere, we leverage a second randomization built into the study design—the random assignment of students to mentors. Although mentors were drawn from a common pool and followed the same program guidelines, they varied substantially in the content and emphasis of their interactions with mentees. Because students were randomly matched to mentors, this variation generates plausibly exogenous differences in the type of mentoring support students received. We begin by documenting substantial heterogeneity in mentor effectiveness using Empirical Bayes methods to estimate mentor-level impacts while accounting for noise due to finite sample sizes. The resulting bias-corrected variance indicates that some mentors were significantly more effective than others. We construct mentor types using a leave-one-out design: for each student, we classify a mentor based on the takeaways of their other mentees, excluding the focal student. This ensures that mentor types reflect systematic differences in mentors' emphasis rather than individual-level responses or outcomes. We then instrument mentor type with men-

[3]These results align with interdisciplinary evidence showing that how difficult information is delivered shapes behavior. Research in medical psychology highlights the importance of combining realism with hope and a sense of agency to promote active coping (Ptacek and Eberhardt, 1996), while a large literature in economics emphasizes that messages from relatable role models are more likely to be internalized when success appears attainable, thereby shaping beliefs and effort toward long-term goals (Beaman and Magruder, 2012; Hoffmann, Junge, and Malchow-Møller, 2015; Porter and Serra, 2020; Carlana, La Ferrara, and Pinotti, 2022; Breda et al., 2023; Riley, 2024).

tor assignment indicators. Mentors who primarily provided information about entry-level conditions or encouragement significantly increased students' willingness to accept job offers and improved short-run labor market outcomes. Mentors emphasizing encouragement also have the strongest effects on career progression, reflected in sustained improvements along the career trajectory index. In contrast, mentors who focused primarily on job search tips had no detectable effects on any outcome.

To assess whether liquidity constraints limit the extent to which students can act on mentorship, we also introduce a one-time cash transfer amounted to 40,000 UGX (approximately $12) to a randomly selected subset of mentored students. Even with information and encouragement, students may be unable to accept or persist in low-paid entry jobs if immediate income needs instead push them toward casual or subsistence work. Similarly, mentorship that encourages more intensive or broader job search may fail to translate into action if students lack the resources needed to cover basic search-related expenses. Comparing outcomes for students assigned to mentorship alone with those who additionally received the cash transfer, we find no differential short-run effects on employment, earnings, or job quality. Unexpectedly, at the one-year mark, observed treatment effects are driven entirely by students assigned to mentoring only. In this group, labor force participation increases by 23 percent ($p = .06$) and earnings by 31 percent ($p = .01$), with effects that are both economically large and statistically robust across multiple specifications. In contrast, in the mentoring-plus-cash arm are substantially smaller and statistically not significant. While survey evidence suggests that liquidity is not a first-order constraint, with over half of recipients saving the transfer, the cash nonetheless altered the mentoring relationship. Students in the cash arm are more likely to focus on actionable search tips and to report search strategies as their main takeaway, primarily at the expense of encouragement, despite similar meeting frequency. This pattern is consistent with the cash transfer crowding out the relational and motivational components of mentorship that appear central to its medium-run impacts, in line with evidence that monetary inputs are not psychologically neutral, and can reframe social interactions toward more transactional relationships (Gneezy and Rustichini, 2000; Ashraf, Field, and Lee, 2014) as well as activate or substitute for mechanisms typically targeted by "soft" interventions such as aspirations, and motivation (Haushofer and Shapiro, 2016; Dercon et al., 2023).

Finally, we assess the cost-effectiveness of the Meet Your Future program by estimating its net present value and internal rate of return under alternative assumptions about the persistence of earnings gains and the existence of scale-up costs (Al-Ubaydli, List, and Suskind, 2019). Because we observe outcomes up to one year after graduation, we avoid long-horizon extrapolation and instead treat persistence as an explicit parameter.[4] We therefore evaluate returns over one-year (observed), two-year, and five-year horizons using the pooled treatment effect. Across plausible persistence scenarios and conservative cost assumptions, the program exhibits high returns relative to its low implementation cost. Under the observed one-year gains, estimated benefits already exceed program costs for most scale-up cost scenarios; under slightly longer persistence (two years), implied internal rates of return exceed 110 percent. If returns are instead benchmarked to the mentoring-only arm, estimated returns are even larger. These estimates compare favorably to returns reported for many active labor market policies in similar settings and underscore the potential of low-cost mentorship interventions. MYF is also simple to implement and highly scalable, relying on mentors only a few years ahead in their careers rather than individuals at the top of the labor market hierarchy, thereby expanding the pool of potential mentors and lowering recruitment costs.

Contributions First, we contribute to the mentorship literature. Existing research on mentorship largely focuses on organizational settings, where mentors support employee advancement, leadership development, or career progression within firms, mostly using observational designs (Levinson, 1978; Allen et al., 2004, 2017; Brooks, Donovan, and Johnson, 2018; Sandvik et al., 2020; Chien, Grennan, and Sandvik, 2025). A separate literature examines mentorship in educational contexts. Here, several observational studies and some experimental evidence document improvements in school outcomes (Jacobi, 1991; DuBois et al., 2002; Eby et al., 2008; Crisp and Cruz, 2009). However, in the few studies that examine labor market outcomes, the evidence is mixed. For example, Rodriguez-Planas (2012) evaluates a mentorship program aimed at increasing school enrollment among low performing high schoolers and finds that, while educational outcomes improve, these gains do not translate into employment, underscoring the limits of interventions not tailored to labor market integration. Ongoing work by Bell (2025) studies a childhood mentorship program targeting disadvantaged children and links treatment assignment to administrative data, documenting positive effects on later earnings driven by long-run social and identity channels.

Our focus is on a mentorship intervention that we explicitly designed for the school-to-work transition. Findings from Resnjanskij et al. (2024) in a high-income setting motivate our approach to studying mentorship as a tool for improving youth labor market entry in

[4]Evidence from low-income countries suggests caution when extrapolating short-run impacts of active labor market policies, as most studies do not track outcomes beyond 18 months and longer-run effects often attenuate (McKenzie, 2017). At the same time, the first year after labor market entry is not an arbitrary horizon. A large literature documents strong path dependence in early career experiences, with initial job placements shaping subsequent skill accumulation, earnings trajectories, and employer matching, and potentially generating scarring effects from early placement into low-paying or low-skill jobs (Autor, Levy, and Murnane, 2003; Acemoglu and Autor, 2011; Gathmann and Schönberg, 2010; Autor and Handel, 2013; Deming, 2017; Kahn, 2010; Oreopoulos, von Wachter, and Heisz, 2012; Altonji, Arcidiacono, and Maurel, 2016; Huckfeldt, 2022).

developing countries, where unemployment and underemployment are widespread and early career setbacks can have lasting consequences. Resnjanskij et al. (2024) examine a mentoring program targeting eighth- and ninth-grade students in Germany and show that, for disadvantaged students, mentorship improves an index of labor market prospects that includes school performance, patience, social skills, and labor market orientation. While realized labor market outcomes cannot yet be comprehensively assessed because most participants remain in education at the three-year horizon, Resnjanskij et al. (2024) find that in the sub-sample of students who transition out of education, the low-SES who received mentorship are more likely to have started work. Importantly, they show that mentorship effects on labor market orientation persist well beyond the duration of the program.

Within this literature, our paper makes two main contributions. First, we provide experimental evidence on a mentorship intervention explicitly tailored to the transition from education to the labor market, a critical phase with lasting consequences for career trajectories. Second, we open the black box of mentorship in labor markets by combining random mentor assignment, rich survey data, and detailed audio recordings of mentor–mentee conversations. This design allows us to identify not only whether mentorship works, but how and why it does, all while studying its natural form without scripting mentors or imposing artificial interaction protocols, and in a high-stakes, non-gamified labor market context.

Second, this paper contributes to the literature on behavioral job search, which emphasizes the role of psychological and behavioral frictions in shaping job search behavior. A large body of work shows that search intensity and persistence depend on factors such as impatience, locus of control, self-confidence, and willpower (DellaVigna and Paserman, 2005; Falk, Huffman, and Sunde, 2006; Caliendo, Cobb-Clark, and Uhlendorff, 2015; McGee and McGee, 2016), as well as on present bias, reference dependence, motivated reasoning, and intention–behavior gaps (Abel et al., 2019; Cooper and Kuhn, 2020; DellaVigna et al., 2022; Mueller and Spinnewijn, 2023; Vyborny et al., 2025).

Recent evidence shows that misaligned expectations, particularly overoptimism, play a central role in job search and unemployment dynamics Spinnewijn (2015); Mueller, Spinnewijn, and Topa (2021). In India, Kelley, Ksoll, and Magruder (2024) show that high expectations can lead to voluntary unemployment, while in South Africa and Uganda, Banerjee and Sequeira (2023) and Bandiera et al. (2023) document that misperceptions can generate search strategies that end in discouragement and lower-quality employment. Attempts to directly correct overly optimistic beliefs among educated young job seekers have failed or backfired. Information interventions targeting university graduates in Mozambique and vocational students in India leave expectations unchanged or induce training dropout (Chakravorty et al., 2024; Jones, Santos, and Xirinda, 2024; Bhatiya et al., 2026). Even Abebe et al. (2025) who study indirect belief updating through exposure to firms at a job fair, find effects for less educated job seekers and not for more educated participants.

Our contribution is to show that mentorship can succeed where information alone fails by combining belief correction with sustained encouragement, thereby avoiding the discouragement and early disengagement documented in prior work. Focusing on educated youth preparing to enter skilled sectors, we show that mentorship helps job seekers revise overly optimistic expectations while maintaining persistence during the transition into work, when returns to education are real but delayed (Alfonsi et al., 2020). This mechanism speaks directly to concerns about discouragement and disengagement among young workers more broadly, including in high-income settings where unmet expectations and poor early matches are increasingly linked to despair (Blanchflower and Bryson, 2025).

Finally, this study contributes to the literature on job search assistance, particularly job counseling, and to the related policy discourse on addressing youth unemployment in the Global South. Existing evidence from rich countries largely studies job counseling as bundled with monitoring and sanctions, typically delivered by public employment services through case managers in unemployment insurance schemes. Where positive effects have been documented, this type of job search assistance has often taken more personalized and intensive forms, frequently through administratively costly programs (Blundell et al., 2004; Bernhard and Kopf, 2014; Card, Kluve, and Weber, 2010, 2018) or relatively sophisticated technology that can deliver tailored advice (Belot, Kircher, and Muller, 2019).

These models are difficult to scale to low- and middle-income countries, where youth labor market entry occurs at massive scale and administrative and technological capacity is limited.[5] We experimentally show that near-peer mentorship—without monitoring, sanctions, or high technology—can deliver personalized job counseling and improve job acceptance and early career progression for graduates of upskilling programs in which governments heavily invest. Mentorship is also cost-effective, yielding some of the highest internal rates of return observed in contexts where youth face severe labor market constraints, and scalable without the heavy hand of policymakers. These results highlight the potential for mentorship-based job search assistance to amplify the effectiveness of vocational training and address youth unemployment in the Global South.

[5] Even in high-income settings, evidence points to impacts that are sensitive to implementation details such as caseloads and provider incentives, with outcomes differing across public, private, and nonprofit provision Crépon et al. (2013); Card, Kluve, and Weber (2010); Behaghel, Crépon, and Gurgand (2014); Cottier et al. (2018). Similarly, new evidence from France shows that automated personalized coaching raises engagement but not employment (Ben Dhia et al., 2022), highlighting limits to personalization without human interaction.

2 Study Setting

2.1 Labor Market Context and Study Population

The study took place in three urban labor markets in Central and Eastern Uganda. Like many others across Sub-Saharan Africa, they are characterized by high rates of youth underemployment, job turnover, and job separation (Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman, 2023; Breza and Kaur, 2025). Here, most youths, including skilled ones, fail to climb a job ladder. Rather, their employment is characterized by transience and informality. The relative magnitudes of the supply- and demand-side imbalances are unclear. Firms often cannot recruit workers who satisfy their needs. Simultaneously, job seekers' failure to obtain their ideal employment leads to their withdrawal from the job market (Bandiera et al., 2023).

In these urban labor markets, worker-firm matching is largely informal: in the sample of skilled workers from which we drew our "future you," only 2% found their first job via a posted offer. Another 61% did so through friends or family; the rest found it via walk-ins. No one registered at employment centers, indicating the absence of a robust system of public employment services. The high degree of informality and lack of digital platforms make information acquisition costly. This has consequences for match quality. These features suggest that the creation of a connection to a successful worker is a promising intervention.

Vocational Training Institutes To boost productivity, the Ugandan government initiated a strategic plan for vocational education in the early 2000s. This commitment was reinforced with the approval of the Skilling Uganda Strategic Plan, a 10-year initiative, in 2011, and complemented in 2017 by the Skilling the Boy Child and Girl Child program. Today, as in many other East African economies, the vocational sector is well established in Uganda; VTIs are effective at generating productive human capital (Alfonsi et al., 2020), and firm owners are familiar with recruiting their graduates. Although training and credentials raise the propensity for stable employment, the market for VTI graduates fails to clear.

Students/Job Seekers Our sample consists of students enrolled in the two-year, government-accredited National Certificate Program at five vocational training institutes (VTIs) located across Eastern and Central Uganda. The program aims to provide structured, occupation-specific training to students preparing to enter the labor market. The 1,111 students in our sample are trained in 13 skills: motor-mechanics, plumbing, catering, tailoring, hairdressing, construction, electrical engineering, carpentry, machining and fitting, teaching/early childhood development, agriculture, accounting and secretarial studies. These sectors constitute a source of stable employment for young workers in Uganda: they collectively employ about 16% of workers aged 20–30, a percentage that more than doubles if we exclude young Ugandans involved exclusively in agriculture. While Uganda has no shortage of VTIs, there is a long left tail of low-quality training providers. We focus on accredited and well established institutes that deliver formal vocational education. Prior research studying similar VTIs shows that such programs are functional and generate positive, long-run labor-market returns (Alfonsi et al., 2020, 2024). As such, our sample captures a policy-relevant population of Ugandan youth enrolled in practical tertiary training which arguably represents a labor market segment with the potential to become among the most productive workers in the country. Table 1 reports students' baseline characteristics and shows balance across treatment groups: they are on average 20 years old, 41% are female, the majority are single and largely of Christian faith. The sample is relatively heterogeneous in terms of socioeconomic background, and about 53% ever worked before (half, in casual work).

Mentors We selected mentors from the alumni of our partner VTIs who had graduated three to five years before the students' transition into the job market balancing relevant experience with approachability and relatability for students.[6] This selection resulted in mentors on average 5 years older than mentees with an average tenure of 3 years in the labor market. Due to the absence of systematic graduate tracking by VTIs, the identification process involved manually collecting and digitizing thousands of alumni records from physical registries and phone contacts. Through this process, we surveyed 714 alumni and ultimately engaged 158 mentors, selected based on their labor market outcomes, with an emphasis on having stable employment within their sector of training. Additional selection criteria included accessibility (reliable phone access and willingness to participate), academic performance (graduation with honors), and soft-skills (self-reported enthusiasm and shyness).[7]

2.2 School-to-Work Transition: Expectations vs. Reality

Misperceptions About Early-Career Opportunities Consistent with evidence from high- and low-income settings, we document widespread distortions in labor market entrants' expectations about their immediate employment prospects.[8] We elicited expectations regarding the time to first employment and expected earnings at first employment. Their evolution was tracked at four points: baseline, midline 1, midline 2, and midline 3. Monetary incentives were provided to reward prediction accuracy in midlines 2 and 3 encouraging thoughtful responses without influencing students' job search behavior.[9]

[6]We avoided the cohort with one year of labor market experience as they overlapped with our student sample. In our sample, only 3% of mentors had previously interacted with the students assigned to them.

[7]Further details of the mentor selection process can be found in Online Appendix A.

[8]High-income countries: Spinnewijn (2015); Mueller, Spinnewijn, and Topa (2021); Conlon et al. (2018); Belot, Kircher, and Muller (2019); Cortés et al. (2023); Low income countries: Banerjee and Sequeira (2023); Bandiera et al. (2023); Abebe et al. (2025); Kelley, Ksoll, and Magruder (2024); Jones and Santos (2022).

[9]The reward was kept small (a lottery for 15,000 UGX in airtime), with winning chances increasing with prediction accuracy and payouts realized three and nine months later. Following Alfonsi et al. (2020), we

We observe a striking optimism bias regarding the expected wage distribution for entry-level jobs. Panel A of Figure 1 presents the distributions of expected monthly earnings elicited pre-treatment (Expected–gray tones) alongside realized conditional monthly earnings in the control group (Realized–red tones).[10] The patterns remain as striking when examining unconditional earnings. The panel structure of our data collection allowed us not only to provide monetary incentives that rewarded individual-level prediction accuracy but also to validate, ex-post, how students' expectations compared to their *own* realized earnings at their first job. Even when accounting for individual observable and unobservable characteristics (such as where they perceive themselves to be on the skills distribution) we find that realized earnings were only 17% of what they had initially predicted. When compared to their *own* realized earnings after one year, this share rises to 78%, suggesting that while students significantly overestimate their immediate post-training earnings, their expectations align more closely with a longer-term reality. Evidence from an earlier cohort studied in Alfonsi et al. (2020), who enrolled in vocational education in 2012, graduated in 2013, and were tracked through 2018, shows nearly identical patterns. Even before training began, prospective students expected vocational education to raise earnings by almost 200%, far above the estimated realized returns of 42%. This indicates that the optimistic beliefs we document are not unique to our cohort or a product of the labor market conditions they faced. Instead, they are consistent with a model of thin labor markets, in which young job seekers primarily interact with employed individuals, often mid-career workers, and have little access to information about entry-level wages and the realities of early-career employment. This leads them to extrapolate from observed career outcomes, reinforcing their optimism. At the same time, the persistence of these distorted beliefs throughout their training suggests that vocational training institutes may have limited incentives to correct them. Reported placement rates by VTI officials are often extremely high (frequently exceeding 90%) and prominently featured in recruiting materials. These figures may reflect financial incentives in for-profit institutions or lack of awareness of selection bias. Many schools do not systematically track graduates or account for attrition, and when tracking occurs, it is often based on non-random samples, making reported outcomes highly susceptible to selection.

Misconceptions About Job Transitions We also document a new fact: labor market entrants in our context are not only too optimistic about their early wages, they also have a poor sense of labor market dynamics and wage-growth opportunities. Panel B of Figure 1 shows the expected and realized transition matrices of employment pathways from three

estimated expected earnings by asking individuals for their minimum and maximum expected earnings if offered a job immediately after graduation, then their assessed likelihood of exceeding the midpoint, fitting a triangular distribution to measure average expectations.

[10]Realized earnings are negative for a subset of workers, reflecting cases in which individuals pay for training or cover upfront input costs (e.g., materials) associated with job entry.

months to one year after the school-to-work transition. In comparing the two, we gain key insights into how these job seekers perceive job ladders. First, soon-to-be graduates substantially undervalue unpaid initial job spells. They expect unpaid work to be no more likely than initial unemployment to lead to paid employment (46% versus 45%), whereas in reality they are far more effective stepping stones: 54% of those initially unpaid are in paid employment one year later. Second, they severely underestimate the persistence of unemployment. Among control students who are still unemployed three months after graduation, 82% remain unemployed one year later and only 15% transition into paid employment. By contrast, respondents expect nearly half (45%) to be in paid employment and only 20% to remain unemployed. Put simply, they undervalue both the benefits of accepting a stepping-stone job and the costs of rejecting it. Finally, while they underestimate unemployment prevalence one year ahead, the gap between expected and realized paid employment conditional on being in paid employment at three months (55% vs. 62%) suggests that they are not simply holding out for paid jobs because they expect them to be a permanent fix. Instead, they seem aware of high separation rates and the relative instability of first jobs, but fail to appreciate the value of alternative pathways.

The Case for Mentorship This presents a key challenge: while, when effectively implemented, vocational training has high internal rates of return and remains a valuable upskilling and policy tool, it inadvertently contributes to unrealistic beliefs about immediate post-training opportunities, which often fall short of students' inflated expectations. Failing to recalibrate beliefs early on may leave students misaligned with the realities of the job market, ultimately dampening the effectiveness of (expensive) training investments. We test mentoring as a complementary intervention capable of adjusting expectations while preserving motivation through the school-to-work transition. By providing direct access to workers a few steps ahead in their career, living proof of the viability of long-term success, mentorship offers a way to both realign expectations *and* sustain motivation.

3 The Experiment

To study the impacts of mentorship on job seekers' performance, we designed Meet Your Future, a program in which graduates about to enter the labor market are matched to successful workers for one-on-one career mentorship sessions. The implementation capacity of our local partner, BRAC Uganda, and our long-standing collaboration with partner VTIs' management allowed for the randomization of 1,111 students into the study.

3.1 Randomization and Treatment Arms

The experimental design is summarized in Figure 3. Of the 1,111 students in our sample, 30% were randomly assigned to the Meet Your Future Program (T1) and 30% were assigned to the Meet Your Future Program, plus Cash (T2). The remaining 40% form our control group.[11] We stratified the randomization at the student level and included all strata and balance variables in every treatment regression. In all our choices, we followed the principles highlighted by Bruhn and McKenzie (2009) and Athey and Imbens (2017).[12] The identification strategy for our RCT assumes that within each stratum, treatment and control students do not differ on average in observable and unobservable characteristics. To support this, we check for balance across treatment arms on observable characteristics likely correlated with the outcomes of interest. The experimental design is balanced across nearly all variables of interest, as shown in Table 1. Furthermore, we have low attrition: 9% overall, with 16% attrition at endline 1 and 17% at endline 2. We consider these rates satisfactory for highly mobile subjects. Online Appendix B describes the correlates of student attrition; they confirm that attrition is uncorrelated with treatment and show no evidence of differential attrition based on observable characteristics (Online Appendix Table A.5). Therefore, we do not correct for attrition in our main regression specifications.

The Meet Your Future Program We connect students randomly assigned to receive this treatment with "the future you", a successful worker who graduated from their same course of study just a few years prior.As part of the program, we facilitated three conversations, which we refer to as mentorship sessions 1, 2, and 3. During these sessions, students could ask questions as well as share their doubts, fears, and dreams. These interactions were unrestricted: each student-mentor pair could discuss what they found most useful for the student's transition to the labor market. This tailored the mentorship to each student's needs, resembling real-life interactions with a network member. The first mentorship session (MS1) occurred about a month before graduation. It was a conference call between the student, mentor, and enumerator, who initiated and recorded the conversation. Treated students learned about the MYF program from the enumerator during this session. After introductions, the enumerator remained silent. A post-interaction survey followed MS1 to capture students' main takeaways. The second (MS2) and third mentorship sessions (MS3) occurred two weeks before and after graduation, respectively. These sessions, initiated by

[11] To design our intervention and refine survey tools and protocol, we piloted the program with 30 students and 10 mentors from a sixth VTI (not in the main experiment) between October and December 2020. All pilot participants completed the program and provided highly positive feedback.

[12] We stratify along four dimensions: VTI (to account for potential variation in treatment implementation), gender, whether a student was hard to reach (to mitigate the risk of differential attrition), and smartphone ownership, resulting in 40 strata. In Online Appendix C, we provide more details from our pre-analysis plan on the selection of strata and the set of variables for which we required no imbalance.

the mentor, were private conversations between mentor and student. Mentors had to send a text after the completion of each of these sessions to confirm they happened. We double checked this information with the students during endline 1. Students and mentors could interact beyond these three sessions. Mentors recorded the frequency, duration, content, and means of any additional interactions in a logbook.[13] Mentors attended a one-day training led by the research team before the program began. They learned their responsibilities as program ambassadors and discussed how to assist students with workforce transition. To thank them for their participation, mentors received ∼\$40 and airtime reimbursements after completing three mentorship sessions with all students assigned to them and a short survey. Their compensation was not tied to the students' success in the labor market.

To test whether relaxing liquidity constraints would compound the effects of the mentorship program, we provided a random subset of MYF program participants (T2) with 40,000 UGX (∼\$12) upon graduation. While students were requested to use it for job search and required to report their spending to BRAC, the transfer was practically unconditional.

3.2 Program Take-up and Participants' Engagement

Take-up of MYF was high on both the extensive and intensive margin, and equally so in T1 and T2. Overall, 91% of the students assigned to the MYF program corresponded with their assigned mentors at least once.[14] The intensive margin reflects the substance of these connections: although the program was designed to last three months, with one scheduled interaction per month, mentor–student relationships frequently extended beyond this structure. Over the formal program period, pairs interacted an average of 2.6 times, with interactions lasting 51 minutes on average. Many relationships continued after the program ended: by one year, the average number of interactions increased to 7.8, 70% of pairs had exceeded the three interactions stipulated by the program, and, conditional of ever connecting, 45% remained in contact on year after the MYF rollout.[15]

We collected self-reported measures of engagement and perceived usefulness from students. We observed high satisfaction rates across all indicators.[16] Similarly, we construct two indexes capturing students' psychological engagement with their mentor: an Identification In-

[13]Online Appendix A describes the MYF Program in more detail.

[14]Noncompliance was mostly due to inability to contact students. Online Appendix Table A.6 shows non-compliers (56 students) were more likely to be married women with above-mean household assets.

[15]The average total amount of interaction time between students and mentors was ultimately 3.2 hours. This is a relatively light touch mentorship program; a meta-analysis of mentorship programs found an average length of 6.8 hours across 55 mentorship interventions (DuBois et al., 2002).

[16]Between 85% and 95% of treated students agreed or strongly agreed with the following statements: "You felt at ease asking questions and discussing personal issues with your mentor"; "The mentor cared about your personal experience"; "Speaking with the mentor felt comfortable, like being with a friend".

dex and a Transportation Index, adapted from Banerjee, Ferrara, and Orozco-Olvera (2019), and they were consistently high.[17]

We validate these patterns using an exclusive data source comprising over 350 hours of mentorship conversations, drawn from 512 audio recordings of first mentorship sessions for nearly all mentor–mentee pairs who successfully connected; only a handful of recordings are missing due to poor audio quality or lost files. Sentiment analysis with VADER (Hutto and Gilbert, 2014) shows that all participants perceived the conversations as neutral or positive, particularly the students. The mentor-to-student speaking time ratio indicates that mentors mainly led the conversations, transferring content to students while ensuring every student was actively engaged. We also examine when *strong links* form between mentors and mentees, defined as interactions beyond the three required mentorship sessions. We analyze data dyadically, considering both student and mentor characteristics, using a simplified version of the Fafchamps and Gubert (2007) regression model since strong links in our setting can only be unidirectional. Table A.1 shows suggestive evidence that repeated connections are more likely when students and mentors come from the same VTI, while strong links are more strongly associated with smaller age gaps and shared district of origin.

4 Results

4.1 Estimation

In this section, we document how the mentorship program influenced students' labor market outcomes three months and one year after the school-to-work transition. We report ITT estimates, the most useful from a policymaker's perspective, as they reflect likely binding challenges to rolling out similar mentorship interventions.[18] Our estimates are based on the following ANCOVA specification for student i in strata s at endline $t = 1, 2$:

$$Y_{i,s,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 T_{1i} + \beta_2 T_{2i} + X_i' \delta + \lambda_s + \epsilon_{i,s,t} \tag{1}$$

Y_i is the outcome of interest for student i, measured at endline 1 or endline 2 (i.e., three or twelve months after the intervention). T_{1i} is a treatment indicator equal to 1 for students

[17] The Identification Index measures similarity and personal relevance of the mentor's experience (e.g., feeling understood, sharing similar experiences, relating to the mentor's personal story). The Transportation Index measures emotional engagement and comfort during the interaction (e.g., feeling at ease speaking with the mentor, perceiving care and support, and viewing the mentor as someone willing to help).

[18] We also estimate ATE specifications with take-up defined as (i) speaking with the mentor at least once and (ii) completing all three sessions. Results are consistent across specifications. See Online Appendix G for details.

assigned to the MYF program only, and T_{2i} is a treatment indicator equal to 1 for students assigned to the MYF program plus cash. When reporting pooled treatment effects, we replace T_{1i} and T_{2i} with a single indicator T_i, equal to 1 if the student was assigned to MYF, regardless of whether cash was provided. X_i is a vector of individual covariates measured at baseline selected on the basis of their ability to predict the primary outcomes to improve statistical power (McKenzie, 2012). λ_s are strata fixed effects. $\epsilon_{i,s,t}$ is the error term. We cluster errors at the strata level.[19] β_1 measures the causal effect of being selected to participate to the MYF program on Y_i under SUTVA. This will not hold if treatment displaces control students because treated students are relatively more attractive to employers. As we implemented the program in five out of 715 accredited VTIs in Central and Eastern Uganda (1,270 nationwide), which are located in the region's three largest urban labor markets, any advantage for treated students will likely not come at the expense of the control group.[20] Indeed, treated students are a small fraction of the job seekers entering the country's largest labor markets during our period of study. SUTVA could also be violated in the case of spillovers from mentored to control students. To limit their occurrence, our intervention happened after classes were concluded and students had returned home (most of these VTIs are boarding schools.) Further, we are not overly concerned with spillovers, as they are likely to make the estimates conservative, given our methodology. In any case, we mapped the VTIs' friendship networks of each treated and untreated student to rigorously measure them. We examine the spillover effects more in detail in Online Appendix F; evidence in Panel B of Table A.8 suggests spillovers, if any, are unlikely to materially affect our main estimates.

4.2 Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

Panel A of Table 2 presents ITT estimates of the impacts on labor market outcomes at three months, for the pooled sample. We begin by examining the extensive margin three months after graduation. Treated students are 4 percentage points more likely to have engaged in any work activity in the month preceding the survey (Column 1), relative to a control mean of 82%, and they worked 8% more days over that month (Column 2). These measures capture a period in which many early jobs take the form of short internships or trial employment spells, and thus reflect substantial turnover in initial labor market experiences.[21] This is reflected in more contemporaneous measures of employment. Current employment, defined with respect to the week preceding the survey, falls to 62% in the control group by three

[19] In our main specification we do what we pre-specified. However, results are unchanged when we report estimates with robust standard errors in Online Appendix G.

[20] As of 2017-2018, the total number of VTIs in the Central and Eastern regions, both formal and informal, accredited either by the DIT (493) or UBTEB (291) or both (69) was 715.

[21] 82% of those employed at three months are covering a trainee position. At one year, the share of those in a traineeship is only 7%.

months after graduation, consistent with the end of many short initial job spells. Even at this point, treated students are 15% more likely to be employed (Column 3). We see a similar pattern when considering labor force participation more broadly. Treated students are 27% less likely to have exited the labor market altogether, meaning they are less likely to be neither working nor searching for a job (Column 4). Despite higher participation, we find no differences in earnings in the month preceding the survey, either unconditionally or conditional on having worked (Columns 5 and 6). Lastly, Columns 7 and 8 speak to the quality of these early matches. Column 7 shows that treated students are 15% more likely to work in the sector in which they received training, and Column 8 shows that these first matches are more stable, lasting 25% longer. Panel B reports estimates separately for students in T1, who were assigned to a mentor as part of the MYF program, and students in T2, who were assigned a mentor and given the 40,000 UGX cash transfer. At three months, labor market outcomes are statistically indistinguishable across the two groups, and estimated treatment effects are similar in size.

4.3 Transitions and Job Ladder Progression

Columns 1 and 2 of Table 3 report treatment effects on labor market transitions one year after graduation, capturing retention within the same firm following an initial traineeship and transitions into worker positions across firms. Panel A shows that treated students progress more quickly along the job ladder: they are 23 percent more likely to be retained after an initial spell ($p = .04$) and 21 percent more likely to move into worker-type positions in other firms ($p = .03$). These patterns suggest that the more numerous and stable early matches treated students obtained translate into upward transitions over time. Panel B reveals some heterogeneity across treatment arms. While transitions move in the same direction for T1 and T2, point estimates are roughly three times larger in T1. These differences, however, are suggestive, as the estimates are not statistically distinguishable across treatment arms.

4.4 Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

We next examine employment and earnings outcomes one year after graduation. Relative to the short run, effects on extensive-margin labor market participation are more muted (Columns 3, 4 and 5 of Table 3). Panel A shows positive but imprecisely estimated impacts on participation, consistent with treated students being less likely to exit the labor market. Panel B highlights some differences across treatment arms. For students assigned to mentoring only, treatment effects on these participation-related outcomes remain large in magnitude but are statistically significant for one out of three of them ($p = .52$, .32, and .06, respectively). In contrast, students assigned to mentoring plus cash (T2) exhibit negative point estimates along these margins, also not statistically significant. This pattern is suggestive that mentoring alone continues to support labor market attachment in the medium-run, while mentoring plus cash does not.

Turning to earnings, Panel A shows that treated students earn 18% more one year after graduation ($p = .10$). Earnings effects remain sizable when conditioning on employment, with treated students earning 14% more ($p = .06$). Panel B shows that these gains are concentrated in the mentoring-only arm: students assigned to T1 experience large and precisely estimated earnings increases both unconditionally (31.0%, $p = .01$) and conditional on working (23.8%, $p = .00$), whereas earnings gains for T2 are smaller and less precisely estimated. We return in Section 5.5 to the asymmetric medium-run patterns across treatment arms and discuss potential reasons for why the cash transfer weakened medium-run impacts; for now, the one-year results highlight substantial earnings gains driven by mentoring.

Figure 5 and Online Appendix Table A.25 provide complementary evidence that these gains are not driven by a small set of outliers or selective attrition. First, distributional evidence indicates a rightward shift in the earnings distribution at one year, with positive quantile treatment effects at multiple points in the distribution, including 8.26 at the median ($p = .10$), 13.77 ($p = .06$) at the 75th percentile, and 18.15 ($p = .06$) at the 90th percentile. Second, Lee (2009) bounds that account for attrition remain strictly positive for both pooled treatment and T1 and do not include the zero. Third, results are similar under alternative outcome transformations such as log(earnings + 1), with consistently large and precisely estimated effects in T1. Fourth, ATE estimates are also consistent with ITTs and robust to alternative take-up definitions (any mentorship contact versus completion of all three sessions), with larger magnitudes under the stricter definition. Finally, earnings is a pre-specified medium-run outcome, and false-discovery-rate adjusted q-values (reported in brackets in Table 3) remain small ($q = .12$ pooled; $q = .02$ for T1).

This same narrative is confirmed by the pathways analysis reported in Table A.2, where we show reduced-form estimates of the effects of MYF on various pathways to employment in a year. Each pathway is described by the combination of one of three possible labor market statuses: unemployed; working for a zero (or negative) pay; and working for a positive pay, three months and one year after graduation. The sample is restricted to respondents found at both endlines. These outcomes, contingent on employment status at three months, provide suggestive evidence consistent with our thesis that the treatment makes students more likely to accept stepping-stone jobs, which in turn help them climb the job ladder. Panel B shows that the effect is driven by students assigned to mentoring only (+43.6%, $p = .01$). All main results are unaffected by the inclusion of an additional set of controls selected through a double LASSO procedure (Belloni, Chernozhukov, and Hansen, 2014).

5 Opening the Black Box of Mentorship

5.1 Interaction Content and Students' Takeaways

The combination of over 350 hours of audio recordings from mentorship sessions and students' self-reported primary takeaway collected at three points in time provides an invaluable window into the conversations. Panel A of Figure 4 presents the raw conversation content as computed using the text data. To perform topic analysis and discern the content of these conversations, we employ a generative pre-trained transformer model. Specifically, we use Claude 3.7 Sonnet (`claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219`), a state-of-the-art model at the time of writing, developed by Anthropic, to label the topic of each sentence within a conversation.

Informed by economic theory and the context of our experiment, we posit (and pre-specified) that mentors can affect students' career trajectories by providing different kinds of support, which we classify into four types: job referrals, search tips, information about entry conditions, and encouragement. Accordingly, we provide Claude 3.7 Sonnet model with natural language descriptions for each of the four categories plus a neutral, residual one.[22][23] Each observation is a conversation. In addition, each sentence is weighted according to its word count. Therefore, the figure represents the raw proportions of each conversation devoted to discussing entry-level labor market conditions, search tips, job referrals, and encouragement to persevere. Several things can be deduced from this figure. First, job referrals, including both the mention of current vacancies the mentor is aware of and the promise of future job referrals, were less frequent than we anticipated.[24] Second, the majority of conversations discussed all three remaining categories of support, with information about entry-level labor market information and encouragement having the highest correlation in terms of frequency. Lastly, no other major topic was discussed.[25]

While learning about the conversation content is useful for diagnosing what was covered, Panel B of Figure 4 speaks to what students learned. The figure shows the share of students whose main takeaway from the first mentorship session fell into each of the four categories

[22] In previous versions of this paper, we relied on the at the time state-of-the-art BART Model and GPT-4o model. Results obtained using these earlier approaches are qualitatively similar in spirit to those reported here; we update the analysis to reflect the substantial recent advances in large language model performance. See Online Appendix E for details on the procedure and examples of classified sentences.

[23] The taxonomy used to classify mentoring content was pre-specified prior to implementation. Details in Online Appendix E.

[24] We adopt a broad definition of referrals, including any instance in which a mentor discussed a potential job opportunity, a personal contact who could assist the mentee, the name of a possible workplace, or an explicit commitment to providing a referral.

[25] Manual reading of the content categorized as neutral suggests that these are greetings, personal introductions, phone numbers exchange, resolutions of issues related to poor network quality, or short sentences, such as "yes, that completely makes sense"; there are only two relatively recurring topics when the conversation is not linked to the job market: examinations and Covid-19 prevention and worry.

of support. We confirm that job referrals were not the most salient information students absorbed, ruling out the possibility that referrals appear less important simply because they are quicker to convey than other forms of guidance, and note that the elasticity of retention is significantly higher for the encouragement category than for search tips or information on labor market conditions. In particular, students disproportionately retained messages centered on persistence and mindset, such as being patient and flexible, working hard and remaining disciplined, and staying confident and determined in the face of early setbacks. One speculative explanation, consistent with prior work, is that encouragement constitutes a more emotionally salient experience, which may increase memory retention (Cahill and McGaugh, 1998).

5.2 An Illustrative Model

5.2.1 Setup

In this section, we present a stylized model to guide the interpretation of our results and derive testable predictions about the four types of support through which mentors may have improved young job seekers' labor market outcomes.

We consider a partial equilibrium environment with a utility maximizing job seeker whose behavior follows a reservation wage strategy. We model their dynamic responses to the MYF program through the lens of a discrete time version of the seminal search model from McCall (1970) in which search occurs sequentially. We adapt this model to incorporate subjective beliefs about the labor market, following Cortés et al. (2023).[26] Specifically, our representative job seeker has subjective beliefs about the entry wage-offer distribution, $F(\cdot;\mu)$, as well as the experience premium, ω, i.e., the perceived future value of accepting a first job beyond its entry wage. Time t is discrete and job seekers have preferences over consumption given by $u(x) = x$. Job seekers are homogeneous in skill level and infinitely lived. When not working, they earn their value of leisure, b.

Absent the MYF program, in each period t, unemployed job seekers choose whether to search for a job, taking into account the i.i.d. cost of search, $c \sim H(c)$. If a job seeker decides to search, they draw a wage offer w_t with probability λ; conditional on an offer, the entry wage w_t is a random draw from an exogenous probability distribution $F(w) \sim N(\mu)$ with associated density $f(w)$. The job seekers decide whether to accept the offer or wait for the next period. If they accept, they receive wage w_t in period t and, beginning in the next period, enjoy an experience premium summarized by $\hat{\omega}$. If they decline the offer, they return to the search decision step. We do not allow for on-the-job search or job destruction.

[26]More details on where we simplify and expand Cortés et al. (2023) are in Online Appendix D.

Our illustrative model abstracts from liquidity constraints. We do so because direct survey evidence shows that liquidity was not a first-order determinant of most students' job search intensity or job-acceptance decisions in this setting. In fact, while compliance with the cash transfer was high (92%), over half of the students did not immediately deploy the cash toward job search or consumption. Instead, they saved it. Three months after disbursement, only 47% of students report having spent the full amount; this share rises to 86% after one year. Table A.3 corroborates this behavior. While students assigned to T2 are equally likely as control students to report savings at baseline, they are 19% more likely to report savings three months after the transfer ($p = .04$), with no difference remaining at one year. Students in our sample are drawn from households able to finance post-secondary vocational training largely without external scholarship support. As a result, the limited role of liquidity constraints documented here may not generalize to contexts in which youth face more severe liquidity constraints.

5.2.2 Biased Beliefs

To replicate what we establish experimentally in Section 2.2, we assume that job seekers do not know μ, the true mean entry wage offer, nor ω, the wage evolution given by the experience premium.[27] Instead, they form beliefs about μ and act based on a perceived entry wage-offer distribution $F(\cdot;\hat{\mu})$. Likewise, they form beliefs about ω and act accordingly. Job seekers' beliefs are biased if $\hat{\mu} \neq \mu$ or if $\hat{\omega} \neq \omega$. Job seekers with $\hat{\mu} > \mu$ are optimistic. While we allow beliefs to change over time, we also assume job seekers are myopic in the sense that, when making decisions, they treat their current beliefs as fixed going forward (Cortés et al., 2023). As in Krueger and Mueller (2016), learning and convergence to the true values of μ and ω occur slowly. As a result, reservation wages and search participation are chosen based on current beliefs $(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$, without explicitly accounting for future belief updates.

[27] Our framework comprises of distorted beliefs and subsequent learning about the mean-wage offer distribution at labor market entry. Alternatively, biases in job search prospects have been modeled as misperceptions about job-offer arrival rate, λ (Spinnewijn, 2015; Bandiera et al., 2023). While expected and realized job search duration mechanically move in tandem, since search length is determined by acceptance decisions that depend on expected wages, we find that students already have accurate beliefs about job search duration early in the program (expectations temporarily shift during the Covid-19 lockdown period, they subsequently revert and remain closely aligned with realized job search duration, see Online Appendix Figure A.9). In contrast, students substantially misjudge the *type* of positions they are likely to obtain (traineeship vs. temporary vs. permanent) and the associated earnings. In particular, they overwhelmingly seek permanent, paid jobs, despite such opportunities being rare for workers with their profile. In a similar setting, Banerjee and Sequeira (2023) show that young job seekers in South Africa overestimate earnings largely because they overestimate the probability of securing high-wage jobs.

5.2.3 Values of Employment and Unemployment

In keeping with much of the literature on learning, we assume that job seekers optimize within an expected-utility framework. The value of employment at entry wage w, given beliefs $\hat{\omega}$ about the experience premium, solves in closed form:

$$W(w, \hat{\omega}) = \frac{w + \beta\hat{\omega}}{1 - \beta} \tag{2}$$

Let $U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ denote the value of unemployment. Each period the unemployed worker draws a search cost $c \sim H$ and chooses whether to search. If she searches, she pays c and receives an offer with probability λ; conditional on receiving an offer, the entry wage w is drawn from from F, though the worker believes it is drawn from the subjective distribution $F(\cdot; \hat{\mu})$. If she does not search, or if no offer arrives, she remains unemployed. The Bellman equation is

$$U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = \int \left[b + \max_{s \in \{0,1\}} \{-cs + \beta V_s(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})\} \right] dH(c) \tag{3}$$

where $V_0(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ and

$$V_1(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = \lambda \int \max\{W(w, \hat{\omega}), U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})\} \, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) + (1 - \lambda) U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) \tag{4}$$

Given a draw of c, the job seeker compares the returns to searching and not searching. This comparison implies a cutoff rule: there exists a search-cost cutoff $c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ such that the worker searches iff $c \leq c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$. Using the reservation-wage rule below, the cutoff can be written as

$$c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})}^{\infty} \left[W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) \right] \, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) \tag{5}$$

Lastly, the job seeker determines a reservation wage in order to maximize her perceived continuation value during unemployment. We define the reservation wage $w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ as the wage that makes the job seeker indifferent between accepting a job and remaining unemployed:

$$W(w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}), \hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = 0 \tag{6}$$

5.2.4 Predictions on MYF

We predict that a MYF mentor can affect outcomes in three ways:

1. *Job referrals and search tips:* mentors can directly affect the arrival rate of offers λ (e.g., by referring students to openings) or effectively raise λ by improving search effectiveness through tips.

2. *Information about entry-level labor market conditions:* mentors can rectify beliefs about the mean of the entry wage-offer distribution by shifting $\hat{\mu}$.[28]

3. *Encouragement and confidence:* mentors can shift beliefs about the future value of the first job by increasing confidence in wage growth opportunities, raising $\hat{\omega}$.

We derive predictions for reservation wage behavior and search-cost cutoff depending on which mechanisms prevail. Proofs are provided in Online Appendix D:

> **Proposition 1:** Search tips and job referrals, by increasing the probability of receiving an offer ($\lambda \uparrow$), lead to an increase in the reservation wage ($w_R \uparrow$) and an increase in the search-cost cutoff ($c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) \uparrow$).

When the offer arrival rate increases, the job-finding rate rises mechanically. As a result, the job seeker becomes more selective and raises her reservation wage.[29] Simultaneously, because offers arrive more frequently, the expected value of search increases, making job seekers willing to incur higher search costs; the search-cost cutoff c^* rises.

> **Proposition 2:** Information on entry-level labor market conditions that corrects optimism ($\hat{\mu} \downarrow$) leads to a decrease in the reservation wage ($w_R \downarrow$) and a decrease in the search-cost cutoff ($c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) \downarrow$).

By shrinking the *expected* stream of high-wage entry offers, the mentor can induce individuals to revise beliefs downward. Lower perceived prospects reduce the option value of waiting and make job seekers more willing to accept offers, thereby lowering the reservation wage. At the same time, because the perceived gains from searching fall, the search-cost cutoff $c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ declines: fewer cost draws satisfy $c \leq c^*$, so some job seekers search less frequently or stop searching altogether (discouragement on the extensive margin). A large empirical literature finds evidence of reservation wages declining over an unemployment spell as beliefs adjust (Barnes, 1975; Feldstein and Poterba, 1984). More recent evidence points toward underreaction, slow adjustment, and consequent undersearch (Spinnewijn, 2015; Mueller, Spinnewijn, and Topa, 2021). We confirm this pattern in our setting: three months after graduation, control students remain overly optimistic about their prospects. In the next section, we show that these sticky reservation wages shift abruptly under the treatment.

> **Proposition 3:** Encouragement and confidence over a positive outlook, by upward shifting beliefs about the future value of the first job ($\hat{\omega} \uparrow$), lead to a decrease in the reservation wage ($w_R \downarrow$) and an increase in the search-cost cutoff ($c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) \uparrow$).

[28] Mentors can also correct pessimism and raise $\hat{\mu}$. However, less than 4% of control students realize a higher than expected wage at their first job. We therefore focus on the empirically relevant case of $\hat{\mu} > \mu$.

[29] We implicitly assume that job seekers know λ or can update beliefs about λ in response to mentors' support.

Encouragement prevents students from leaving the labor force. When mentors emphasize the importance of persistence, and patience as early jobs, including unpaid or low-paid positions, can be stepping stones with meaningful subsequent progression, treated students become more willing to accept lower-paying first jobs because their perceived future value is higher. At the same time, the higher perceived future returns from any job increase the expected value of search, raising the search-cost cutoff c^*: job seekers are willing to incur higher costs to find employment because the long-run payoff to getting started is greater.

In sum, participation in the MYF program can shift employment outcomes through (i) an *actual* change in prospects, modeled as an increase in the offer arrival rate λ, and/or (ii) a *perceived* change in prospects, modeled as shifts in beliefs $(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$. Proposition 1 describes how job seekers respond to a direct change in the fundamentals of the search problem. Propositions 2 and 3 describe how search behavior responds to changes in perceived fundamentals. Theoretically, both the reservation wage and the search-cost cutoff can move in either direction when multiple channels operate simultaneously.[30] Using our survey data, we now test empirically which mechanism dominates.

5.3 Testing the Model's Predictions Using Survey Data

To test the model's predictions, we can examine the direct impacts the mentorship program had on reservation wages, the search-cost cutoff, search effectiveness, and earnings beliefs.

Reservation Wage and Willingness to Accept an Unpaid Job Columns 1 and 2 of Table 4 report treatment effects on student' reservation wages and self-reported willingness to accept an unpaid position as their first job. The results are clear: the treatment substantially lowered the reservation wage (-32%) and increased the willingness to accept an unpaid job (+13%). These changes translated into changes in search behavior, most notably with respect to job offers acceptance as treated students are 23% less likely to turn down a job offer while looking for their first job.[31] Panel B shows that these effects are similar in magnitude across the two treatment arms (T1 and T2).

[30] An alternative framework that can generate increased search effort alongside a drop in reservation wages is the model proposed by Abebe et al. (2025), which introduces a minimum admissible match quality and a direct cost of unemployment, leading to a discontinuity in the value function. While a compelling approach, we chose not to adopt it for our setting as the assumption that job seekers impose a strict lower bound on match quality is not directly supported by our data (even sector alignment after two years of sector-specific training was not a binding constraint). Additionally, while unemployment is undoubtedly costly, our job seekers systematically underestimate the risks of prolonged unemployment. This suggests that they do not internalize the dynamic costs of joblessness in a way that would generate the type of reservation wage adjustment emphasized in Abebe et al. (2025).

[31] Conditioning on having searched for a job, the estimated treatment effect on job offer rejection is 25% ($p = .05$). This conditional estimate is not reported in the table.

Job Search Outcomes Next, we discuss search behavior. First, we examine the effect of the treatment on the decision to participate in the labor market by determining whether individuals began their job searches after receiving training. In the words of our model, we look at the closest measure of the search-cost cutoff. Column 4 of Table 4 shows that treated students, despite the sharp decline in reservation wages, are more likely to initiate a job search, which matches with the results in Table 2 of fewer students dropping out of the labor force and the overall impact on labor market participation being positive.

We then test whether treated students improved their search skills following the mentorship sessions, which included substantial discussion of actionable search tips. To achieve this, we construct an index of search effectiveness that measures the students' conversion rates during their searches (Column 5). We use two conversion rates. The first is the ratio of interviews received to applications submitted, and the second is the ratio of job offers received to applications submitted. We also include the total number of CVs successfully submitted. We find no effects of the intervention on any dimension of search effectiveness. In addition, in Columns 6 and 7, we rule out variations in two more aspects of searching: intensity, as measured by hours per day, days per week, number of applications submitted, and money spent on searching, and broadness, as measured by number of search and fundraise methods, geographical scope of search and number of sectors searched in.[32] In short, treated students do not seem to have searched any differently.

Finally, in Column 8, we see that conditional on searching for a job, students assigned to a mentor have a 30% shorter initial unemployment spell. As the other columns in the table indicate, this reduction does not stem from more intensive or more effective search. Rather, students in both treatment arms are less likely to reject job offers, reflecting a greater willingness to accept available jobs (Columns 1 and 2).[33] This result is particularly important given extensive evidence that unemployment exit rates decline with duration due to behavioral responses like discouragement and reduced search effort (**?**).

Beliefs Complementary evidence from our direct measures of beliefs strengthens the interpretation of these behavioral responses. Three months after graduation, we asked all students to estimate their earnings one year later (when we would return for the second endline). Column 1 of Table 5 shows that treated students substantially revise expected

[32] While our conceptual framework does not include directed search, we can use rich survey data on the search process to rule out changes in search breadth, as measured by the number of search methods employed, the geographical scope of the search, and the number of sectors targeted. Index components were pre-specified. Again, we observe no treatment effect on any index dimension or the overall index, both overall and when looking at T1 and T2 separately.

[33] In the same vein, students in T1 exhibit narrower search breadth (differentially so than those in T2), driven by shorter distances traveled, and also consistent with a lower acceptance threshold for entry-level positions and reduced reliance on geographically distant, unlikely job opportunities.

earnings downward relative to the control group, by about 8% relative to the control mean, with effects concentrated in T1 (this is the 'cleanest' beliefs outcome in the table, as it captures stated expectations measured at endline 1 without incorporating realized earnings or employment status).

Columns 2 and 3 move from levels to accuracy. Treated students overestimate future earnings by significantly smaller amounts, about 14% in the pooled treatment group ($p = .09$) and 26% in T1 ($p = .01$), and are less likely to overestimate at all. Columns 4–6 report the same outcomes conditional on working. Among control students, beliefs are more accurate once individuals enter paid work, consistent with learning from exposure to the labor market. Mentoring amplifies this process. Relative to controls, treated students who are working exhibit larger reductions in both expected earnings and overestimation. These conditional patterns should be interpreted descriptively, as labor-market entry and employment are endogenous. Yet, they highlight an informative and, at first glance, puzzling point. Treated students revise earnings expectations *downward* and become *more accurate* in their beliefs, even though they earn more one year after graduation than control students. This is because baseline expectations substantially exceed realized earnings in all groups. Mentoring accelerates convergence toward realized outcomes from an initially optimistic baseline, but does not lead to pessimism or discouragement, and belief correction and improved earnings occur simultaneously.

Career Satisfaction Finally, Columns 7 and 8 provide additional evidence consistent with an increase in w_R despite a sizable decline in expected earnings at first job, we find no corresponding decline in self-reported satisfaction with the school-to-work transition, measured three months after graduation. One year later, treated students, particularly those in T1, report significantly higher satisfaction.

Referrals Within this framework, the remaining question concerns the role of job referrals. Did mentors provide referrals, but belief correction dominate the reservation-wage response, effectively overshadowing this channel? Or, were referrals simply not meaningfully provided? To address these questions, we return to our comprehensive survey data. We asked treated students, for each work activity, whether it was obtained through a connection made by their mentor. While 7.4% report receiving or being offered a referral by the alum, only 2.9% secured their first job through one of these referrals, half of which were direct hires by the alum. Results are unchanged when we exclude these observations from the analysis.

Taken together, the evidence aligns closely with the conceptual framework and its predictions. Mentoring induces a downward revision in beliefs about entry-level wages, reflected in lower w_R, higher willingness to accept unpaid jobs and faster job acceptance, consistent with Proposition 2. At the same time, it raises the perceived future value of early work experience, mitigating discouragement, increasing c^* and sustaining search effort, as in Proposition 3. Empirically, the latter channel dominates: despite a sharp decline in reservation wages and earnings expectations, treated students do not exit the labor force more quickly, accept jobs sooner, accumulate sector-relevant experience, and achieve more stable and higher-paying matches over time. In contrast, we find little evidence for Proposition 1: search intensity, search effectiveness, and reliance on job referrals change minimally, and only a small share of first jobs are obtained through mentor connections. Overall, the MYF program operates primarily by reshaping how young job seekers interpret early labor-market signals and evaluate stepping-stone jobs, rather than by expanding the set of offers they receive.

5.4 Mentor Heterogeneity

We next leverage the second randomization built into the study design to investigate whether students assigned to mentors who systematically emphasize different types of support, independent of students' own preferences or baseline characteristics, experience different labor-market outcomes. We proceed in two steps. First, we document the existence of meaningful mentor-level heterogeneity in effectiveness. Second, we use an instrumental variable strategy to examine which dimensions of mentor support account for this heterogeneity.

EB: Variation in mentors' effectiveness We estimate the extent of the heterogeneity using Empirical Bayes techniques. Specifically, we estimate the following reduced-form regression:

$$Y_{i,j,d} = \sum_j M_{ij}\gamma_j + \lambda_d + \mu_i \tag{7}$$

where Y_i is the outcome of interest for student i. λ_d denotes VTI-course fixed effects and M_{ij} is an indicator for whether student i is assigned to mentor j. A standard F-test rejects the null of no mentor heterogeneity ($p = .02$ for the short-run labor market index and $p = .01$ for the career trajectory index). Because the number of mentees per mentor is limited, the estimated mentor fixed effects, $\hat{\gamma}$, obtained via equation 7 are overdispersed: even if all the γ were the same and there was no dispersion in mentor effect, we would still have some chance variation across the $\hat{\gamma}$. We therefore compute bias-corrected estimates of the variance of mentor effects by subtracting the average squared standard error from the raw variance of the estimated coefficients (Kline, Saggio, and Sølvsten, 2020).[34] Figure A.1 reports both the raw estimates and the posterior means under a normal–normal EB model. The resulting bias-corrected variance estimates are sizable: .432 for the short run index and .442 for the

[34] Under the assumption that the estimated standard errors of $\hat{\gamma}$ are reasonably accurate, this variance estimator is unbiased and consistent with a large number of mentors. Kline, Saggio, and Sølvsten (2020) have a general framework for the estimation of unbiased variance components under unrestricted heteroskedasticity.

career trajectory index. These values are large relative to benchmarks in the teacher value-added literature, where disperson above .2 is typically considered substantial (Angrist et al., 2017). Signal-to-noise ratios are high for both indices, indicating that the observed dispersion reflects meaningful heterogeneity rather than sampling variation.

IV: Mentors' types We next examine which dimensions of mentor support account for this heterogeneity. We focus on three mediators that correspond to the main types of support observed in student–mentor conversations and map directly onto the mechanisms proposed in our model: information about entry-level conditions, encouragement, and job search tips.[35]

Let Y_i represent the outcome of interest for student i and let $Info_i, Enc_i$, and $Search_i$ denote indicator variables capturing whether the mentor primarily emphasized information on entry conditions, encouragement, or job search strategies, respectively. In our preferred specification, we construct mentor types using students' post-session rankings of conversation content, aggregated at the mentor level using a leave-one-out procedure informed by the peer effects literature (Caeyers and Fafchamps, 2024). Specifically, after each session, students report their main takeaways from the conversation. Because students shape discussions through their questions and engagement, associations between reported content and outcomes may reflect both mentors' tendencies and endogenous interaction dynamics. To address this concern, we aggregate reports from all other mentees assigned to the same mentor, excluding the focal student, to compute mentor-level measures of topic salience. This approach minimizes reflection concerns and ensures that the mentor-type measures used in the second-stage are not mechanically correlated with individual student's assessment.

Since mentor–student pairings were randomized within treatment arms, we use the 158 mentor indicators as instruments for conversation content.

The first stage regressions are given by:

$$Info_i = \sum_j M_{ij}\gamma_{j1} + \lambda_{d(i),1} + \mu_i \tag{8}$$

$$Search_i = \sum_j M_{ij}\gamma_{j2} + \lambda_{d(i),2} + u_i \tag{9}$$

$$Enc_i = \sum_j M_{ij}\gamma_{j3} + \lambda_{d(i),3} + \tau_i \tag{10}$$

where M_{ij} is an indicator for whether student i was assigned to mentor j, and $\lambda_{d(i),k}$ denotes fixed effects for student i's dual VTI-course assignment $d(i)$ in each equation. The residuals

[35] Keeping referrals as a separate category would not affect the analysis, as referrals are extremely rare and no mentor would be classified as primarily providing referrals under any metric we use.

μ_i, u_i, and τ_i capture individual-level unobserved variation. In the second stage, $Info_i$, Enc_i, and $Search_i$ are replaced by their fitted values from the first stage.

The validity of this strategy relies on two assumptions. First, instrument relevance requires that mentor indicators be correlated with the three endogenous variables (conversation content). We formally test for weak identification using the Sanderson-Windmeijer first-stage F-statistic. As reported in Table 6, we reject the null hypothesis of weak instruments for all three endogenous regressors ($p = .00$ for all three). First-stage F-statistics are extremely high (all above 81), and well above standard thresholds for instrument strength. These high F-statistics reflect strong between-mentor variation in conversational styles combined with high within-mentor agreement: approximately 75% of mentors exhibit perfect agreement, meaning all students assigned to the same mentor consistently identify the same primary conversation focus. This pattern indicates that mentors have stable conversational types that students reliably recognize. While mentors can tailor advice to individual mentee needs, these adjustments likely occur within a persistent underlying approach. A simple variance decomposition confirms this interpretation: 70 to 80% of variation in mentor types is between mentors, with 20 to 30% within mentors. Robustness checks using simple majority-rule classification show 87% agreement with our leave-one-out method, validating that we capture genuine mentor characteristics rather than measurement noise.[36]

Second, the exclusion restriction requires that mentor assignment affect outcomes only through the three identified channels. This assumption could be violated if mentors influence outcomes through unobserved dimensions such as network quality or post-program availability. We assess the plausibility of the exclusion restriction using the overidentification test implied by having 158 instruments for three endogenous variables. The Sargan-Hansen test fails to reject the null, suggesting the instruments capture the primary dimensions of heterogeneity. Moreover, given the large number of instruments, it is sufficient for any additional channels to be uncorrelated with the fitted values in the second stage for the IV estimates to remain valid (Kolesár et al., 2015). Nonetheless, we acknowledge an important interpretive limitation: our estimates reflect the combined influence of conversational emphasis and any correlated mentor attributes, and should be understood as intention-to-treat effects of being assigned to a mentor of a given type.[37]

[36]Random assignment of students to mentors ensures that exposure to these mentor tendencies is orthogonal to students' characteristics. The leave-one-out construction ensures that the mentor-type measures used in the second stage are not mechanically correlated with any individual student's own assessment, addressing reflection concerns standard in peer effects estimation.

[37]A scripted intervention randomizing mentors into mechanism-specific conversations would have sharpened channel isolation, but would have sacrificed realism and likely reduced overall effectiveness.

We conduct a series of robustness checks to address concerns related to noise in mentor-type measurement and residual endogeneity. First, we complement student-reported measures with an independent classification based on text analysis of mentorship conversations, defining mentor types by the share of conversation devoted to each topic (Figure A.4). Using transcript-based measures yields less precise but directionally aligned results: greater emphasis on information is associated with stronger short-run treatment effects; encouragement primarily amplifies medium-run effects and modestly increases willingness to accept jobs; and greater emphasis on job search strategies is associated with weaker short-run gains. Second, we estimate models using Limited Information Maximum Likelihood as well as two jackknife IV estimators, JIVE and UJIVE (Blomquist and Dahlberg, 1999; Angrist, Imbens, and Krueger, 1999). These approaches are less sensitive to weak instruments and finite-sample bias and are particularly well suited to settings with many instruments. Results from these alternative estimators, reported in Online Appendix Table A.23, show that our key findings are robust: mentors who primarily provided entry level labor market information and encouragement were the most effective in the short run. In the medium run, encouragement plays an even greater role, reinforcing persistence and patience plays a key role in shaping longer-term outcomes. Finally, restricting the analysis to mentors with at least four mentees yields estimates that are similar in magnitude, if anything, stronger (Online Appendix Table A.24). While these cells remain small, the fact that results strengthen as measurement becomes slightly less noisy is reassuring.

5.5 Cash and the Mentoring Relationship

So far, we have shown that the cash transfer received by students in T2 was largely saved rather than immediately spent. Consistent with this, the transfer had no differential impacts on short-run labor market outcomes (Table 2). Yet medium-run trajectories diverge sharply across arms. As shown in Table 3, students assigned to mentoring only (T1) reap the one-year benefits of the program. For this group, treatment effects persist along both the participation and earnings margins: one year after graduation, they are 23% more likely to be in the labor force and earn 31% more ($p = .01$). In contrast, these effects dissipate for students in T2. This pattern is puzzling in light of the reduced-form short-run evidence: T1 and T2 exhibit very similar immediate behavioral responses, including comparable changes in reservation wages and willingness to accept work (Table 2).

To investigate the source of this divergence, we examine all observable dimensions of mentor–student interactions and students' reported takeaways. We find no meaningful differences across T1 and T2 in the frequency, timing, duration and attrition is balanced across arms. We do, however, find differences in the *content* of conversations and in what students retained. Mentor–student pairs in T2 devote relatively more time to actionable search tips, which T2 students are also more likely to report as their main takeaway, and relatively less to encouragement (Figure A.2). This evidence is consistent with the cash transfer altering the framing of the mentoring relationship. Introducing money may have shifted students' mindset about what the program was meant to deliver, shifting attention toward instrumental, transactional guidance and away from relational forms of support, such as encouragement, that appear to matter more for medium-run outcomes. In light of this evidence, a natural reconciliation is that the short-run response reflects immediate adjustments in beliefs and willingness to take available opportunities, whereas medium run gains depend on sustained persistence after initial employment (e.g., remaining engaged once in a low-paying job). In this interpretation, encouragement serves as a key input into this longer-run persistence margin. We cannot fully trace how transfers were used between endline 1 and endline 2, and thus cannot rule out alternative channels operating through later spending (e.g., short-lived self-employment attempts or changes in job search intensity). That said, the transfer was modest in size, making it less likely that direct spending effects alone account for the sharp medium-run divergence. Taken together, the content and takeaway causal evidence is consistent with the cash transfer altering the framing of the mentoring relationship and attenuating the encouragement channel. This interpretation is also in line with prior evidence that cash transfers are not psychologically neutral and can interact with relational interventions by reshaping motivation and social dynamics (see, e.g., Haushofer and Shapiro, 2016; Dercon et al., 2023; Gneezy and Rustichini, 2000; Ashraf, Field, and Lee, 2014).

Extensions To inform the optimal design of mentorship programs, we explore how characteristics of the program design affected its success. In Figure A.3 we examine heterogeneity in mentor effectiveness by analyzing variation across mentor-mentee pair characteristics. Across all main results, the observed patterns are largely consistent across subgroups, with no clear evidence that the effectiveness of mentorship varied meaningfully along most observable mentor-mentee characteristics. We also assess whether exposure to a mentor who has conducted multiple sessions differs from exposure to a mentor leading their first session. We find no significant differences in student outcomes, likely because all mentors share the same training and labor market, making their guidance relevant even without extensive prior mentoring experience. Last, we assess the impact of the number of mentees per mentor and find suggestive evidence that a mentor's effectiveness decreases with each additional mentee beyond four.

6 Scalability and Cost Effectiveness

Our goals in designing the intervention were scalability and cost-effectiveness, reflecting demand from VTIs and BRAC's Youth Empowerment Program. The program is straightforward to replicate logistically. Though most VTIs do not systematically track alumni, once a basic tracking system exists, the marginal cost of maintaining contacts is low. Mentor selection is also simple to reproduce, relying only on standard survey and administrative data available at school registration. However, while institutionalizing the intervention at the school level eliminates the need for enumerators, there remains uncertainty around how per-student costs might change at scale. Per-student costs could rise if administrators include overhead, if recruiting mentors is harder in new schools, or if the mentor-to-mentee ratio falls below 4.1, each of which pushes program costs up, even if larger treatment effects due to lower mentor-to-mentee ratios were to offset some of the increase. Following Al-Ubaydli, List, and Suskind (2019), we treat this as a potential "scale-up problem." To address the potential scale-up problem, as well as to avoid long-horizon extrapolation and instead treat persistence as an explicit parameter, we use Monte Carlo simulations to conduct a sensitivity analysis on the program's cost-effectiveness.

Costs: Per-student costs have three parts: (1) direct program costs, (2) students' opportunity costs, and (3) mentors' opportunity costs. Direct costs per mentor are about \$5 USD for a half-day training (snack, stationery, venue), \$15 USD for airtime (~ 70 hours), and \$40 USD to cover travel costs for mentors training and facilitate participation (disbursed only if mentors completed all assigned sessions). Because each mentor is matched to an average of 4.1 students, these expenses sum to roughly \$60 USD per mentor, or about \$15 USD per student. Opportunity costs are computed from baseline earnings. Students devoted on average 3.6 hours to the program; we conservatively round this to two full days. For mentors, we count the opportunity cost of time spent on interactions beyond the three mandatory sessions already covered in program costs.

Benefits: We observe labor market outcomes up to one year after graduation, which leaves the durability of treatment effects beyond this horizon uncertain. To maintain a conservative approach, we simulate benefits using estimates for the pooled treatment group, reported in Table 3, Panel A, Column 6. Notably, returns are even larger at one year when considering the mentoring-only arm, excluding the cash transfer, as shown in Panel B.

Sensitivity Analysis: In each of 10,000 simulated "mentor programs," program cost per student is drawn from $U(15, 30)$, taking \$15 USD (our observed value) as the lower bound and allowing a 100% increase as a conservative upper bound. We then add student and mentor opportunity costs to obtain total per-student costs. In each draw, opportunity costs for both students and mentors are computed by bootstrapping one observation from their respective baseline earnings distributions and converting monthly earnings into daily amounts, assuming two days for students and one for mentors. Benefits are drawn from a normal distribution with parameters from the estimated ITT on monthly earnings reported in Table 3, Panel A, Column 6. We map these gains into annual cashflows with cost at $t = 0$ and benefits in years $1, \ldots, t$: year-1 benefits grow linearly from month 3 to month 12; years $2, \ldots, t$ use full annual benefits; benefits are set to zero after the persistence horizon t.[38]

Table 7 reports the 25th, 50th, and 75th percentiles of these simulated outcomes for each $t \in \{1, 2, 5\}$. With the one-year persistence of benefits we observe, the program already breaks even in the median program (IRR = 5.2%). At the lower quartile the NPV and IRR are negative, while the upper quartile already shows material returns (IRR = 51.5%). If benefits persist 2 years, returns are substantial: IRRs range from 51.9% to 172.7%. Under a five-year persistence assumption, the IRR ranges from 95.3% to 208.4%. These results indicate that the program is highly cost-effective under plausible assumptions and would remain so even if program costs increased at scale, suggesting that mentorship is a tool capable of delivering some of the highest internal rates of return observed in settings where youth face severe labor market constraints.[39]

7 Conclusions

Across much of the Global South, large cohorts of young people enter labor markets with scarce formal jobs, high turnover, and many low-quality initial matches (Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman, 2023; Breza and Kaur, 2025). Even when returns to education and vocational training are positive, early careers are often marked by low pay, instability, and repeated rejection. At the same time, young workers tend to hold overly optimistic expectations about entry-level conditions and the speed at which returns to education materialize, making discouragement and premature disengagement salient risks at labor market entry.

This paper studies whether mentorship can mitigate these risks. In partnership with BRAC, one of the largest NGOs in the world, we design a one-on-one mentorship intervention tar-

[38] For each draw of costs and benefits at horizon t, we compute NPV as the present value of cash flows $\{CF_{s,k}\}_{k=0}^{t}$ discounted at 5%, BCR as $PV(\text{benefits})/PV(\text{costs})$, and IRR as the discount rate that sets $PV(\{CF_{s,k}\}_{k=0}^{t}) = 0$.

[39] This is based on our review of active labor market programs targeting youth in low-income countries, particularly those focused on upskilling or job search assistance. With the caveat that many studies do not report program costs or calculate internal rates of return, we are not aware of other interventions in similar settings reporting IRRs of comparable magnitude. Most training programs report IRRs in the range of 23%–35% (Adoho et al., 2014; Alfonsi et al., 2020; Blattman, Fiala, and Martinez, 2014; Chakravarty et al., 2016; Maitra and Mani, 2017), while job search assistance programs typically report IRRs between 3.4% and 9.8% (Crépon and Premand, 2024; Abebe et al., 2021).

geted explicitly at the transition from school to work, when young job seekers first confront job offers, rejections, and the possibility of discouragement. Implemented among vocational graduates in urban Uganda, the program pairs students with mentors only a few years ahead in their careers. Students are randomly assigned to receive mentorship and, conditional on treatment, randomly matched to mentors. We combine this two-stage randomization with rich survey data and over 350 hours of recorded mentor–mentee conversations to study both the effects of mentorship and which dimensions of mentor support drive labor market outcomes.

Mentorship substantially improves early labor market trajectories. Three months after graduation, mentored students are about 15 percent more likely to be working, to do so in the sector of training and 27 percent less likely to have exited the labor force. These gains translate into faster progression: within the first year, mentored students are 23 percent more likely to be promoted and stay in the same firm where they obtained their first job as well as more likely to experience job-to-job promotion and earn 18 percent more than control students.

To understand how mentorship shapes outcomes, we draw on a job search model with subjective beliefs together with survey data, detailed recordings of mentor–mentee conversations, and randomized matching of students to mentors. Taken together, these sources point to a clear pattern. The effects of mentorship do not operate through direct job placement, as mentors provide neither vacancies nor referrals, nor through improvements in job search technology: treated students do not search more intensively, broaden their search, or adopt different or more effective search strategies. Instead, mentorship reshapes how young workers interpret early opportunities and setbacks. Mentors provide credible information about entry-level labor market conditions and sustained encouragement, which leads students to lower reservation wages, reject fewer job offers, and accept low-paid or unpaid entry jobs as stepping-stones rather than remaining unemployed or disengaging.

These insights are reinforced by the cash-transfer arm of the experiment. Medium-run impacts are strongest among students who receive mentorship alone, with larger gains along both the labor force participation and earnings margins. Evidence from mentoring interactions suggests that the cash transfer shifts mentoring relationships away from encouragement and toward more transactional guidance, crowding out the relational support that appears central to persistence.

These findings are particularly relevant in the African context. The continent is home to roughly one-fifth of the world's first-time job seekers, and youth unemployment and underemployment rates remain extremely high (United Nations, 2019; Bandiera et al., 2022). Early labor market churn is costly not only for workers, but also for small and medium-firms, which form the backbone of African economies and face high costs from rapid worker turnover. At the same time, information about labor market functioning is limited, making it difficult for young workers to form accurate beliefs about early career trade-offs. Our results show that mentorship can partially bridge this gap by providing credible, experience-based guidance.

From a policy perspective, mentorship offers a cost-effective and scalable complement to existing investments in skills and vocational training. The program relies on near-peer mentors rather than individuals at the top of the labor market hierarchy, expanding the pool of potential mentors and reducing implementation costs. It does not require monitoring, sanctions, or advanced technology, and can be embedded within educational institutions at the point of graduation. By helping young workers stay engaged long enough for returns to education to materialize, mentorship amplifies the effectiveness of upskilling programs.

More broadly, the findings point to a general principle for labor market interventions targeting young workers. Correcting overly optimistic expectations is often necessary, but doing so without sustaining motivation can backfire. Interventions that combine realism with credible reassurance about longer-run progress can help workers navigate early setbacks without disengaging.

Main Tables

Table 1: Baseline Balance on Students' Characteristics and Labor Market Outcomes

Variable	N	(1) Control Mean/(SE)	N	(2) MYF Mean/(SE)	N	(3) MYF+Cash Mean/(SE)	(1)-(2) P-value	(1)-(3) P-value	(2)-(3) P-value
							Pairwise t-test		
Panel A: Socio-economic characteristics									
Age in 2020	466	20.309	320	20.304	325	20.260	.972	.737	.785
		(.093)		(.114)		(.112)			
Gender (1=M)	466	.590	320	.600	325	.591	.782	.986	.812
		(.023)		(.027)		(.027)			
Christian	466	.828	320	.850	325	.828	.415	.981	.442
		(.017)		(.020)		(.021)			
Single	462	.905	318	.893	324	.880	.597	.268	.592
		(.014)		(.017)		(.018)			
Has Children	466	.024	320	.028	325	.018	.698	.617	.417
		(.007)		(.009)		(.007)			
Region of Origin: Central	464	.297	319	.342	324	.302	.194	.879	.288
		(.021)		(.027)		(.026)			
Region of Origin: Eastern	464	.539	319	.508	324	.519	.395	.575	.787
		(.023)		(.028)		(.028)			
HH Assets Index Above Mean	458	.421	319	.398	324	.349	.517	.039**	.196
		(.023)		(.027)		(.027)			
HH Main Income Source Agriculture	464	.474	320	.463	325	.468	.749	.859	.895
		(.023)		(.028)		(.028)			
Panel B: Labor market history pre MYF									
Ever Worked Pre MYF	466	.528	320	.544	325	.526	.662	.962	.655
		(.023)		(.028)		(.028)			
Ever Worked in Training Sector	441	.070	302	.089	312	.080	.351	.617	.681
		(.012)		(.016)		(.015)			
Has Done Any Casual Work	464	.256	320	.259	325	.237	.927	.530	.510
		(.020)		(.025)		(.024)			
Has Done Any Wage Employment	464	.293	320	.306	325	.298	.694	.871	.830
		(.021)		(.026)		(.025)			
Has Done Any Self Employment	464	.078	320	.075	325	.095	.893	.386	.354
		(.012)		(.015)		(.016)			

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: The table reports means with standard errors in parentheses for the Control and Treatment groups. The last columns shows the robust p-value for the t-test of equality of means between the two groups. Data is from the baseline and midline surveys to students, which we use to build updated measures of work experience accumulated before the roll-out of the MYF program. We classified as casual the following occupations: agricultural day labor; (un)loading trucks; transporting goods on bicycle; fetching water; land fencing; slashing someone's compound; and all occupations in which neither principal nor agent held any contractual obligations toward the other, and the principal requested the agent on a need-based basis.

Table 2: Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Short Run								Index
	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment									
MYF Treatment Assignment	.036	1.267**	.094***	-.057***	1.700	1.216	.081***	19.227***	.150***
	(.022)	(.540)	(.025)	(.019)	(2.176)	(2.677)	(.026)	(4.872)	(.050)
	[.047]	[.017]	[.003]	[.007]	[.155]	[.170]	[.007]	[.003]	[.007]
Panel B — By Treatment Arm									
T1 (MYF)	.055**	1.544**	.086**	-.049**	2.617	1.933	.081**	18.374***	.162**
	(.025)	(.647)	(.034)	(.022)	(2.637)	(3.254)	(.037)	(6.686)	(.066)
	[.052]	[.052]	[.052]	[.052]	[.090]	[.141]	[.052]	[.052]	[.052]
T2 (MYF+Cash)	.018	1.004	.102***	-.064**	.824	.510	.082***	20.042***	.139**
	(.024)	(.628)	(.027)	(.025)	(2.517)	(2.938)	(.025)	(7.187)	(.055)
	[.241]	[.086]	[.004]	[.023]	[.388]	[.404]	[.011]	[.020]	[.023]
Control Mean	.82	16.15	.62	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934
Pooled Effects (%)	4.37	7.85	15.14	-26.57	14.15	8.34	15.11	24.63	-
T1 Effects (%)	6.61	9.56	13.77	-22.90	21.78	13.25	15.00	23.53	-
T2 Effects (%)	2.24	6.22	16.43	-30.04	6.86	3.50	15.22	25.67	-
T1=T2	.15	.43	.63	.59	.52	.65	.97	.87	.75

Notes: ITT estimates of MYF effects on short-run labor market outcomes from Equation 1. Clustered standard errors (strata) in parentheses; q-values in brackets (Benjamini, Krieger, and Yekutieli, 2006). Panel A: pooled effects. Panel B: arm-specific effects (T1, T2); last row shows equality test p-value. Bottom rows: control mean and treatment effects as percent of control mean. Controls include strata dummies and pre-intervention employment. Dependent variables: Column 1 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual worked in the previous month. Column 2 is the number of days worked in the previous month. Column 3 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual reports working in the past 7 days. Column 4 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual is out of the labor force (either entirely inactive or engaged in subsistence farming). Column 5 is total earnings in the previous month. Column 6 is total earnings in the previous month conditional on being employed in the previous month. The top and bottom 1% of earnings values are top-coded at the 99th and 1st percentiles, respectively. All monetary variables are converted into February 2022 USD. Column 7 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual is employed in their sector of training. Column 8 is the duration (in days) of the first job spell after graduation. The Short Run Index in Column 9 is a standardized index of the outcomes in Columns 2, 4, 5, and 7, following Anderson (2008), and accounting for the covariance structure of the components. Statistical significance throughout the paper is indicated by *, **, and *** for p-values of .10, .05, and .01, respectively.

Table 3: Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Transitions		**Medium Run**					**Index**
	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Out of the Labor Force (5)	Earnings Last Month (6)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (7)	Career Trajectory Index (8)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment								
MYF Treatment Assignment	.041**	.076**	.006	.265	-.025	5.889*	8.382*	.135**
	(.019)	(.033)	(.037)	(.925)	(.022)	(3.456)	(4.340)	(.057)
	[.121]	[.121]	[.479]	[.479]	[.183]	[.121]	[.121]	[.121]
Panel B — By Treatment Arm								
T1 (MYF)	.059**	.114**	.028	1.146	-.059*	10.379**	14.336***	.256***
	(.024)	(.042)	(.043)	(1.132)	(.030)	(4.010)	(4.189)	(.074)
	[.025]	[.021]	[.152]	[.100]	[.034]	[.021]	[.006]	[.006]
T2 (MYF+Cash)	.025	.041	-.013	-.523	.006	1.871	2.801	.028
	(.025)	(.042)	(.043)	(1.034)	(.031)	(3.647)	(5.522)	(.071)
	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]	[1.000]
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
N	934	934	923	923	923	916	512	844
Pooled Effects (%)	22.87	20.70	1.15	2.12	-9.53	17.59	13.90	-
T1 Effects (%)	32.69	30.93	4.97	9.17	-22.79	31.00	23.77	-
T2 Effects (%)	13.57	11.01	-2.26	-4.18	2.32	5.59	4.65	-
T1=T2	.28	.15	.38	.15	.13	.02	.02	.02

Notes: ITT estimates of MYF effects on medium-run labor market dynamics from Equation 1. Clustered standard errors (strata) in parentheses; q-values in brackets (Benjamini, Krieger, and Yekutieli, 2006). Panel A: pooled effects. Panel B: arm-specific effects (T1, T2); last row shows equality test p-value. Dependent variables: Column 1 is an indicator equal to 1 if the respondent was retained after a trial period (students were typically hired as trainees in their first job after graduation). Column 2 is an indicator equal to 1 if the respondent transitioned from being an intern/trainee to being a worker not in training within one year from graduation. Column 3 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual worked in the previous month. Column 4 is the number of days worked in the previous month. Column 5 is an indicator equal to 1 if the individual is out of the labor force. Column 6 is total earnings in the previous month. Column 7 is total earnings in the previous month conditional on being employed in the previous month. The top and bottom 1% of earnings values are top-coded at the 99th and 1st percentiles, respectively. All monetary variables are converted into February 2022 USD. The Career Trajectory Index in Column 8 is a standardized index of the five outcomes in Columns 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6, following Anderson (2008), and accounting for the covariance structure of the components. Statistical significance throughout the paper is indicated by *, **, and *** for p-values of .10, .05, and .01, respectively.

Table 4: Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Willingness to Accept a Job			**Job Search**				**Search Duration**	**Indexes**	
	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment										
MYF Treatment Assignment	-11.410***	.073**	-.040*	.029**	-.009	.002	-.086	-8.289**	-.029	.277***
	(3.307)	(.031)	(.021)	(.014)	(.068)	(.065)	(.078)	(3.930)	(.076)	(.080)
	[.007]	[.064]	[.082]	[.082]	[.644]	[.644]	[.188]	[.082]	[.545]	[.007]
Panel B — By Treatment Arm										
T1 (MYF)	-13.218***	.079**	-.011	.031*	.008	-.075	-.062	-10.778**	-.041	.252**
	(3.828)	(.037)	(.024)	(.016)	(.080)	(.069)	(.090)	(4.550)	(.090)	(.097)
	[.014]	[.083]	[.568]	[.083]	[.860]	[.306]	[.550]	[.072]	[.568]	[.065]
T2 (MYF+Cash)	-9.597***	.066*	-.067**	.027	-.024	.075	-.109	-5.928	-.017	.302***
	(3.535)	(.038)	(.027)	(.016)	(.077)	(.081)	(.075)	(4.137)	(.072)	(.077)
	[.047]	[.173]	[.055]	[.173]	[.324]	[.291]	[.191]	[.191]	[.324]	[.004]
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668
Pooled Effects (%)	-31.50	13.40	-23.23	3.10	-	-	-	-29.89	-	-
T1 Effects (%)	-36.50	14.53	-6.38	3.37	-	-	-	-38.87	-	-
T2 Effects (%)	-26.50	12.26	-39.18	2.86	-	-	-	-21.38	-	-
T1=T2	.27	.78	.07	.74	.69	.06	.40	.20	.68	.48

Notes: ITT estimates of MYF effects on job acceptance willingness and job search outcomes from Equation 1. Clustered standard errors (strata) in parentheses; q-values in brackets (Benjamini, Krieger, and Yekutieli, 2006). Panel A: pooled effects. Panel B: arm-specific effects (T1, T2); last row shows equality test p-value. Dependent variables: Column 1 is the lowest wage the respondent is willing to accept. Column 2 is a self-reported indicator for willingness to accept an unpaid job. Column 3 is an indicator equal to 1 if the respondent ever rejected a job offer during their first job search spell after graduation. Column 4 is an indicator equal to 1 if the respondent started job search following graduation. Column 5 reports the Search Effectiveness Index, a standardized index of (i) the ratio of interviews to applications, (ii) the ratio of offers received to applications submitted, and (iii) the number of CVs submitted during search. Column 6 reports the Search Broadness Index, a standardized index of (i) the number of search methods used, (ii) the number of fundraise methods used, (iii) the geographic scope of search (measured travel time), and (iv) the number of sectors in which the respondent searched. Column 7 reports the Search Intensity Index, a standardized index of (i) hours per day searching, (ii) days per week searching, (iii) the number of applications submitted, and (iv) money devoted to job search. Column 8 is the length (in days) of the first job search spell after graduation, conditional on having started a search. Column 9 reports the Search Behavior Index, a standardized index of the outcomes in Columns 4–7. Column 10 reports the Willingness to Accept a Job Index, a standardized index of the outcomes in Columns 1–3. All indices follow Anderson (2008) and account for the covariance structure of the components. Statistical significance throughout the paper is indicated by *, **, and *** for p-values of .10, .05, and .01, respectively.

Table 5: Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Earnings Expectations						Satisfaction with School-to-Work Transition	
	Unconditional			Conditional on Working				
	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (4)	Amount Overestimated (5)	Any Overestimate (6)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment								
MYF Treatment Assignment	-11.432	-15.992*	-.064***	-21.674*	-41.020**	-.100**	-.008	.007
	(7.347)	(9.199)	(.022)	(10.726)	(15.776)	(.045)	(.137)	(.140)
	[.113]	[.099]	[.044]	[.082]	[.049]	[.067]	[.316]	[.316]
Panel B — By Treatment Arm								
T1 (MYF)	-17.899**	-29.691**	-.081***	-30.174***	-60.432***	-.127**	.011	.164
	(7.869)	(11.202)	(.027)	(10.830)	(16.591)	(.052)	(.185)	(.172)
	[.024]	[.018]	[.016]	[.018]	[.007]	[.023]	[.314]	[.111]
T2 (MYF+Cash)	-5.326	-3.914	-.050*	-14.016	-23.034	-.076	-.026	-.133
	(8.617)	(10.091)	(.026)	(11.806)	(17.383)	(.048)	(.162)	(.150)
	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]	[.943]
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	157.27	100.64	.88	6.22	6.19
N	927	832	832	628	370	370	934	921
Pooled Effects (%)	-7.82	-14.20	-6.84	-13.78	-40.76	-11.34	-.13	.11
T1 Effects (%)	-12.24	-26.36	-8.59	-19.19	-60.05	-14.31	.17	2.64
T2 Effects (%)	-3.64	-3.48	-5.29	-8.91	-22.89	-8.59	-.42	-2.14
T1=T2	.10	.02	.30	.03	.00	.24	.86	.07

Notes: ITT estimates of MYF effects on earnings expectations, accuracy, and satisfaction from Equation 1. Clustered standard errors (strata) in parentheses; q-values in brackets. Panel A: pooled effects. Panel B: arm-specific effects (T1, T2); last row shows equality test p-value. Sample sizes vary because accuracy measures require both EL1 (3 months) and EL2 (1 year) data, and some outcomes condition on EL1 employment. Base sample: 934 EL1 respondents. Column 1 uses those with non-missing expected earnings ($N = 927$). Columns 2–3 measure expectation accuracy and therefore restrict to respondents with non-missing expectations at EL1 who were also interviewed at EL2, yielding $N = 832$ (a subset of the 844 jointly interviewed in both rounds). Columns 4–6 condition on working at EL1: Column 4 uses EL1 respondents who report currently working and have non-missing expectations ($N = 628$); Columns 5–6 further restrict to those also interviewed at EL2, yielding $N = 370$. Satisfaction at three months and one year is measured on a 0-10 scale.

Table 6: Treatment Effects by Mentor Types

	Mechanisms		Labor Market Outcomes	
	Search Behavior Index (1)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (2)	Short Run Index (3)	Career Trajectory Index (4)
Panel A — 2SLS				
Entry Conditions	-.09	.59***	.23***	.08
	(.10)	(.09)	(.08)	(.10)
Encouragement	-.04	.27***	.20***	.21***
	(.07)	(.09)	(.06)	(.07)
Search Tips	.05	.02	-.02	-.00
	(.13)	(.14)	(.08)	(.10)
Control Mean	.00	-.00	-.00	.00
N Mentors	158	158	158	157
N	934	668	934	844
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.67	.00	.00	.01
AP Partial F (pval)- Entry Conditions	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Encouragement	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Search Tips	.00	.00	.00	.00
Overidentification test (pval)	.51	.64	.42	.40
Panel B — OLS				
Entry Conditions	-.07	.42***	.19**	.09
	(.10)	(.08)	(.08)	(.09)
Encouragement	-.03	.28***	.20***	.17***
	(.07)	(.09)	(.06)	(.06)
Search Tips	.03	.15	-.02	.01
	(.12)	(.13)	(.08)	(.09)
N	934	668	934	844
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.83	.00	.02	.04

Notes: Panel A of the table presents the 2SLS estimates of the effect of mentor types based on the predominant form of support the students received from them: Entry Conditions, Encouragement, or Search Tips. The estimates are reported for our four key outcome indexes: (1) Search Behavior Index, (2) Willingness to Accept Job Index, (3) Short-Run Labor Market Outcomes Index, and (4) Career Trajectory Index. In the top panel, the coefficients represent the estimated effects, with standard errors reported in parentheses. These are obtained by estimating the second-stage equation on our four main indexes. The panel at the bottom reports control means and sample sizes, including the number of mentors (which is also the number of instruments) and total observations for each index, which vary as data are collected across waves. For certain variables, observations are required to be present in both waves. Joint significance tests and first-stage F-tests are included to verify instrument strength, while Hansen's test assesses instrument validity. Panel B of the table presents the OLS estimates of the effect of mentor types.

Table 7: Cost-effectiveness by Treatment Effect Persistence t

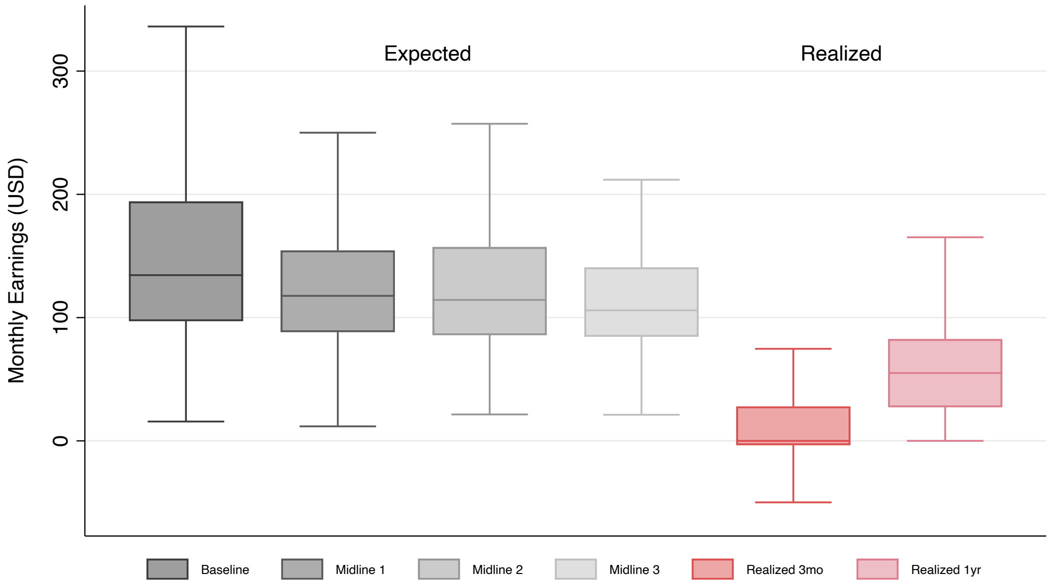
	Percentile of Simulated Outcomes		
	25th	50th	75th
Persistence $t = 1$ (ramp only; zero after year 1)			
NPV (USD, 5%)	-12.84	.06	12.75
BCR	.59	1.00	1.44
IRR (%)	-29.42	5.21	51.53
Persistence $t = 2$ (ramp + full year 2)			
NPV (USD, 5%)	26.04	63.71	101.29
BCR	1.83	3.08	4.44
IRR (%)	51.92	112.99	172.74
Persistence $t = 5$ (ramp + full years 2–5)			
NPV (USD, 5%)	132.92	238.63	343.18
BCR	5.19	8.75	12.61
IRR (%)	95.31	152.25	208.41

Notes: This table reports a sensitivity analysis of program cost-effectiveness using 10,000 Monte Carlo draws. In each draw, the ITT on monthly earnings is sampled from the estimated coefficient and standard error (see Panel A, Column 6 of Table 3). Program benefits are then mapped into an annual cashflow with costs in year 0, ramped gains in year 1 (months 3–12), and full gains in years $2, \ldots, t$; benefits are set to zero after the persistence horizon t. Program costs are drawn from U(15,30) USD per student, and student (2 days) and alum (1 day) opportunity costs are bootstrapped from the observed data. Net present value (NPV) discounts annual cashflows at 5% per year. The benefit-to-cost ratio (BCR) is PV(benefits)/PV(costs), with costs incurred at $t = 0$ and benefits accruing in years $1, \ldots, t$. The internal rate of return (IRR) is the discount rate that sets the present value of the same cashflow stream to zero. Reported entries are the 25th, 50th, and 75th percentiles across simulations.

Main Figures

Figure 1: Overoptimism

Panel A: Expected and Realized Conditional Monthly Earnings



Panel B: Expected and Realized Job Ladders

1 YEAR \ 3 MONTHS	Expected: Paid	Expected: Unpaid	Expected: Unemp	Realized: Paid	Realized: Unpaid	Realized: Unemp
Paid	55%	46%	45%	62%	54%	15%
Unpaid	20%	25%	35%	3%	6%	3%
Unemp	25%	29%	20%	36%	39%	82%

Notes: Panel A shows expected and realized monthly earnings conditional on employment, in the control group. In the first four box-and-whisker plots, students' expected monthly earnings at their first job are shown for all four pre-intervention data points. The fifth and sixth plots represent students' realized monthly earnings at their first job and one year after graduation. Data comes from the control group. Each plot shows the median and the interquartile range (25th and 75th percentiles). Whiskers extend to the lower and upper adjacent values, defined as the most extreme observations within 1.5 times the interquartile range. Expected monthly earnings are calculated by taking the reported likelihood that earnings exceed the midpoint of the minimum and maximum, and fitting a triangular distribution, following Alfonsi et al. (2020). Panel B shows the expected and realized transition matrix from the three-month to the 1-year employment status at one year. The unpaid category comprises of workers paying for work (negative wage). The matrix on the left contains information about the expected transition shares. These were collected from a comparable sample of first and second-year students from a later cohort, surveyed specifically to elicit these expectations. The one on the right contains the realized shares as computed in the control group of our main sample.

Figure 2: Study Timeline

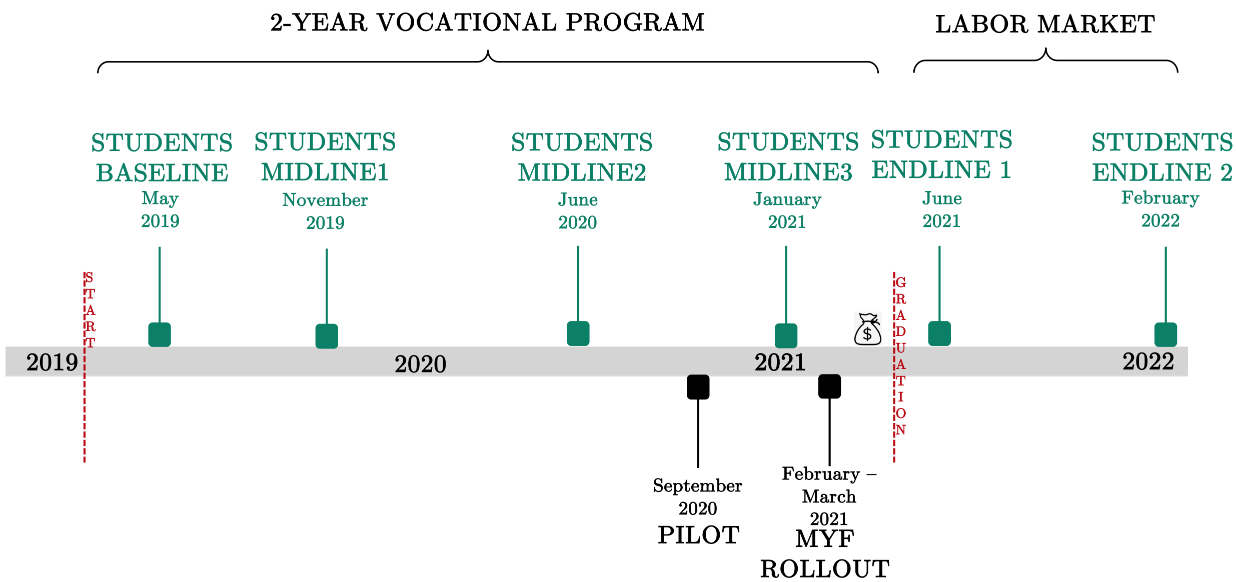


Figure 3: Experimental Design

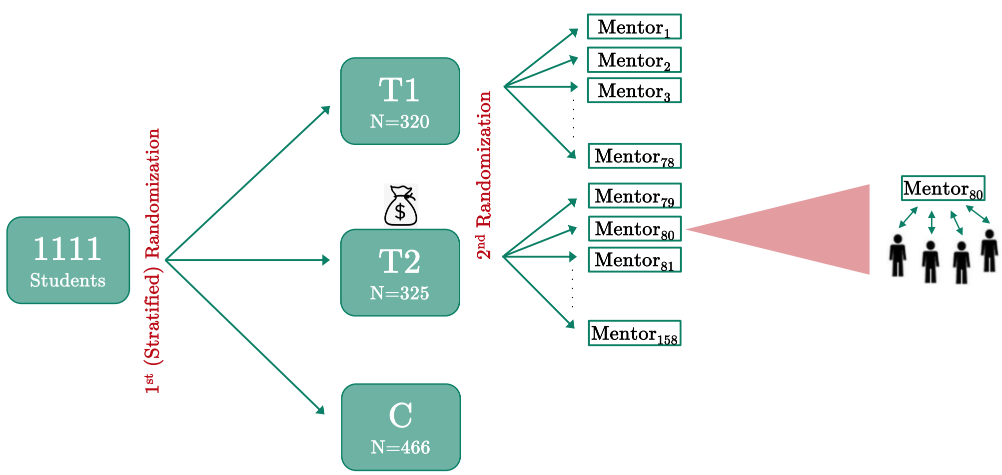
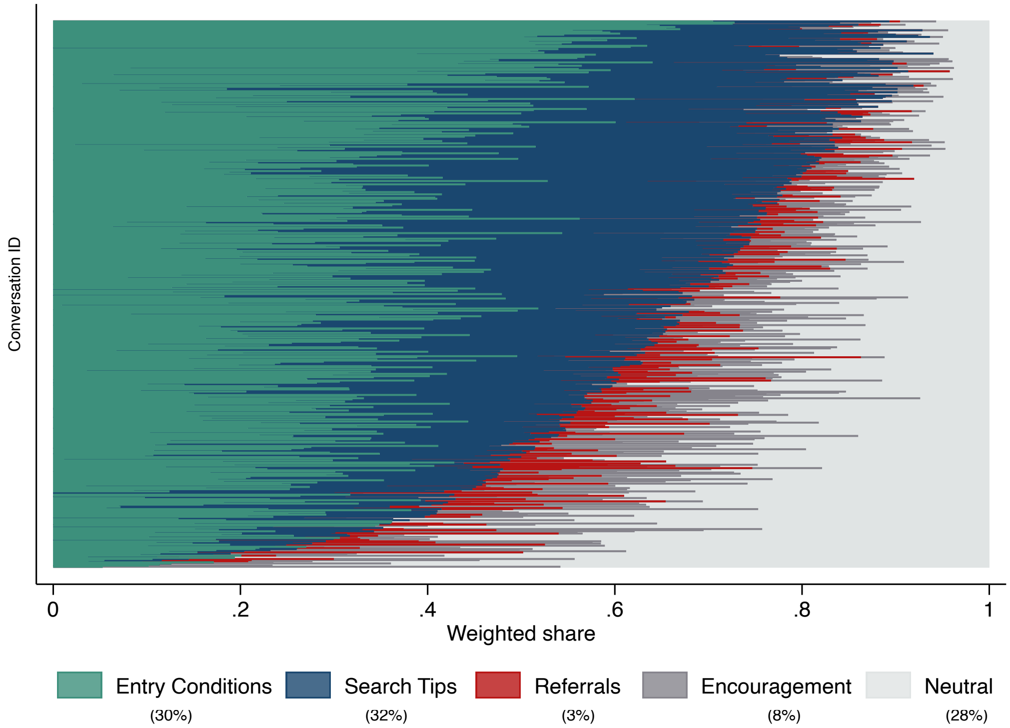
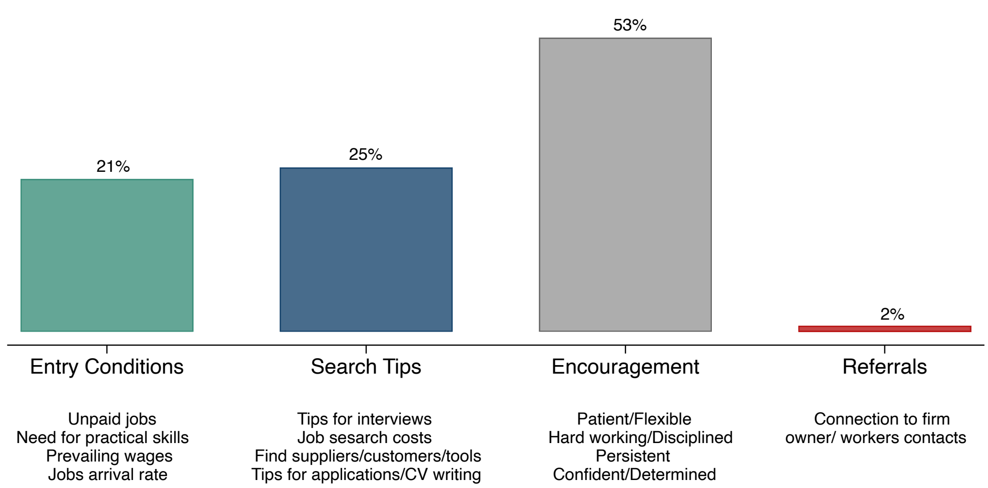


Figure 4: Conversations' Content and Takeaways

Panel A: Coded Conversation Content From Audio Recordings



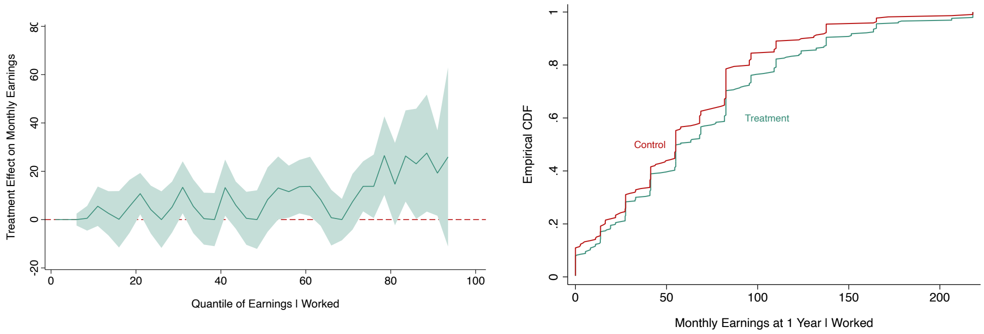
Panel B: Students' Main Takeaway



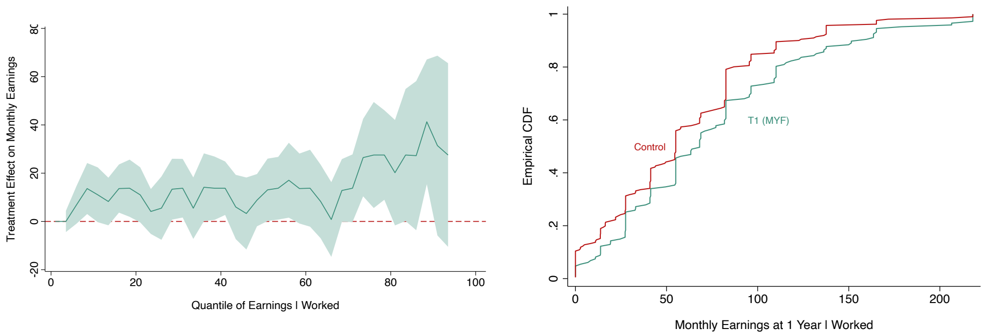
Notes: Panel A shows the raw conversation data from MS1: each observation represents a conversation, with sentences weighted by word count. Panel B displays the distribution of students' main takeaways from their mentor conversations. Each bar indicates the percentage of students whose takeaway falls into each macro-topic, with the most common micro-topic listed below.

Figure 5: Treatment Effects on Conditional Monthly Earnings at 1 Year

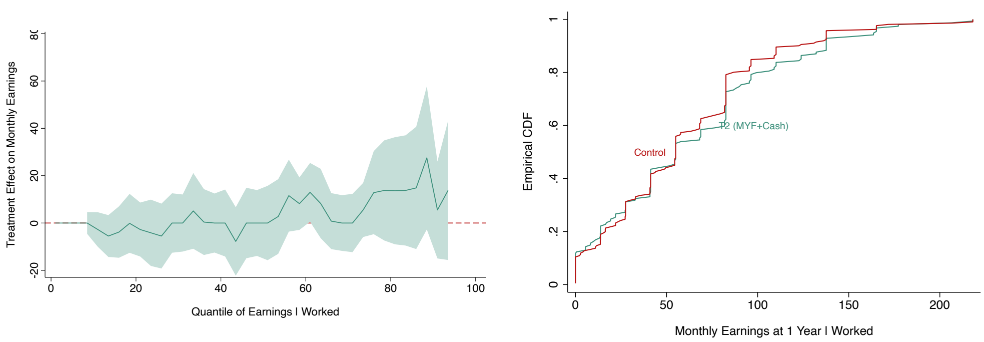
Panel A: Pooled Treatment



Panel B: MYF Only (T1)



Panel C: MYF+Cash (T2)



Notes: This figure shows quantile treatment effects (QTEs) and empirical cumulative distribution functions (CDFs) of monthly earnings at one year, conditional on working. Panel A compares the pooled treatment group (MYF and MYF+Cash combined) versus control. Panel B compares MYF Only (T1) versus control. Panel C compares MYF+Cash (T2) versus control. Earnings are converted into February 2022 USD. QTE estimates show treatment effects at each quantile of the earnings distribution with 90% confidence intervals, estimated without controlling for covariates or stratum fixed effects.

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Appendix Tables and Figures

Table A.1: Strength of the Mentor-Mentee Connection

	Ever Connected (1)		Connected More Than Once (2)		Strong Link (3)	
Panel A - Dyad has same:						
Tribe	-.14	(-.43)	-.12	(-.38)	-.24	(-1.36)
Language	-.53	(-1.62)	-.04	(-.11)	-.31	(-1.38)
District of origin	.04	(.14)	.20	(.68)	.37**	(2.01)
VTI	.74*	(1.86)	.66*	(1.85)	.35	(1.46)
Gender	-.73	(-1.53)	-.48	(-.95)	-.09	(-.36)
Panel B - Sum of:						
Age	.04	(.90)	.06*	(1.65)	.03	(1.09)
Household Asset Index	-.19**	(-2.03)	-.09	(-.98)	-.05	(-.77)
Panel C - Difference in:						
Age	-.06	(-1.22)	-.06	(-1.22)	-.05*	(-1.68)
Household Asset Index	-.15	(-.91)	.14	(.86)	-.08	(-.77)
Observations	578		577		578	

Notes: Estimates from $SL_{ij} = \beta_0 + \beta_1|z_i - z_j| + \beta_2(z_i + z_j) + \gamma|w_{ij}| + u_j$, where SL_{ij} indicates a strong link between student i and mentor j, and z denotes characteristics. β_1 measures effects of attribute differences; β_2 measures effects of combined attribute levels. Panel A reports γ coefficients on dyad-similarity indicators (w_{ij}). Panels B and C report β_1 and β_2 for continuous characteristics. Mentor level clustered SE.

Table A.2: Decomposition of the Effects of MYF on Pathways to Employment

	Unemp ↓ Unemp (1)	Unpaid ↓ Unemp (2)	Unpaid ↓ Paid (3)	Paid ↓ Unemp (4)	Paid ↓ Paid (5)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment					
MYF Treatment Assignment	-.023	-.024	.059*	.005	.015
	(.016)	(.030)	(.032)	(.024)	(.029)
Panel B — By Treatment Arm					
T1 (MYF)	-.028	-.052	.111***	.007	.019
	(.018)	(.045)	(.041)	(.026)	(.032)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	-.018	.001	.013	.003	.012
	(.016)	(.032)	(.034)	(.027)	(.030)
Control Mean	.07	.25	.25	.13	.22
N	844	844	844	844	844
Pooled Effects (%)	-31.15	-9.69	23.19	3.84	7.02
T1 Effects (%)	-38.58	-21.10	43.62	5.21	8.86
T2 Effects (%)	-24.58	.39	5.14	2.63	5.40
T1=T2	.53	.27	.00	.90	.81

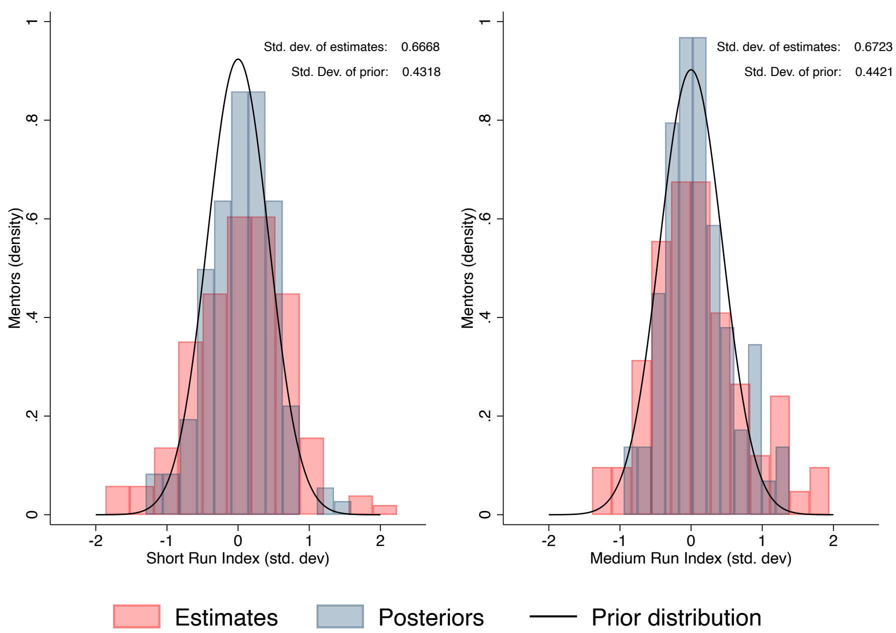
Notes: Reduced-form estimates of MYF effects on pathways to employment in the first year after graduation. Each pathway combines labor market status at three months and one year: unemployed, working for zero/negative wage, or working for positive wage. Only pathways with 5%+ of students are shown; unreported pathways show null effects. Standard errors clustered at the strata level in parentheses.

Table A.3: Savings Behavior

	Savings		
	Savings Baseline (1)	Savings Short Run (2)	Savings Medium Run (3)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment			
MYF Treatment Assignment	.011	.028	-.018
	(.029)	(.032)	(.033)
Panel B — By Treatment Arm			
T1 (MYF)	-.001	-.023	-.004
	(.035)	(.039)	(.041)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	.023	.076**	-.030
	(.035)	(.039)	(.039)
Control Mean	.35	.41	.50
N	1055	934	922
Pooled Effects (%)	3.13	6.82	-3.48
T1 Effects (%)	-.30	-5.64	-.71
T2 Effects (%)	6.46	18.61	-5.95
T1=T2	.54	.02	.54

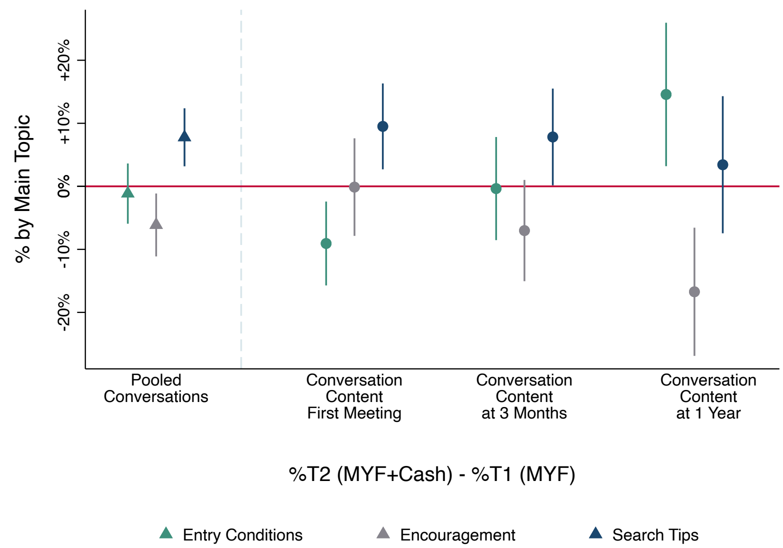
Notes: Intent-to-treat estimates of MYF effects on savings behavior at baseline, short run (EL1), and medium run (EL2) from Equation 1. Panel A: pooled effects (MYF vs. control). Panel B: arm-specific effects (T1 vs. control; T2 vs. control); last row shows p-value for equality test. Dependent variables are binary. Clustered standard errors (strata level) in parentheses.

Figure A.1: Reduced Form Estimates: Biased and Unbiased Mentors Fixed Effects



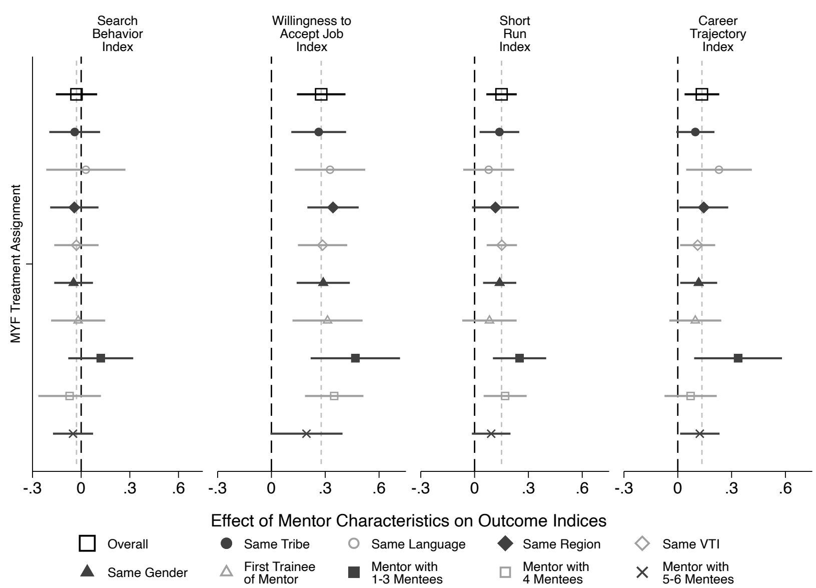
Notes: This figure reports biased (estimates) and unbiased (shrunk posteriors) distributions of the mentors fixed effects. Overlayed the prior distribution, a normal centered on zero with bias-corrected sd.

Figure A.2: Conversation Content by Topic and Treatment Arm Over Time



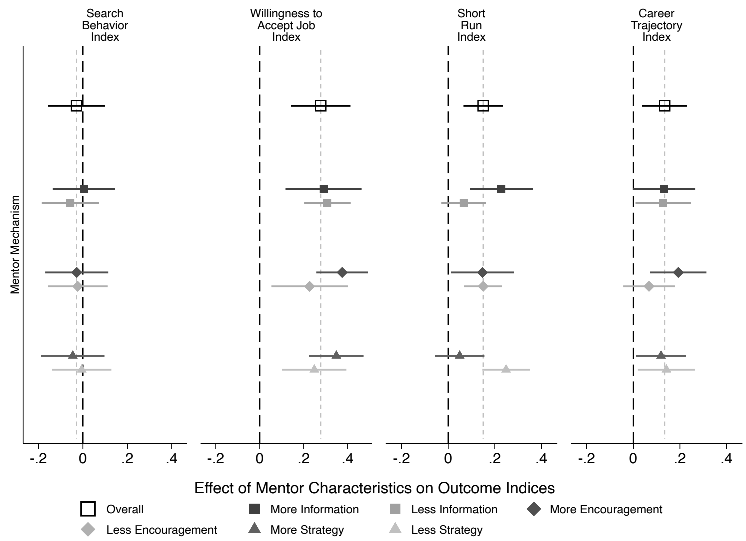
Notes: This figure reports the difference and confidence intervals in shares of conversations by main students' takeaways in MYF only (T1) and students in MYF+Cash (T2) both pooled and by mentoring session.

Figure A.3: Heterogeneity in Treatment Effect by Dyad Characteristics



Notes: This figure reports heterogeneous treatment effects on four main outcome indexes by mentor–mentee dyad characteristics. Dots show point estimates with 90 percent confidence intervals (standard errors clustered at the strata level). The black square shows the overall treatment effect. Rows two to six show effects by shared characteristics (tribe, language, region, VTI, gender). Row seven shows effects for mentors' first mentees. The last three rows show effects by mentor caseload (1–3, 4, and 5+ mentees).

Figure A.4: Treatment Effects by Mentor Conversation Topics



Notes: This figure plots treatment-effect estimates on four type based on text analysis of mentorship conversations. Dots show point estimates; bars show 90 percent confidence intervals (clustered standard errors). Black square: overall effect. Remaining points: effects split by mentor type (above/below median in Information, Encouragement, and Strategy topic shares from text-based measures).

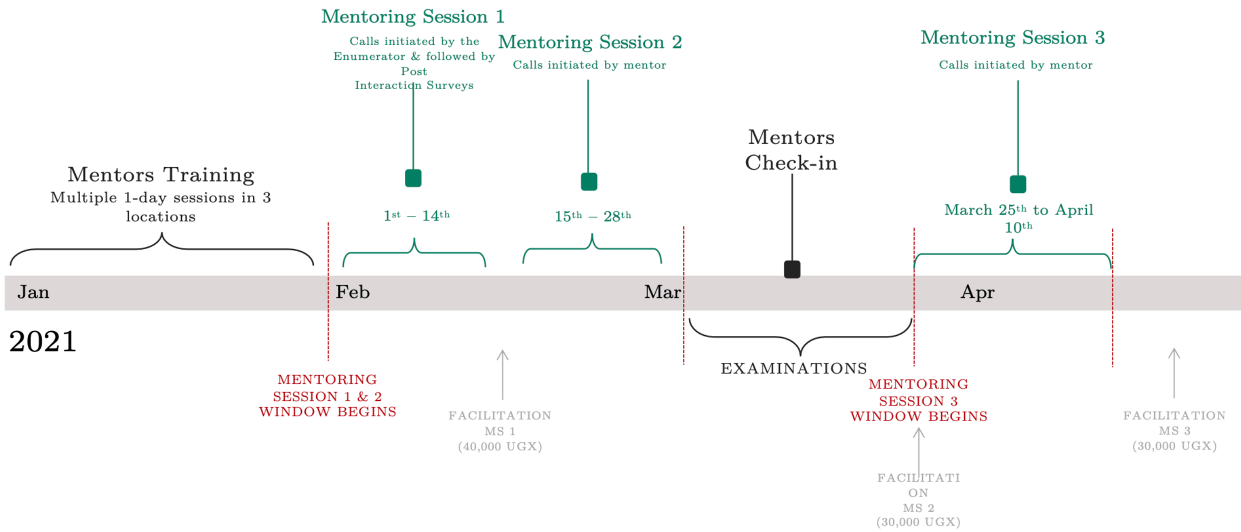
Meet Your Future: Experimental Evidence on the Labor Market Effects of Mentors

Material for Online Appendix

Contents

A Program Details

Figure A.5: The MYF Program in Detail



The mentor training sessions were one day in-person events carried out by the research team. During the training mentors were explained the structure and admin of the program as described in Online Appendix Figure A.5. They were also given logbooks and instructed on how to fill them. During the Mentors' Check-in (two-thirds of the way through the program), we collected data on the content and duration of each mentorship session as well as information on additional interactions (whether they took place, who initiated them, duration, mode and content).

Mentors were selected among alumni of the Vocational Institutes we partnered with. Like most similar institutes, such VTIs do not systematically store former students' contacts. For that reason, we collected and digitized alumni contacts available in the VTIs' registries. Of the 1,368 alumni for whom we found a registry entry, we successfully contacted and surveyed 714. We consider the tracking rate of 52% a success: the quality of the contact information collected by the VTIs is generally poor and outdated. Additionally, due to the written nature and manual entry of the records, the digitization process was not only prone to error, but much of the data was not recent as telephone SIM cards were required to be registered in 2016. This prompted many Ugandans to change their phone numbers. To select the mentors we defined a set of rules to ensure the overall quality of the mentorship as well as to ensure replicability. After excluding alumni that did not provide their availability to participate as well as those with no work experience in the occupation of training, we assigned a score to a set of relevant characteristics:

- Accessibility: indicator for whether the alum has smartphone.
- General labor market indicators: indicator for having graduated between 2014 and 2018; indicator for below median longest unemployment spell; indicator for above median earnings at first job; indicator for whether first job was in sector of training; indicator for being currently employed; indicator for above median earnings at current job; indicator for whether current job in is sector of training.
- Education: indicator for having graduated with honors.
- Soft Skills: self-reported ability to generate enthusiasm and shyness.

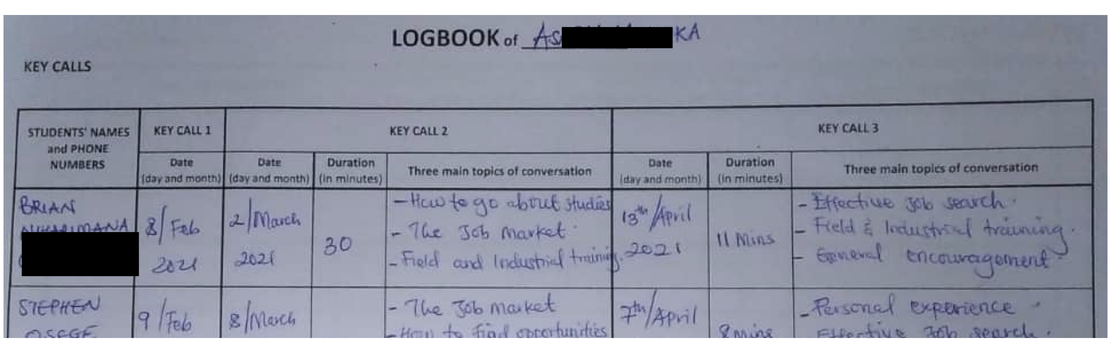
We rank alumni based on their total score. We select the N highest ranked alumni for each VTI-training area combination, where N is a function of the number of treated students in each VTI-training area. When we have fewer alumni than needed, we select the highest ranked alumni graduated from the training areas in question from other VTIs. After the selection, we end up with a sample of 171 mentors. Each mentor is assigned one to five treated students at random. Each mentor is assigned students belonging to the same treatment arm. When forming groups, we maximize the number of groups with three, four, or five students per mentor and prioritize assigning students to mentors from the same VTI (and otherwise the nearest VTI)..

Figure A.6: Mentors' Logbooks

LOGBOOK of __________

KEY CALLS

STUDENTS' NAMES and PHONE NUMBERS	KEY CALL 1	KEY CALL 2			KEY CALL 3		
	Date (day and month)	Date (day and month)	Duration (in minutes)	Three main topics of conversation	Date (day and month)	Duration (in minutes)	Three main topics of conversation



LOGBOOK of AS[redacted]KA

KEY CALLS

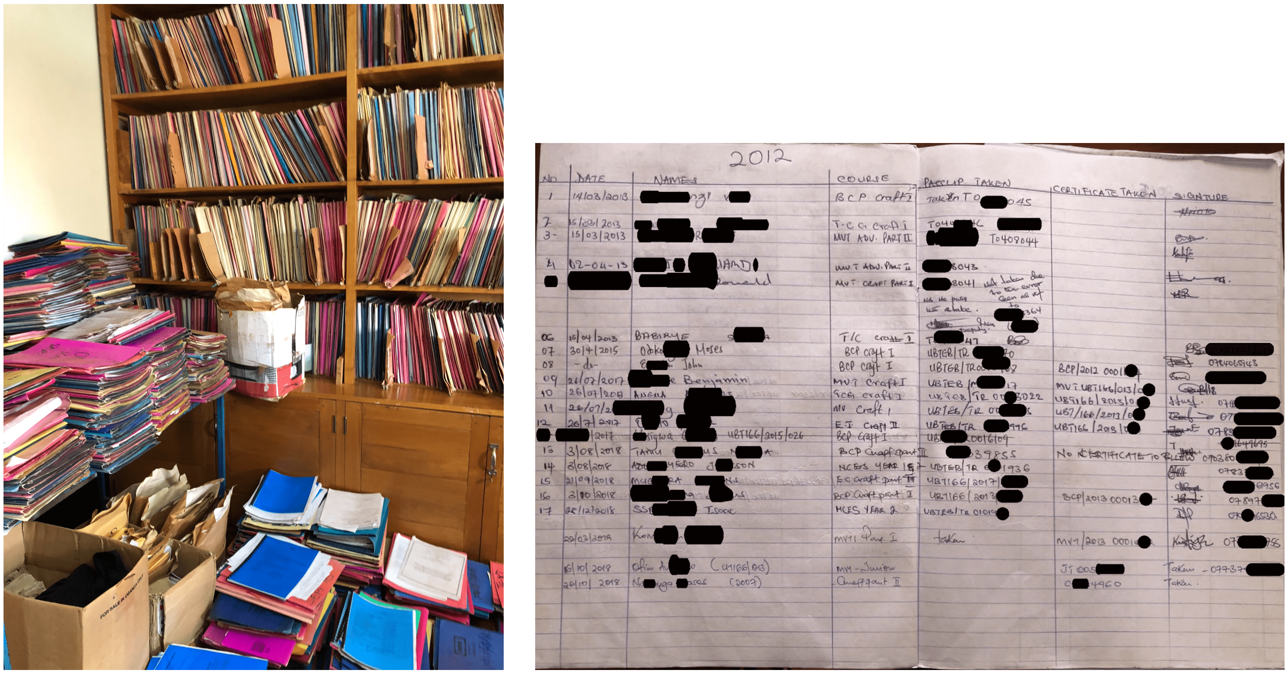
STUDENTS' NAMES and PHONE NUMBERS	KEY CALL 1	KEY CALL 2			KEY CALL 3		
	Date (day and month)	Date (day and month)	Duration (in minutes)	Three main topics of conversation	Date (day and month)	Duration (in minutes)	Three main topics of conversation
BRIAN [redacted]	8/Feb 2021	2/March 2021	30	- How to go about studies - The Job market - Field and Industrial training.	13th/April 2021	11 Mins	- Effective Job search. - Field & Industrial training. - General encouragement.
STEPHEN OSEGE	9/Feb	8/March		- The Job market - How to find opportunities	7th/April	8 mins	- Personal experience. - Effective Job search.

Table A.4: Mentors' Characteristics

	Mean	SD
Panel A: Socio-Economic Characteristics		
Female	.23	.42
Age	25.05	3.17
Married	.42	.49
Has children	.49	.50
Traditional religious denomination	.71	.45
House of origin: rural	.43	.50
Region of origin: Central or Eastern	.84	.36
Caretaker's years of education	10.61	5.27
Panel B: Labor Market Characteristics		
Years in labor market	2.72	1.93
Wage employed	.69	.46
Self employed	.17	.38
Has permanent job	.75	.43
Works in / owns registered firm	.43	.50
Enrolled in further education	.04	.20
Involved in casual occupations	.02	.15
Works in area of training	.93	.26
Works in area of training (uncond. on working)	.93	.26
Ever worked in area of training	.08	.27
Panel C: Dyad Characteristics		
Same gender	.87	.33
Same training area	1.00	.00
Same VTI	.84	.37
Age Difference	5.03	3.13
Age gap within 6 years	.66	.47
Same district of origin	.49	.50

Notes: In this table, we report demographic and labor market characteristics of MYF mentors.

Figure A.7: Mentors Sample Construction - Records Digitization

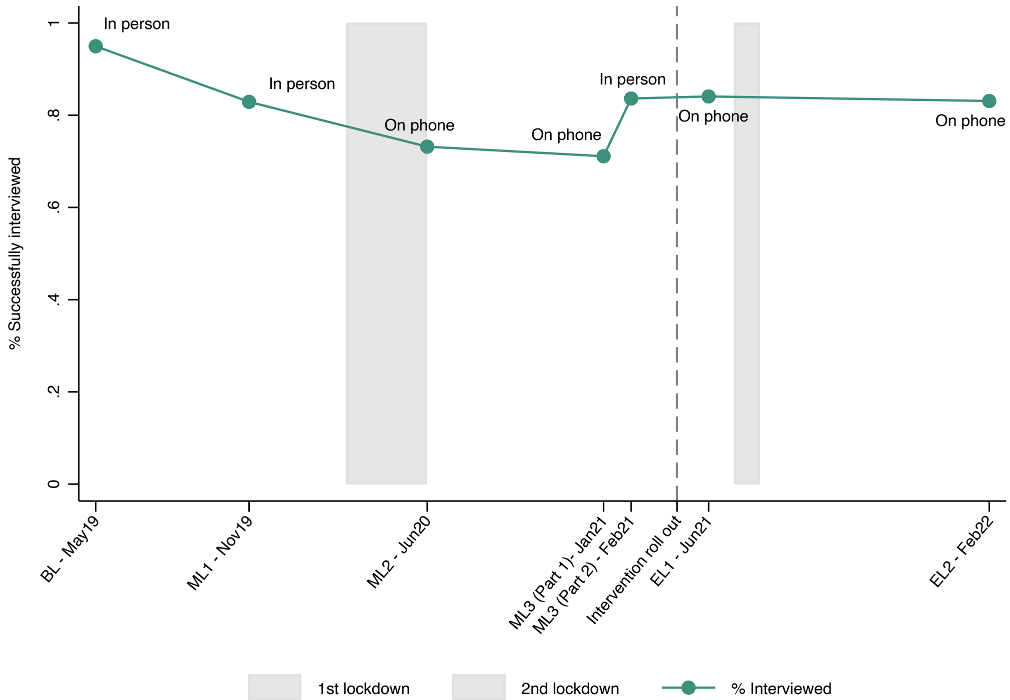


B Attrition and Compliance

Online Appendix Figure A.8 reports attrition rates by survey round. The baseline and first midline survey were conducted in person, with the enumerators interviewing students at the VTIs. The decrease in the share of successfully completed interviews reported between baseline and midline surveys is unrelated to students dropping out of school. Rather, it can be attributed to the timing of the interviews — enumerators went to schools only after the exam period by which time many students had already left the schools to go home.

Starting from the second midline survey we conducted all project activities on the phone due to the onset of Covid-19. A rise in the attrition rate followed, as students' mobile phone numbers had not been extensively collected, making it more difficult to contact them. Therefore, a third midline survey was conducted both in person and on the phone before the roll out of the MYF program to collect students' alternative mobile phone numbers and details of contact person(s). The in-person tracking allowed the share of successful interviews at midline 3 to equal pre-pandemic values.

Figure A.8: Attrition



The overall attrition rate after the intervention was stable at approximately 7.6% with respect to the latest pre-intervention data collection and 8.7% with respect to baseline. In the first case, a 7.6% attrition rate is particularly low. In absolute numbers, this means that of the 1046 students surveyed in the third midline, 1013 students were successfully found after the intervention. In the latter case, the figure of 8.7% is low compared with the literature, where a review of 91 RCTs published in top economics journals (Ghanem, Hirshleifer, and Ortiz-Beccera, 2023) shows an average of 15%, and studies surveying youth (Bandiera et al., 2020) report 18%. For the few studies that reported lower rates of attrition, substantial differences could be noted – for example, most studies among those mentioned in Bandiera et al. (2020) tracked students for one or two years only, whereas in this study, two years elapsed between baseline and the roll out of the intervention and three years between the baseline and the second endline. Last, the studies that tracked students for four or more years typically focused on a random subsample with intensive tracking, while we aimed to track all students present from baseline. We find these attrition rates satisfactory.

Table A.5: Attrition

	Found in EL1			Found in EL2			Ever found		
MYF Treatment Assignment	-.005	-.008	.227	.015	.016	.066	.003	.001	.261
	(.021)	(.022)	(.221)	(.018)	(.018)	(.260)	(.014)	(.014)	(.178)
Gender (1=M)			.001			.248			.028
			(.100)			(.174)			(.074)
Age			.011			-.006			.003
			(.008)			(.010)			(.005)
HH Main Income Source Agriculture			.047			.078			.057*
			(.033)			(.053)			(.032)
Student Has a Scholarship			-.010			-.057			.003
			(.036)			(.046)			(.027)
HH Assets Index Above Mean			-.016			.028			.015
			(.037)			(.041)			(.030)
Ever Worked Pre MYF			.019			.054			.051
			(.037)			(.043)			(.034)
Treatment × Gender			.030			-.001			.012
			(.046)			(.047)			(.033)
Treatment × Age			-.013			-.000			-.011
			(.011)			(.013)			(.008)
Treatment × HH Main Income Source Agriculture			-.003			-.038			-.041
			(.051)			(.047)			(.045)
Treatment × Student Has a Scholarship			.025			.038			-.028
			(.057)			(.048)			(.046)
Treatment × HH Asset Index Above Mean			.008			-.080			-.058
			(.052)			(.064)			(.048)
Treatment × Ever Worked Pre MYF			.003			-.013			-.016
			(.055)			(.051)			(.038)
Constant	.843***	1.004***	.783***	.822***	.992***	1.077***	.910***	.999***	.879***
	(.029)	(.011)	(.163)	(.023)	(.009)	(.193)	(.021)	(.007)	(.110)
Control Mean	.84	.84	.84	.82	.82	.82	.91	.91	.91
R-squared	.00	.11	.12	.00	.09	.10	.00	.10	.11
N	1111	1111	1101	1111	1111	1101	1111	1111	1101
Controls	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Strata	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
F-statistc									
Characteristics			.71			.13			.09
Characteristics + Interactions			.41			.20			.86

Considering attrition at endline 1, Column 1 of Online Appendix Table A.5 shows that being assigned to the MYF treatment does not predict attrition, and Column 2 suggests that the result is robust within strata. Column 3 shows that the result holds also when controlling for baseline characteristics and allowing for there to be differential attrition between treatment and control based on these characteristics (age, gender, agricultural household, scholarship, household assets index above mean and previous work experience). None of these characteristics predicts attrition (except for the indicator for agricultural household significant at 10% level) and there is no evidence of differential attrition across treatment and control groups by these characteristics. At the bottom of Column 3, we report the p-value for the joint F-statistic on the characteristics and on the interactions, which are jointly insignificant (p-value of .71). The same holds, at 5% significance level, for attrition between baseline and endline 2 and between baseline and the indicator dummy Ever found which takes value 1 if the student was found at endline 1 or endline 2. In brief, treatment does not predict attrition, nor do the strata dummies nor baseline characteristics (except for agricultural household for the ever found dummy, at 10% significance level).

Lastly, Online Appendix Table A.6 presents a comprehensive set of balance checks based on students who complied with or were assigned to the treatment. We find no significant differences in baseline characteristics between compliers and non-compliers, except for a few cases: non-compliers were more likely to be female and to have a household asset index above the mean.

Table A.6: Attrition Analysis: Baseline Characteristics for Compliers and Non-Compliers

	(1) Non-Compliers		(2) Compliers		(1)-(2) Pairwise t-test
Variable	N	Mean/(SE)	N	Mean/(SE)	P-value
Panel A: Socio-economic characteristics					
Age in 2020	56	19.963 (.279)	589	20.312 (.083)	.227
Gender (1=M)	56	.464 (.067)	589	.608 (.020)	.040**
Christian	56	.911 (.038)	589	.832 (.015)	.056*
Single	56	.804 (.054)	586	.894 (.013)	.098*
Has Children	56	.054 (.030)	589	.020 (.006)	.280
Region of Origin: Central	56	.518 (.067)	587	.303 (.019)	.002***
Region of Origin: Eastern	56	.411 (.066)	587	.523 (.021)	.104
HH Assets Index Above Mean	56	.500 (.067)	587	.361 (.020)	.047**
HH Main Income Source Agriculture	56	.393 (.066)	589	.472 (.021)	.249
Panel B: Labor market history pre MYF					
Ever Worked Pre MYF	56	.518 (.067)	589	.537 (.021)	.790
Ever Worked in Training Sector	51	.078 (.038)	563	.085 (.012)	.863
Has Done Any Casual Work	56	.321 (.063)	589	.241 (.018)	.217
Has Done Any Wage Employment	56	.179 (.052)	589	.314 (.019)	.014**
Has Done Any Self Employment	56	.089 (.038)	589	.085 (.011)	.912

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

C Strata and Balance Variables

Choice of the strata variables

First, we stratify by VTI, as the implementation of the treatment could vary at the school level. Second, we stratify by a measure of "risk of attrition" to reduce the possibility of selective attrition. To do so, we use *hard to find*, an indicator for whether the student has not been successfully interviewed in three out of the first three pre-intervention survey rounds. Third, we choose to stratify along dimensions that are likely to be correlated with our outcomes of interest based on economic theory and existing data. To identify these variables we look at correlates of pre-VTI employment in our student sample while for the alumni we look at correlates of their labor market outcomes. We stratify along the following four dimensions and obtain a total of 5×2×2×2=40 strata:

Table A.7: Strata Variables

Variable Name	**Description**	**Motivation**
VTI	Categorical variable with 5 levels corresponding to the 5 VTIs in our sample	Potentially correlated with treatment implementation
Male	Indicator for whether student's gender is male	Positively correlated with labor market outcomes
Hard to find	Indicator for not reaching the student in all pre-intervention survey rounds	To reduce the risk of having differential attrition by treatment status
Smartphone	Indicator for smartphone ownership	Negatively correlated with labor market outcomes; to reduce the risk of having differential attrition by treatment status

Choice of the balance variables

The randomization procedure was replicated until balance was achieved on a predetermined characteristic we expected to be highly correlated with the outcomes of interest: a dummy variable indicating whether the student had ever worked (either before beginning the course or during the lockdown). The procedure determining whether the randomization should be replicated was defined ex-ante and detailed in the pre-analysis plan. In practice, balance was achieved after one randomization, thus no replication of the randomization was necessary.

D Model Derivations

Our model builds on Cortés et al. (2023) but is tailored to our setting. Relative to their framework, we (i) omit job search before graduation, (ii) abstract from explicit belief dynamics over time, and (iii) do not model individual risk aversion.[40] We expand their setup by introducing beliefs about the early experience premium (the "steepness of the job ladder"), $\hat{\omega}$. Throughout, job seekers hold beliefs about (i) the mean of the *entry wage-offer distribution*, $\hat{\mu}$, and (ii) the *experience premium*, $\hat{\omega}$, which affects values through post-acceptance wage growth (via W). Thus the perceived offer distribution is $F(\cdot; \hat{\mu})$.

Setup: Let $U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ denote the value of unemployment and let $W(w, \hat{\omega})$ denote the value of employment at entry wage w.

We assume the value of employment takes the affine form

$$W(w, \hat{\omega}) = \frac{w + \beta\hat{\omega}}{1 - \beta}, \tag{11}$$

so that

$$W_w(w, \hat{\omega}) = \frac{1}{1 - \beta} > 0, \qquad W_{\hat{\omega}}(w, \hat{\omega}) = \frac{\beta}{1 - \beta} > 0. \tag{12}$$

Lemma 1: Cutoff search and cutoff representation. There exists a cutoff $c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ such that the worker searches iff $c \leq c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$. Let the reservation wage $w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ be defined implicitly by

$$W(w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}), \hat{\omega}) = U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}). \tag{13}$$

Then the cutoff satisfies

$$c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})}^{\infty} \left(W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})\right) \, dF(w; \hat{\mu}). \tag{14}$$

Proof sketch. Conditional on c, searching yields net value $-c + \beta\mathcal{V}(1)$, while not searching yields βU. The gain from searching is strictly decreasing in c, so the optimal policy is a cutoff. Indifference at $c = c^*$ gives $c^* = \beta(\mathcal{V}(1) - U)$. Using $\mathcal{V}(1) = \lambda \int \max\{W, U\} \, dF + (1 - \lambda)U$ and the reservation wage definition (13) implies $\int \max\{W, U\} \, dF - U = \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W - U) \, dF$, yielding (14). $\square$

Lemma 2: Value identity and derivative link. Under the cutoff policy from Lemma 1, the unemployment value satisfies

$$U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = b + \beta U(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) + H(c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})) \, c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) - \int_0^{c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})} c \, dH(c). \tag{15}$$

[40] An earlier version of the paper mistakenly stated that risk preferences were measured post-treatment, while they were elicited only at baseline, and are balanced between T and C. We did elicit time preferences post-treatment, motivated by the prominence of intertemporal considerations in mentorship conversations ("patience" was the single most frequent word in the conversations transcripts), but find no treatment effects on this measure. As in Falk et al. (2018), we used adapted modules from the Global Preference Survey.

Moreover, for any scalar parameter x that affects the right-hand side of (15) only through (U, c^*),

$$(1-\beta)\, U_x(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}) = H(c^*)\, c^*_x, \quad \text{where } c^* = c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega}). \tag{16}$$

Proof. Split the Bellman over $c \le c^*$ and $c > c^*$ and use the cutoff indifference condition (from Lemma 1) to replace the continuation-value difference by c^*/β. This yields (15). Differentiating (15) w.r.t. x and applying the chain rule yields the cancellation $\frac{\partial}{\partial x}[H(c^*)c^*] = [h(c^*)c^* + H(c^*)]\, c^*_x$ and $\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left[\int_0^{c^*} c\, dH(c)\right] = c^* h(c^*) c^*_x$, which implies (16). □

We now prove Propositions 1–3 using Lemmas 1–2. We focus on the interior region where search occurs with positive probability (equivalently $c^* > 0$ and $1 - F(w_R) > 0$).

Proof of Proposition 1. Holding $(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ fixed, c^* and w_R are increasing in λ.

Proof. Fix $(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})$ and suppress them in notation where unambiguous.

By Lemma 2,

$$U_\lambda = \frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\, c^*_\lambda. \tag{17}$$

From (14),

$$c^* = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R(\lambda)}^{\infty} \left(W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\lambda)\right)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}).$$

Differentiate w.r.t. λ. Let $G(w, \lambda) = W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\lambda)$. Then

$$c^*_\lambda = \beta \int_{w_R}^{\infty} G(w, \lambda)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) + \beta\lambda \left[\int_{w_R}^{\infty} (-U_\lambda)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) - G(w_R, \lambda) f(w_R; \hat{\mu})\, w_{R,\lambda}\right].$$

Because $G(w_R, \lambda) = W(w_R, \hat{\omega}) - U(\lambda) = 0$ by (13), the boundary term vanishes, so

$$c^*_\lambda = \beta \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W - U)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) - \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}))U_\lambda. \tag{18}$$

Substitute (17) into (18) and rearrange:

$$\left[1 + \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}))\frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\right] c^*_\lambda = \beta \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W - U)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}).$$

The bracketed term is strictly positive. The integral on the right-hand side is strictly positive because $W(w, \hat{\omega}) > U$ for $w > w_R$ and $1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}) > 0$ in the interior region. Hence $c^*_\lambda > 0$.

Differentiate (13) w.r.t. λ:

$$W_w(w_R, \hat{\omega})\, w_{R,\lambda} = U_\lambda,$$

since W does not depend on λ. Using $W_w > 0$ from (12) and $U_\lambda > 0$ from (17) and $c^*_\lambda > 0$, we obtain $w_{R,\lambda} > 0$. □

Proof of Proposition 2. Holding $\hat{\omega}$ fixed, c^* and w_R are increasing in $\hat{\mu}$.

Proof. Fix $\hat{\omega}$ and suppress it in notation. Assume the perceived entry wage distribution is Normal:

$$w \sim \mathcal{N}(\hat{\mu}, \sigma^2), \qquad f(w;\hat{\mu}) = \frac{1}{\sigma}\phi\left(\frac{w-\hat{\mu}}{\sigma}\right), \tag{19}$$

By Lemma 2,

$$U_{\hat{\mu}} = \frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\, c^*_{\hat{\mu}}. \tag{20}$$

From (14),

$$c^* = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R(\hat{\mu})}^{\infty} \left(W(w,\hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\mu})\right)\, dF(w;\hat{\mu}).$$

Differentiate w.r.t. $\hat{\mu}$. Let $G(w,\hat{\mu}) = W(w,\hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\mu})$. Then

$$c^*_{\hat{\mu}} = \beta\lambda \left[\int_{w_R}^{\infty} (-U_{\hat{\mu}})\, dF(w;\hat{\mu}) - G(w_R,\hat{\mu}) f(w_R;\hat{\mu})\, w_{R,\hat{\mu}}\right] + \beta\lambda \int_{w_R}^{\infty} G(w,\hat{\mu})\, \frac{\partial f(w;\hat{\mu})}{\partial \hat{\mu}}\, dw.$$

Again $G(w_R,\hat{\mu}) = 0$ by (13), so

$$c^*_{\hat{\mu}} = -\beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R;\hat{\mu}))U_{\hat{\mu}} + \beta\lambda \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W-U)\, \frac{\partial f(w;\hat{\mu})}{\partial \hat{\mu}}\, dw. \tag{21}$$

Substitute (20) into (21) and rearrange:

$$\left[1 + \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R;\hat{\mu}))\frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\right] c^*_{\hat{\mu}} = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W-U)\, \frac{\partial f(w;\hat{\mu})}{\partial \hat{\mu}}\, dw. \tag{22}$$

Using (**??**), the right-hand side becomes

$$\frac{\beta\lambda}{\sigma^2} \int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W(w,\hat{\omega}) - U)\, (w-\hat{\mu})\, f(w;\hat{\mu})\, dw.$$

Since $W(w,\hat{\omega}) - U > 0$ for $w > w_R$ and the upper tail has positive probability mass, the integral is strictly positive.Because the bracketed term on the left-hand side of (22) is strictly positive, it follows that $c^*_{\hat{\mu}} > 0$.

Differentiate (13) w.r.t. $\hat{\mu}$ holding $\hat{\omega}$ fixed:

$$W_w(w_R,\hat{\omega})\, w_{R,\hat{\mu}} = U_{\hat{\mu}}.$$

Using $W_w > 0$ from (12) and $U_{\hat{\mu}} > 0$ from (20) and $c^*_{\hat{\mu}} > 0$, we obtain $w_{R,\hat{\mu}} > 0$. □

Proof of Proposition 3. Holding $\hat{\mu}$ fixed, c^* is increasing in $\hat{\omega}$ and w_R is decreasing in $\hat{\omega}$:

$$\frac{\partial c^*(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})}{\partial \hat{\omega}} > 0, \qquad \frac{\partial w_R(\hat{\mu}, \hat{\omega})}{\partial \hat{\omega}} < 0.$$

Proof. Fix $\hat{\mu}$ and suppress it in notation.

By Lemma 2,

$$U_{\hat{\omega}} = \frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\, c^*_{\hat{\omega}}. \tag{23}$$

From (14),

$$c^* = \beta\lambda \int_{w_R(\hat{\omega})}^{\infty} \left(W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\omega})\right)\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}).$$

Differentiate w.r.t. $\hat{\omega}$. Let $G(w, \hat{\omega}) = W(w, \hat{\omega}) - U(\hat{\omega})$. Then

$$c^*_{\hat{\omega}} = \beta\lambda \left[\int_{w_R}^{\infty} (W_{\hat{\omega}} - U_{\hat{\omega}})\, dF(w; \hat{\mu}) - G(w_R, \hat{\omega}) f(w_R; \hat{\mu})\, w_{R,\hat{\omega}} \right].$$

Because $G(w_R, \hat{\omega}) = 0$ by (13), the boundary term vanishes, so

$$c^*_{\hat{\omega}} = \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}))\, (W_{\hat{\omega}} - U_{\hat{\omega}})\,. \tag{24}$$

Substitute (23) into (24) and rearrange:

$$\left[1 + \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}))\frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta}\right] c^*_{\hat{\omega}} = \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu})) W_{\hat{\omega}}. \tag{25}$$

Since $W_{\hat{\omega}} = \frac{\beta}{1-\beta} > 0$ by (12) and the bracketed term is strictly positive, it follows that $c^*_{\hat{\omega}} > 0$.

Differentiate (13) w.r.t. $\hat{\omega}$:

$$W_w(w_R, \hat{\omega})\, w_{R,\hat{\omega}} + W_{\hat{\omega}}(w_R, \hat{\omega}) = U_{\hat{\omega}}.$$

Hence

$$w_{R,\hat{\omega}} = \frac{U_{\hat{\omega}} - W_{\hat{\omega}}}{W_w}. \tag{26}$$

From (25) define

$$A := \beta\lambda(1 - F(w_R; \hat{\mu}))\frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta} > 0.$$

Then (25) implies $c^*_{\hat{\omega}} = \beta\lambda(1-F)W_{\hat{\omega}}/(1+A)$, and using (23) we obtain

$$U_{\hat{\omega}} = \frac{H(c^*)}{1-\beta} c^*_{\hat{\omega}} = W_{\hat{\omega}} \frac{A}{1+A} \; < \; W_{\hat{\omega}}.$$

Therefore $U_{\hat{\omega}} - W_{\hat{\omega}} < 0$, and since $W_w > 0$ by (12), (26) yields $w_{R,\hat{\omega}} < 0$. $\square$

E Text Data Processing and Classification

E.1 Topic Classification

To perform topic analysis and discern the content of these conversations, we utilize the (at the time of analysis) state-of-the-art Claude 3.7 Sonnet (`claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219`) model developed by Anthropic to label the topic of each sentence within a conversation. We refrain from supervised learning, due to our relatively small corpus and to avoid subjective input during training data labeling. To utilize the model, we define four categories: Information about job-market, Strategies, Encouragement and Referrals, based on content from the mentors' training and questions from the post-interaction survey.[41]

The taxonomy used to classify mentoring content into four channels, was pre-specified prior to implementation and embedded in mentor training materials and post-interaction survey. While the decision to audio-record mentorship calls was taken after the Stage-1 acceptance at the Journal of Development Economics, the analytical plan to study mentoring content along these four dimensions was pre-specified. The only difference from the original plan concerns measurement: rather than having enumerators listen to calls and manually code topics from the pre-defined list, we use a large language model to classify sentence-level content using the same taxonomy. This approach reduces measurement noise and improves replicability, as live coding of several hundred hours of unstructured conversations would have been difficult to audit and verify at scale, whereas the model applies a fixed and documented prompt uniformly across all conversations. We use the following prompt to classify:

You are tasked with classifying each sentence in a conversation between a youth and a mentor. The youth is a vocational student during their school-to-work transitions in urban Uganda. The mentor is a recent graduate of the same vocational school and course of study, with substantive experience in the labor market and pertinent information on local labor market conditions. Each sentence is numbered for reference.

Conversation:

[1] Mentor: "Hello, how are you?"

[2] Student: "I am fine."

[3] Mentor: "May I have your number, please?"

[4] Student: "It's 070-865-XXXX."

[41] Content related to mentors' personal experience is classified as either information about the labor market or search strategies, depending on the substance of the experience, as described in detail in the prompt.

[copy the rest of the conversation here]

Categories:

1. Information about the job market
2. Strategies to navigate the job market
3. Encouragement and psychological support
4. Referral of job opportunities
5. Anything that does not fall under the aforementioned 4 categories

1. Job Market and Workplace Information and Experience. Examples include but not limited to: Time to find a job; Prevailing wages; Possibility of finding a job/working; Commonality of unpaid jobs or paying for training; Practical skills for job finding; Types of positions/contractual arrangements; Women's conditions, discrimination, and rights in the workplace; Time to start a business from scratch; Profits for a new business; Mentor's current and past jobs/occupations; Mentor wages/profits; Time for mentor to find jobs; Mentor's wage/profits.

2. Tips for Job Search, Workplace Behavior, and Career Development. Examples include but not limited to: Job search strategies; Setting up a business; Recommended job/business locations; Interviewing skills; Number of job to apply; CV writing; Job application materials; Negotiation of job offers; Job application costs; Transportation costs during job search; Resources for starting a business; Networking with providers and clients; Finding basic tools/equipment; Business accounting; Obtaining loans for business/tools; Time management during job search; Mentor's own experience navigating the job market and work place; Strategies the mentor employed during their job search / early career.

3. Encouragement and Motivation. Examples include but not limited to: Encouragement to persist and focus on goals; Confidence building; Support for optimism about the future; Uplifting students' spirits.

4. Referrals. Examples include but not limited to: Referrals or promises of job opportunities, internships, potential employers, and clients.

5. Other Topics. Examples include but not limited to: Anything that does not fall under the aforementioned 4 categories; General greetings, introductions, and contact exchanges.

Instructions:

- **Your task is to classify each sentence into one of the 5 categories above.**

- **Consider the context of each sentence within the conversation.**

- **For backchannels (e.g., “uh-huh”, “yeah”, “okay”), assign the category based on context, such as the category of the preceding sentence.**

- **For utterances that fall into multiple categories, assign the most dominant or primary category.**

- **For utterances that don’t directly contain content from categories 1-4 but serve to initiate or redirect conversation towards a specific category, assign them the category they are leading towards.**

- **Provide the output in JSON format, with sentence numbers as keys and category numbers as values.**

- **Your response should contain the JSON only.**

Example Output Format:

‘‘‘json

“1”: 3,

“2”: 1,

“3”: 3,

“4”: 2,

“5”: 2,

“6”: 1,

“7”: 1,

“8”: 2,

“9”: 3,

“10”: 3

”’

To maximize reproducibility, we set model temperature to 0.

E.1.1 Examples of Sentence Classification

Information About Entry Conditions

- ⋆ For the start they tell you since you don't have any experience we give you 10,000 UGX.
- ⋆ At first the permit was costing 450,000 shillings but now they increased it is at 500,000.
- ⋆ Where I started from I was working and they would pay me just 7,000 shillings a day. I worked for 7,000 shillings for 8 months.
- ⋆ In December 2014 in the garage we were assigned some work. We had five vehicles but they were not paying us we would only get allowance and that was after the first month. The first month we worked for free.
- ⋆ After all those allowances they are going to be paying you let me say 100,000 shillings.

Encouragement

- ⋆ You can start poorly but if you are patient, flexible, disciplined you will be promoted easily.
- ⋆ I don't want you to lose morale when you find that they are paying you little money in the start first look at experience because sometimes patience is needed.
- ⋆ At national water they told me they did not have other jobs other than digging trenches so despite having studied I agreed because it was still in my field. I was flexible, patient, and disciplined, the manger had kept on observing me.
- ⋆ So for the start they might pay you less than your expectations but you need to be patient for the beginning then they keep on up grading.
- ⋆ What I can encourage you is to be patient, don't lose hope, work hard, you need to work hard, everything you have to work for it.

Search Tips

- ⋆ If you are writing an application, either to a company or a workshop, we look at the headlines, you get a paper, on the right write your address, then you jump one line and write the company address where you are applying.
- ⋆ Getting a job sometimes depends on the way you express yourself, dress code and even the way as you enter someone's office.
- ⋆ You can look for a job through Newvision, Bukedde, those newspapers. The first thing to do when you see a job is to write an application and you take it there.
- ⋆ With like 5000 shillings you can print a light cv and seal it in the envelope.
- ⋆ Some people may pretend they are askaris yet they are interviewers.
- ⋆ When you are going for interview you have to put on good clothes and look smart.
- ⋆ I had 2 types of letters, okay 3, a cover letter, an application letter and CV.

Job Referrals

- ⋆ I have someone who told me I should get her a worker who can sew uniforms and if you say you know how to sew them, I will connect you with her.
- ⋆ I will try to get the number of the field engineer and give it to you the next time we talk.
- ⋆ So when you are done I will recommend you to some places like SHAKA XXXX, JAVA HOUSE and you can drop your applications.
- ⋆ You can call 078610XXXX and ask them but they don't hire trainees but if you ready to work they can take you on, I have worked there before it has a logo of a rhino.

E.2 Text Pre-Process for Embedding-Based Analysis

We pre-process the conversation transcripts using GPT-4o-mini to correct spelling and grammatical errors in the transcripts, with the following prompt:
"Please correct any spelling and grammatical errors, and add missing punctuation to the following text, which is a transcription of an utterance in a conversation. Do not remove existing punctuation. Your response should only include the corrected text.
Text:
[text] "
We use the cleaned text for embedding-based analysis. For classification we use the original text to minimize text manipulation and because the generative model we use understands sentences with spelling and grammatical issues. We use the mini version of GPT-4o for text cleaning, a simple task that does not need advanced models.

F Spillovers

This section explores the potential indirect treatment effects on the outcomes of untreated students who regularly interact with program participants. To study spillovers, we take advantage of the fact that, as part of our intensive data collection effort, we have mapped the VTIs' friendship networks of each treated and untreated student. Specifically, we gathered information on each student's two closest friends in the cohort, regardless of classroom or field of study. We are able to determine the treatment status of each student's two closest friends as a result of the fact that, for the primary experiment, we constructed a panel data comprising the entire cohort of interest.

Recent work showed the importance of these types of social contact, consistent with qualitative and descriptive data from our environment (Caria, Franklin, and Witte, 2023). The spillover design is relatively straightforward. By treating students at random, we automatically altered the proportion of treated friends control students will have. To examine the presence of spillovers we run the following regression:

$$Y_{i,s,t} = \alpha + \beta_1 S_1 C_i + \gamma_0 S_0 T_i + \gamma_1 S_1 T_i + X_i' \delta + \lambda_s + \epsilon_{i,s,t} \tag{27}$$

where T_i identifies students who have been assigned to the MYF treatment, while C_i identifies students who have not been assigned to the MYF treatment. S_1 is an indicator variable for students with at least one friend assigned to MYF. β_1 captures the difference in outcomes between control students with at least a treated friend and control student with no treated friends. γ_1 measures the difference in outcomes between treated students with treated friends and control students with no treated friends.

During this analysis, we lose nearly half of the data points. Firstly, the network of friends was mapped at midline 3, which corresponds to the survey round with the highest attrition rate (Online Appendix Figure A.8). In addition, because each student could choose friends from the entire cohort (over 300 students) while coding the survey tool, we decided against creating pre-fixed lists of names from which to choose (such long lists would frequently froze the tablets). Names were entered as strings instead. As a result, we matched based on first name, last name, and field of study, resulting in a partially incomplete network of friends due to spelling errors and incomplete names (e.g., only first name, which were too common to match with certainty.)

The results are shown in the Online Appendix Table A.8. As we lose nearly half of the sample, we start by checking whether our main results replicate in the sample for which we have friendship data in Panel A. The main findings remain unchanged. In this sample, the medium run results are, if anything, stronger in magnitude and precision presicion.

Examining Panel B of Online Appendix Table A.8, the evidence is inconclusive: we do not

Table A.8: Spillovers: Leveraging the Network of Friends

	Short Run Labor Market Outcomes					**Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes**				
	Out of the Labor Force (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Working in Sector of Training (3)	Earnings Last Month (4)	First Job Duration (5)	Retained Post Internship (6)	Internship to Job Transition (7)	Out of the Labor Force (8)	Days Worked Last Month (9)	Earnings Last Month (10)
MYF Treatment Assignment	-.08**	1.55**	.08**	3.05	24.41***	.08***	.09	-.06**	1.34	11.01**
	(.03)	(.76)	(.03)	(3.64)	(8.21)	(.02)	(.06)	(.03)	(1.30)	(4.07)
Control + Treated Friends	-.00	1.30	-.03	-10.96	16.97	-.06	.05	.09	-.01	6.25
	(.08)	(1.61)	(.13)	(8.74)	(18.82)	(.09)	(.08)	(.08)	(2.07)	(5.76)
MYF + No Treated Friends	-.03	1.62	.06	-8.47	25.91	.02	.14	-.01	1.82	15.83
	(.11)	(1.77)	(.16)	(8.92)	(26.80)	(.09)	(.12)	(.08)	(3.25)	(10.23)
MYF + Treated Friends	-.09	2.80*	.06	-5.29	40.67***	.03	.12	.02	1.24	16.20***
	(.08)	(1.44)	(.10)	(8.51)	(12.90)	(.05)	(.09)	(.07)	(2.24)	(4.80)
Control Mean	.19	17.00	.65	17.42	80.21	.23	.43	.19	13.97	37.73
N	471	471	471	469	470	471	471	456	456	454

Notes: This table examines spillover effects. The first row replicates main results in the subsample with friendship data. Subsequent rows compare: control students with versus without treated friends; treated students with no treated friends versus controls with no treated friends; and treated students with treated friends versus controls with no treated friends.

find statistically precise evidence that control students with treated friends experience systematically better or worse career trajectories than other control students. However, the point estimates for most key outcomes are aligned with our main treatment effects, notably first-job duration, retention probability, and especially one-year earnings. This pattern is consistent with, though far from definitive evidence of, spillovers that would make our ITT estimates conservative. At minimum, the absence of negative point estimates on these outcomes is reassuring that our main estimates are unlikely to be overstated.

G Robustness and Additional Analyses

We submitted a detailed Pre-Analysis Plan to the *Journal of Development Economics* pre-results submission process. The PAP underwent a revise and resubmit process, and was accepted at *JDE* in early 2021, ahead of the collection of any post-intervention data. From such PAP, there have been almost no deviations, meaning that nearly everything we committed to doing was carried out as planned. The main difference lies in how the analyses of the mechanisms were conducted, which we see as a clear improvement and describe in Appendix Section G.1, along with other minor deviations. Another key point to note is that not all planned analyses are included in the main paper. Appendix Section G.2 serves to document these additional analyses, ensuring full transparency and reporting key takeaways—all of which align fully with (and in some cases strengthen) our main findings.

G.1 Analysis of Mechanisms

Our approach to analyzing mechanisms evolved beyond what was initially planned. We adopted an Empirical Bayes approach, which was not in the original PAP, as we only learned about this methodology later and we explored why the cash transfer had such unintended consequences.

The original PAP stated (in blue):

- Process analysis and mechanisms.
  - Het effect in engagement (reported in Appendix G.2)
  - Het effect in interaction frequency (reported in Appendix G.2)
  - Het effect in interaction length (reported in Appendix G.2)
  - Het effect in type and amount of support provided
    - Deviation: Upon revisiting our original PAP a year later, it was unclear what exactly this last point was meant to translate into, possibly a suggestive heterogeneity analysis interacting treatment with the content of the first mentorship session or key takeaways for students. However, we believe our IV/EB approach represents a significant methodological improvement over the simpler interaction-based analysis originally proposed.
- Het effect in whether the mentee values the interactions.
  - Deviation: Mentees' satisfaction levels are too high for any meaningful heterogeneity analysis.
- Predictors for the success of cash transfer and analyze how they correlate with the main effects on primary outcomes.
  - While the PAP did not specify exactly how we planned to analyze predictors nor which exact predictors, we certainly had not expected the finding reported

in Figure A.2 of the main paper: the cash transfer influenced the mentoring discussions in ways we had not anticipated or intended. We explored all other possible predictors, particularly after finding the cash transfer results puzzling. However, none of the collected data added much explanatory power. In hindsight, we should have collected more detailed information on self-employment attempts, spending patterns, and mentor guidance on financial decisions.

- One of our additional exploratory analyses suggested in the PAP involved providing evidence on the condition of the economy, overall and by sector.
  - We ultimately did not pursue this, as we found no meaningful heterogeneity by sector or region.
- We pre-specified that all data was going to be probability-reweighted to reflect any intensive tracking.
  - There was no systematic intensive tracking.
- We pre-specified that standard errors would be robust to heteroskedasticity, given the individual-level randomization.
  - However, following discussions with many other scholars in the field, we clustered errors at the strata level for the main regressions. Based on Abadie et al. (2023), we remain undecided on the most appropriate SE specification, so we report regressions with robust SE in Online Appendix Tables A.9 and A.10, with no change in results.
- We pre-specified a Matching Quality Index, intended to measure the quality of mentee-employer matches.
  - To construct this index, we had to incorporate data from two rounds of endlines as well as an employer survey. Due to the limited sample size (N = 306) of the employer survey and non-random selection, we did not build this Index.
- We are unable to analyze cohort-level employment expectations as pre-specified because these items were inadvertently omitted from the endline questionnaire.
  - We did, however, elicit beliefs about peers' earnings at endline 1. Estimated effects on expected peer earnings are negative (approximately 4–14% relative to the control mean) but imprecise, and we find no evidence of heterogeneity across treatment arms.

G.2 Additional Analysis from the Pre-Analysis Plan

In this section, we report all the additional analyses we had committed to in the Pre-Analysis Plan. These analyses are divided into heterogeneities, additional outcomes, and alternative estimations of treatment effects. None of these results contradict the main findings. To the contrary, they remain consistent with and even strengthen our primary analysis.

G.2.1 Heterogeneity by Mentee Characteristics

We examined heterogeneity in treatment effects based on mentee characteristics, including gender, previous work experience, cognitive ability (Raven's test score), locus of control, and socio-economic background.

The key takeaway is that none of these heterogeneity factors appear to be particularly relevant, meaning that the treatment was effective across all groups. There is suggestive, but not statistically significant, evidence indicating that individuals who had never worked prior to MYF experienced the largest increase in willingness to accept a job and showed the greatest improvements in short-run labor market outcomes. Similarly, those with higher cognitive ability (as measured by Raven's scores) exhibited stronger labor market outcomes (Tables A.11 – A.16).

G.2.2 Heterogeneity by Interaction Frequency, Length, and Engagement

Take-up of the program was exceptionally high, with strong engagement throughout: Treatment take-up was 91%, with an average of 6.8 interactions per mentee and a total average interaction time of 3.2 hours. Interaction patterns suggest that mentor-mentee pairs who were closer in age and from the same vocational training institutes engaged more frequently (Table A.1). Overall, satisfaction levels were high across all pairs, with strong identification and transportation indices (Banerjee, Ferrara, and Orozco-Olvera, 2019). We conducted sentiment analysis on interactions and examined engagement levels in terms of mentor-to-mentee ratios, frequency of contact, and overall time spent interacting. Feedback was neutral to positive, and while mentors primarily led the conversations, students remained actively engaged throughout the program. Additionally, our heterogeneity analysis largely aligned with expectations:

- Closer mentor-mentee pairs were more effective.
- More engaged trainees benefited more in terms of skills development and labor market outcomes.
- Pairs with stronger connections had longer interactions, higher take-up, greater satisfaction, and stronger identification and transportation indices.

While most of these effects were only directionally aligned, some were statistically significant. We pre-specified heterogeneity analyses on engagement index, identification index, and usefulness index. While considerable effort was spent adapting and piloting these indices to fit the study context, engagement was too uniformly high for meaningful heterogeneity analysis, as there was insufficient variability to be leveraged. This could, however, follow the effectiveness of the mentor selection process and the overall success of the program. This appendix does not include every exploratory correlation or robustness check conducted, as there were numerous additional analyses performed. Further details can be provided upon request. Finally, as part of this heterogeneity analysis, we also pre-specified an analysis on Network Link Formation, which is reported in Table A.1.

G.2.3 Additional Labor Market Outcomes Not in the Main Tables

Beyond the primary outcomes reported in the main tables, we examine several additional labor market indicators: Hours Practicing Technical Skills; Employer-Reported Satisfaction with Employee; Ability to Keep the Job for at Least 3 Months. When assessing Intent-to-Treat estimates for these additional labor market outcomes, we find that all treatment effect signs align with expectations: higher employer satisfaction, increased likelihood of maintaining a job for at least three months, and more time spent practicing technical skills. However, none of these effects reach statistical significance (Online Appendix Table A.17).

G.2.4 Alternative Estimation of Treatment Effects

We committed to reporting results from two additional estimation approaches for our primary outcomes measured in both Endline 1 and Endline 2.

1. Separate Analysis for T1 and T2 The first approach involved analyzing the treatment effects separately for T1 and T2. The findings replicate our main results, with T1 showing the strongest effects in the medium run, including statistically significant impacts on labor market participation (Tables A.18 and A.19).
We follow Goldsmith-Pinkham, Hull, and Kolesár (2024) and use "a linear regression which restricts estimation to the individuals who are either in the control group or the treatment group of interest" to avoid contamination bias. Specifically, we restrict the sample to T1 + Control, and run the regression using T1 as the treatment variable. Same for T2. The ITT specification we use for the regression on Treatment overall is Equation 1. In this section, the new regression specifications we use to avoid contamination bias are:

$$Y_{i,s,t} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 T1_i + X_i'\delta + \lambda_s + \epsilon_{i,s,t} \text{ if } i \text{ in T1 or Control Group} \tag{28}$$

and

$$Y_{i,s,t} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 T2_i + X_i'\delta + \lambda_s + \epsilon_{i,s,t} \text{ if } i \text{ in T2 or Control Group} \tag{29}$$

2. Pooled Sample with Clustered Standard Errors For outcome variables measured in both rounds (EL1 and EL2), we had pre-specified that we would pool the samples and cluster standard errors at the respondent level. We implement this in Table A.20, and the results confirm that pooling across waves reveals overall gains in labor market participation and total earnings (both conditional and unconditional) as a result of the treatment.

3. ATEs vs. ITTs We also committed to reporting Average Treatment Effects on top of Intention-to-Treat estimates reported already in the main tables. Given that among students assigned to treatment and observed at endline 1 ($N = 934$), 98% completed at least one mentorship interaction, ATEs are virtually identical (Table A.22).

Robustness and Additional Analyses Tables

Robust Standard Errors

Table A.9: Robust SE: Short Run, Medium Run, Job Search, and Beliefs

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment Assignment	.036	1.267**	.094***	-.057**	1.700	1.216	.081**	19.227***	.150**
	(.023)	(.575)	(.031)	(.026)	(2.532)	(3.006)	(.032)	(7.192)	(.063)
	[.056]	[.033]	[.020]	[.033]	[.187]	[.187]	[.030]	[.030]	[.033]
Control Mean	.82	16.15	.62	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
Treatment Effect (%)	4.37	7.85	15.14	-26.57	14.15	8.34	15.11	24.63	-
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment Assignment	.041	.076**	.006	.265	.006	-.025	5.889*	8.382*	.135*
	(.026)	(.032)	(.033)	(.793)	(.033)	(.029)	(3.266)	(4.487)	(.070)
	[.192]	[.192]	[.604]	[.604]	[.604]	[.351]	[.192]	[.192]	[.192]
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.56	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
Treatment Effect (%)	22.87	20.70	1.15	2.12	1.15	-9.53	17.59	13.90	-
N	934	934	923	923	923	923	916	512	844

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment Assignment	-11.410***	.073*	-.040*	.029**	-.009	.002	-.086	-8.289**	-.029	.277***
	(3.911)	(.042)	(.024)	(.015)	(.064)	(.064)	(.063)	(3.863)	(.062)	(.086)
	[.017]	[.125]	[.125]	[.104]	[.415]	[.415]	[.170]	[.094]	[.319]	[.014]
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
Treatment Effect (%)	-31.50	13.40	-23.23	3.10	-	-	-	-29.89	-	-
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (4)	Amount Overestimated (5)	Any Overestimate (6)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment Assignment	-11.432*	-15.992**	-.064***	-21.674**	-41.020***	-.100**	-.008	.007
	(6.887)	(7.824)	(.020)	(9.256)	(15.340)	(.040)	(.149)	(.147)
	[.069]	[.041]	[.011]	[.032]	[.028]	[.032]	[.317]	[.317]
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	157.27	100.64	.88	6.22	6.19
Treatment Effect (%)	-7.82	-14.20	-6.84	-13.78	-40.76	-11.34	-0.13	0.11
N	927	832	832	628	370	370	934	921

Notes: This table bundles the robust-standard-error versions of the main ITT estimates (MYF vs. control). For outcome definitions and column-by-column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.10: Treatment Effects by Mentor Types (Robust SE)

	Mechanisms		**Labor Market Outcomes**	
	Search Behavior Index (1)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (2)	Short Run Index (3)	Career Trajectory Index (4)
Panel A — 2SLS				
Entry Conditions	-.09	.59***	.23**	.08
	(.10)	(.11)	(.10)	(.11)
Encouragement	-.04	.27***	.20***	.21**
	(.07)	(.09)	(.08)	(.09)
Search Tips	.05	.02	-.02	-.00
	(.10)	(.13)	(.10)	(.11)
Control Mean	.00	-.00	-.00	.00
N Mentors	158	158	158	157
N	934	668	934	844
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.68	.00	.01	.11
AP Partial F (pval)- Entry Conditions	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Encouragement	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Search Tips	.00	.00	.00	.00
Overidentification test (pval)	.64	.58	.13	.25
Panel B — OLS				
Entry Conditions	-.07	.42***	.19**	.09
	(.09)	(.11)	(.09)	(.10)
Encouragement	-.03	.28***	.20**	.17*
	(.07)	(.09)	(.08)	(.09)
Search Tips	.03	.15	-.02	.01
	(.09)	(.12)	(.09)	(.10)
N	934	668	934	844
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.79	.00	.02	.24

Notes: This table replicates Table 6 but reports robust standard errors.

Heterogeneity Analyses

Table A.11: Heterogeneity Analysis by Gender

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Female Trainee	.054	1.372	.068	-.059*	2.919	2.386	.035	24.383***	.145
	(.033)	(.862)	(.044)	(.033)	(4.697)	(6.060)	(.045)	(8.305)	(.098)
× Male Trainee	.028	1.240*	.111***	-.058**	.492	.121	.111***	16.734**	.150**
	(.028)	(.691)	(.031)	(.025)	(2.013)	(2.647)	(.033)	(6.516)	(.056)
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934
P-Value	.53	.90	.41	.98	.62	.72	.15	.45	.96

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Female Trainee	.036	.092*	-.022	-.556	-.022	-.039	6.210*	11.303*	.166*
	(.030)	(.051)	(.041)	(.927)	(.041)	(.037)	(3.284)	(5.980)	(.087)
× Male Trainee	.047*	.072	.028	.880	.028	-.017	5.756	6.386	.123
	(.027)	(.045)	(.053)	(1.336)	(.053)	(.029)	(5.425)	(5.918)	(.079)
N	934	934	923	923	923	923	916	512	844
P-Value	.77	.76	.44	.36	.44	.62	.94	.53	.70

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× Female Trainee	-6.230	.016	-.043	.017	.031	.074	-.181	-6.226	-.039	.153
	(5.735)	(.058)	(.036)	(.024)	(.137)	(.109)	(.154)	(7.544)	(.109)	(.147)
× Male Trainee	-14.983***	.111***	-.038	.037**	-.033	-.037	-.024	-9.898**	-.018	.357***
	(4.136)	(.034)	(.025)	(.017)	(.066)	(.081)	(.093)	(4.425)	(.106)	(.091)
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668
P-Value	.19	.14	.91	.47	.66	.40	.37	.66	.88	.22

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× Female Trainee	-18.611*	-27.530**	-.089**	-24.176**	-37.959*	-.176**	.009	.352
	(9.084)	(10.790)	(.034)	(10.034)	(20.976)	(.072)	(.245)	(.206)
× Male Trainee	-7.180	-9.506	-.045*	-20.490	-42.486*	-.064	.022	-.201
	(9.803)	(12.543)	(.026)	(15.477)	(21.401)	(.049)	(.193)	(.147)
N	927	832	832	628	370	370	934	921
P-Value	.37	.26	.29	.83	.87	.16	.97	.02

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by gender (female vs. male). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.12: Heterogeneity Analysis by Previous Work Experience

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Worked Pre MYF	.059	1.001	.065	-.045	.127	-.877	.074	23.744***	.109
	(.038)	(.983)	(.045)	(.037)	(3.656)	(4.341)	(.048)	(8.262)	(.098)
× Never Ever Worked Pre MYF	.005	1.332	.105**	-.060	5.264	6.117	.073	18.285*	.202**
	(.039)	(.895)	(.051)	(.037)	(3.141)	(3.710)	(.046)	(10.576)	(.095)
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934
P-Value	.37	.83	.61	.81	.31	.23	.99	.72	.56

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Worked Pre MYF	.040	.083	-.002	-.213	-.002	-.021	4.751	8.034	.148**
	(.031)	(.055)	(.049)	(1.280)	(.049)	(.026)	(4.255)	(6.738)	(.064)
× Never Ever Worked Pre MYF	.038	.065	.006	.737	.006	-.018	6.681	8.125	.122
	(.044)	(.046)	(.060)	(1.269)	(.060)	(.044)	(5.462)	(7.961)	(.120)
N	934	934	923	923	923	923	916	512	844
P-Value	.97	.81	.91	.57	.91	.96	.77	.99	.86

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× Worked Pre MYF	-5.721	.069	-.009	.051**	.056	-.004	-.043	-8.829**	.035	.116
	(5.010)	(.058)	(.026)	(.021)	(.090)	(.099)	(.085)	(3.950)	(.118)	(.100)
× Never Ever Worked Pre MYF	-16.507***	.074	-.054	-.000	-.003	-.034	-.176	-7.093	-.111	.398***
	(5.177)	(.055)	(.036)	(.023)	(.099)	(.088)	(.142)	(7.097)	(.097)	(.112)
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668
P-Value	.12	.95	.31	.08	.63	.81	.40	.82	.31	.02

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× Worked Pre MYF	1.673	-3.065	-.053	-16.482	-40.773	-.072	-.097	-.109
	(15.535)	(17.782)	(.032)	(24.701)	(33.348)	(.065)	(.169)	(.192)
× Never Ever Worked Pre MYF	-21.760**	-27.325**	-.063*	-25.779***	-40.783**	-.138**	.044	.146
	(8.960)	(11.644)	(.032)	(7.234)	(17.845)	(.061)	(.222)	(.183)
N	927	832	832	628	370	370	934	921
P-Value	.25	.30	.82	.75	1.00	.44	.57	.27

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by baseline work experience (worked pre-MYF vs. never worked). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.13: Heterogeneity Analysis by Raven's Test Score

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Raven Score above Median	.057	1.064	.123***	-.112***	2.019	.903	.082*	35.886***	.204***
	(.037)	(.879)	(.040)	(.026)	(2.761)	(3.182)	(.042)	(8.498)	(.068)
× Raven Score below Median	.018	1.869**	.097**	-.026	4.851	5.905	.092**	9.549	.186*
	(.036)	(.921)	(.040)	(.038)	(4.436)	(5.173)	(.044)	(6.834)	(.098)
N	889	889	889	889	886	753	889	884	889
P-Value	.40	.48	.64	.09	.63	.47	.87	.01	.88

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Raven Score above Median	.095**	.040	.004	-.336	.004	-.042	9.580	13.689	.226*
	(.040)	(.048)	(.052)	(1.188)	(.052)	(.044)	(5.680)	(9.071)	(.123)
× Raven Score below Median	-.008	.102**	.021	1.191	.021	-.008	3.287	3.560	.053
	(.033)	(.043)	(.056)	(1.458)	(.056)	(.046)	(5.523)	(7.236)	(.089)
N	889	889	874	874	874	874	868	488	803
P-Value	.05	.27	.82	.39	.82	.64	.42	.39	.29

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× Raven Score above Median	-5.823	.068	-.043	.069***	.100	.004	-.110	-11.345**	.034	.211**
	(4.324)	(.048)	(.034)	(.022)	(.082)	(.104)	(.099)	(4.487)	(.093)	(.090)
× Raven Score below Median	-15.042***	.074	-.040	.011	-.112	-.016	-.058	-7.453	-.079	.326**
	(5.191)	(.055)	(.042)	(.023)	(.112)	(.096)	(.102)	(6.609)	(.115)	(.136)
N	702	702	889	889	889	889	889	842	889	639
P-Value	.17	.93	.95	.05	.08	.88	.59	.58	.32	.44

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× Raven Score above Median	6.823	1.881	-.070*	2.830	-2.797	-.082	.006	-.060
	(12.372)	(16.786)	(.040)	(22.261)	(40.072)	(.091)	(.245)	(.219)
× Raven Score below Median	-24.013***	-29.232***	-.078*	-38.810***	-58.494**	-.125	.068	.209
	(7.477)	(9.888)	(.042)	(9.681)	(23.681)	(.087)	(.212)	(.225)
N	883	793	793	602	357	357	889	872
P-Value	.03	.11	.89	.11	.29	.73	.85	.35

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by baseline Raven score (above-median vs. below-median). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.14: Heterogeneity Analysis by Locus of Control

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Locus of Control above Median	.009	.654	.077	-.040	4.621	5.925	.124***	17.138*	.191
	(.038)	(.971)	(.050)	(.050)	(5.383)	(6.229)	(.044)	(9.809)	(.114)
× Locus of Control below Median	.049*	1.627**	.097***	-.064***	.121	-.732	.059	18.138**	.127**
	(.028)	(.644)	(.034)	(.021)	(2.819)	(3.664)	(.037)	(7.140)	(.061)
N	930	930	930	930	927	783	930	925	930
P-Value	.39	.39	.76	.65	.47	.36	.26	.93	.62

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Locus of Control above Median	.054	.076	-.021	-.925	-.021	-.025	3.589	7.886	.089
	(.047)	(.070)	(.077)	(2.024)	(.077)	(.045)	(7.250)	(9.321)	(.145)
× Locus of Control below Median	.034	.088**	.024	.832	.024	-.018	6.136*	7.655	.140*
	(.028)	(.037)	(.036)	(.836)	(.036)	(.031)	(3.422)	(5.792)	(.070)
N	930	930	920	920	920	920	913	511	842
P-Value	.74	.87	.54	.35	.54	.90	.71	.98	.75

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× Locus of Control above Median	-13.583**	.115	-.032	.036	.057	-.137	-.201	-11.212*	-.119	.402**
	(5.630)	(.082)	(.039)	(.035)	(.157)	(.145)	(.168)	(6.081)	(.168)	(.159)
× Locus of Control below Median	-11.663***	.067	-.056	.028*	-.024	.061	-.034	-6.473	.018	.228*
	(3.998)	(.045)	(.034)	(.015)	(.073)	(.071)	(.081)	(5.751)	(.068)	(.122)
N	734	734	930	930	930	930	930	881	930	665
P-Value	.76	.64	.68	.83	.62	.20	.32	.58	.38	.40

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× Locus of Control above Median	-3.224	-4.182	-.036	-23.021**	-42.460**	-.026	.184	.140
	(7.834)	(9.456)	(.043)	(9.863)	(20.695)	(.104)	(.258)	(.381)
× Locus of Control below Median	-15.658	-20.184	-.064**	-23.644	-44.972*	-.135*	-.053	-.005
	(10.778)	(13.071)	(.029)	(16.947)	(25.427)	(.067)	(.227)	(.170)
N	923	830	830	626	369	369	930	918
P-Value	.34	.28	.57	.98	.94	.30	.51	.74

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by baseline locus of control (above-median vs. below-median). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.15: Heterogeneity Analysis by Socio-economic Background

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× HH Asset above Mean	.028	1.150	.092**	-.017	-1.639	-2.247	.082	21.665**	.065
	(.036)	(.884)	(.035)	(.029)	(5.247)	(6.395)	(.050)	(10.562)	(.095)
× HH Asset below Mean	.049*	1.266*	.084**	-.078**	4.133	4.044	.077**	14.681*	.201***
	(.029)	(.696)	(.037)	(.030)	(2.989)	(3.840)	(.033)	(7.426)	(.067)
N	928	928	928	928	925	780	928	923	928
P-Value	.62	.91	.87	.14	.38	.44	.93	.63	.25

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× HH Asset above Mean	.107**	.062	.007	.494	.007	-.040	6.395	10.104	.227*
	(.043)	(.077)	(.050)	(1.222)	(.050)	(.036)	(4.944)	(6.723)	(.112)
× HH Asset below Mean	-.006	.093**	.012	.345	.012	-.012	7.597*	9.700	.088
	(.032)	(.036)	(.043)	(1.093)	(.043)	(.039)	(4.216)	(6.666)	(.094)
N	928	928	918	918	918	918	911	510	839
P-Value	.05	.71	.92	.90	.92	.65	.82	.96	.40

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× HH Asset above Mean	-11.819*	.081	-.013	.024	.024	.068	-.195	-6.808	-.048	.184
	(6.160)	(.065)	(.039)	(.027)	(.117)	(.093)	(.153)	(5.709)	(.156)	(.152)
× HH Asset below Mean	-12.548***	.087**	-.039	.034*	-.003	-.061	-.059	-12.103**	-.037	.324***
	(3.483)	(.041)	(.031)	(.017)	(.086)	(.082)	(.076)	(5.429)	(.078)	(.109)
N	735	735	928	928	928	928	928	879	928	666
P-Value	.91	.95	.59	.75	.84	.27	.35	.47	.95	.42

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× HH Asset above Mean	8.855	5.046	-.075*	7.650	-14.476	-.127	.242	-.030
	(13.086)	(17.219)	(.044)	(18.228)	(26.371)	(.084)	(.267)	(.212)
× HH Asset below Mean	-24.985***	-31.942***	-.069***	-41.174***	-65.626***	-.091	-.176	.117
	(7.154)	(7.719)	(.023)	(9.812)	(16.039)	(.059)	(.165)	(.195)
N	921	827	827	625	368	368	928	916
P-Value	.00	.01	.90	.00	.02	.70	.16	.59

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by baseline household asset index (above-mean vs. below-mean). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.16: Heterogeneity Analysis by Pre-MYF Expectation

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Above Median	-.010	.035	.067	-.064	3.020	5.143	.054	35.790***	.136
	(.046)	(1.295)	(.065)	(.046)	(4.426)	(4.552)	(.048)	(11.737)	(.118)
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Below Median	-.001	1.116	.119**	-.072	-.878	-1.545	.151**	16.623	.158
	(.042)	(1.238)	(.046)	(.066)	(4.401)	(5.435)	(.062)	(14.891)	(.108)
N	512	512	512	512	510	452	512	509	512
P-Value	.86	.51	.48	.91	.44	.27	.16	.33	.87

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment									
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Above Median	.135**	.023	.021	.210	.021	.004	10.855**	13.723	.209*
	(.058)	(.073)	(.062)	(1.435)	(.062)	(.054)	(4.719)	(8.119)	(.122)
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Below Median	-.009	.090	.024	1.127	.024	-.034	3.119	2.888	.071
	(.043)	(.056)	(.075)	(1.994)	(.075)	(.067)	(5.670)	(9.112)	(.102)
N	512	512	495	495	495	495	493	291	472
P-Value	.03	.42	.98	.65	.98	.69	.27	.33	.38

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment										
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Above Median	-23.177***	.143**	-.096	.045	-.092	.058	-.050	-4.521	-.010	.466***
	(5.897)	(.059)	(.065)	(.028)	(.144)	(.120)	(.117)	(6.398)	(.136)	(.149)
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Below Median	1.405	.028	-.051	.023	-.133	-.207*	-.085	-6.052	-.179	.044
	(3.084)	(.048)	(.047)	(.028)	(.122)	(.116)	(.115)	(5.711)	(.127)	(.121)
N	485	485	512	512	512	512	512	490	512	446
P-Value	.00	.13	.47	.54	.78	.02	.81	.86	.21	.01

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (Cond. Working) (4)	Amount Overestimated (Cond. Working) (5)	Any Overestimate (Cond. Working) (6)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	School-to-Work Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
MYF Treatment								
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Above Median	-33.864***	-40.288***	-.100**	-50.304***	-94.671***	-.159	-.035	-.027
	(11.668)	(11.062)	(.039)	(15.166)	(17.263)	(.095)	(.334)	(.278)
× Pre-MYF Expected Earnings Below Median	-4.407	-7.076	-.021	-4.660	-2.775	-.064	-.295	.063
	(9.932)	(11.285)	(.054)	(12.290)	(23.083)	(.118)	(.309)	(.284)
N	509	468	468	366	218	218	512	493
P-Value	.04	.02	.15	.01	.00	.41	.55	.82

Notes: This table reports treatment effects separately by baseline earnings expectations (above-median vs. below-median). For outcome definitions and column details, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Additional Labor Market Outcomes

Table A.17: Additional Labor Market Outcomes

	Hours Practicing Technical Skills (1)	Employer Satisfaction (0-10, EL2) (2)	3 Mon+ Job Duration (3)
MYF Treatment Assignment	5.054	.259	.026
	(5.092)	(.187)	(.023)
Control Mean	57.38	7.55	.45
N	904	306	1013
T Effect (%)	8.81	3.43	5.67

Notes: In this table, we report the intent-to-treat estimates of the direct effects of the MYF program on additional labor market outcomes. These are obtained by estimating Equation 1. Dependent variables: Column 1: Total number of hours spent practicing technical skills in the last month. Column 2: Employer-reported satisfaction with the mentee on a scale of 0-10, measured at 1 year. Column 3: Ability to keep the job / firm running for at least 3 months. This variable takes the form of an indicator which takes the value of 1 if the duration of either first job, job at 3 months, or job at 1 year is 90 days or longer. Statistical significance throughout the paper is indicated by *, **, and *** for p-values of .10, .05, and .01, respectively.

Treatment Arm vs. Control

Table A.18: T1 vs. Control: Short Run, Medium Run, Job Search, and Beliefs

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
T1 (MYF)	.045*	1.547**	.056	-.050**	2.803	2.199	.081**	18.236**	.165**
	(.024)	(.661)	(.036)	(.023)	(2.632)	(3.279)	(.038)	(6.789)	(.067)
Control Mean	.85	16.15	.63	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
N	786	657	710	657	656	554	657	655	657
T Effect (%)	5.29	9.58	8.93	-23.28	23.32	15.08	15.09	23.36	-

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Out of the Labor Force (5)	Earnings Last Month (6)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (7)	Career Trajectory Index (8)
T1 (MYF)	.062**	.122***	.030	1.180	-.061*	10.573**	15.432***	.273***
	(.025)	(.042)	(.044)	(1.155)	(.031)	(4.065)	(4.283)	(.076)
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
N	657	657	638	638	638	633	358	583
T Effect (%)	34.34	33.00	5.34	9.44	-23.52	31.58	25.59	-

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
T1 (MYF)	-14.035***	.083**	-.012	.030*	.019	-.083	-.060	-10.928**	-.040	.268**
	(4.029)	(.040)	(.024)	(.016)	(.081)	(.071)	(.092)	(4.657)	(.092)	(.101)
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
N	464	465	657	657	657	657	657	619	657	422
T Effect (%)	-38.75	15.31	-6.94	3.19	-	-	-	-39.41	-	-

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (4)	Amount Overestimated (5)	Any Overestimate (6)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
T1 (MYF)	-18.249**	-29.944**	-.079***	-31.843***	-58.629***	-.115**	.002	.178
	(7.989)	(11.562)	(.027)	(11.366)	(17.423)	(.054)	(.191)	(.179)
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	157.27	100.64	.88	6.22	6.19
N	651	574	574	428	251	251	658	637
T Effect (%)	-12.48	-26.59	-8.40	-20.25	-58.26	-13.01	.03	2.88

Notes: This table reports T1-versus-control versions of the short-run labor market outcomes, medium run labor market outcomes, job search, and beliefs tables. For further details on each column, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.19: T2 vs. Control: Short Run, Medium Run, Job Search, and Beliefs

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	.008	.973	.092***	-.063**	.722	.296	.081***	20.744***	.136**
	(.022)	(.631)	(.027)	(.025)	(2.483)	(2.938)	(.025)	(7.238)	(.055)
Control Mean	.85	16.15	.63	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
N	791	670	724	670	667	555	670	666	670
T Effect (%)	.98	6.03	14.76	-29.70	6.01	2.03	15.00	26.57	-

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Out of the Labor Force (5)	Earnings Last Month (6)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (7)	Career Trajectory Index (8)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	.026	.038	-.012	-.500	.004	1.624	2.878	.024
	(.025)	(.042)	(.043)	(1.037)	(.030)	(3.711)	(5.683)	(.072)
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
N	670	670	668	668	668	663	365	613
T Effect (%)	14.22	10.34	-2.10	-4.00	1.54	4.85	4.77	-

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	-9.794***	.069*	-.066**	.028*	-.030	.075	-.107	-6.000	-.018	.311***
	(3.535)	(.038)	(.028)	(.016)	(.077)	(.082)	(.076)	(4.146)	(.072)	(.079)
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
N	467	468	670	670	670	670	670	631	670	429
T Effect (%)	-27.04	12.67	-38.79	2.98	-	-	-	-21.64	-	-

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Expected Amount (4)	Amount Overestimated (5)	Any Overestimate (6)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (7)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (8)
T2 (MYF+Cash)	-4.885	-3.044	-.047*	-13.909	-22.413	-.081	-.015	-.127
	(8.599)	(10.105)	(.026)	(11.917)	(18.551)	(.051)	(.165)	(.148)
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	157.27	100.64	.88	6.22	6.19
N	665	604	604	443	258	258	670	667
T Effect (%)	-3.34	-2.70	-5.04	-8.84	-22.27	-9.10	-.24	-2.06

Notes: This table reports T2-versus-control versions of the short-run labor market outcomes, medium-run labor market outcomes, job search, and beliefs tables. For further details on each column, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Pooled Variables

Table A.20: Pooled Variables: Estimation 1 and Estimation 2

Panel A — Estimation 1

	Out of the Labor Force (1)	Worked Last Month (2)	Days Worked Last Month (3)	Earnings Last Month (4)	Earnings Conditional (5)	Working in Sector of Training (6)	School-to-Work Transition Satisfaction (7)
MYF Treatment Assignment	-.043**	.022	.795	3.761*	4.114*	.049*	-.002
	(.017)	(.021)	(.492)	(2.094)	(2.206)	(.027)	(.110)
Control Mean	.24	.69	14.35	22.58	32.65	.47	6.20
N	1857	1857	1857	1847	1298	1857	1856
T Effect (%)	-18.15	3.16	5.54	16.66	12.60	10.52	-.04

Panel B — Estimation 2

	Out of the Labor Force (1)	Worked Last Month (2)	Days Worked Last Month (3)	Earnings Last Month (4)	Earnings Conditional (5)	Working in Sector of Training (6)	School-to-Work Transition Satisfaction (7)
MYF Treatment Assignment	-.032	.017	.497	6.884**	10.082**	.025	.009
	(.021)	(.030)	(.819)	(3.270)	(3.893)	(.036)	(.143)
Control Mean	.25	.58	12.72	30.71	36.95	.40	6.18
N	1013	1013	1013	1012	859	1013	1012
T Effect (%)	-12.71	3.01	3.91	22.42	27.29	6.27	.14

Notes: Panel A reports "Estimation 1," which pools outcomes measured at both rounds (e.g., school-to-work satisfaction, time spent conducting occupation-related tasks, worked in last month, earnings, conditional earnings, and worked in the same sector). The specification is $Y_{i,s} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 T_i + \beta_2 EL1_i + X_i'\delta + \lambda_s + \epsilon_{i,s}$, where $EL1_i$ is an indicator equal to 1 for Endline 1 observations and 0 for Endline 2 observations. Standard errors are clustered at the strata and trainee level. Panel B reports "Estimation 2," which keeps one observation per person: Endline 2 if available, otherwise Endline 1. Standard errors are clustered at the strata level.

ATE Estimates

Table A.21: ATE Estimates: Short Run, Medium Run, Job Search, and Beliefs

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment Takeup	.037*	1.289**	.096***	-.058***	1.730	1.231	.083***	19.571***	.153***
	(.021)	(.530)	(.024)	(.019)	(2.134)	(2.605)	(.025)	(4.793)	(.049)
Control Mean	.82	16.15	.62	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934
T Effect (%)	4.44	7.98	15.41	-27.04	14.40	8.44	15.38	25.07	-

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment Takeup	.042**	.078**	.007	.280	.007	-.026	6.215*	8.611**	.137**
	(.019)	(.033)	(.038)	(.944)	(.038)	(.023)	(3.514)	(4.218)	(.056)
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.56	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
N	934	934	923	923	923	923	916	512	844
T Effect (%)	23.28	21.07	1.22	2.24	1.22	-10.08	18.56	14.28	-

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment Takeup	-11.720***	.074**	-.040**	.030**	-.009	.002	-.088	-8.411**	-.029	.279***
	(3.244)	(.030)	(.020)	(.014)	(.067)	(.064)	(.076)	(3.843)	(.074)	(.077)
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668
T Effect (%)	-32.36	13.76	-23.64	3.16	-	-	-	-30.33	-	-

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (4)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (5)
MYF Treatment Takeup	-11.610	-16.207*	-.065***	-.008	.007
	(7.224)	(8.993)	(.021)	(.135)	(.143)
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	6.22	6.19
N	927	832	832	934	921
T Effect (%)	-7.94	-14.39	-6.93	-.14	.12

Notes: This table reports ATE versions of the short-run labor market outcomes, medium-run labor market outcomes, job search, and beliefs tables. For further details on each column, see Tables 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Table A.22: ATE Estimates with Full Takeup Definition (3+ Sessions)

Panel A — Short Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Worked Last Month (1)	Days Worked Last Month (2)	Currently Employed (3)	Out of the Labor Force (4)	Earnings Last Month (5)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (6)	Working in Sector of Training (7)	First Job Duration (8)	Short Run Index (9)
MYF Treatment Takeup (3+ Sessions)	.044*	1.549**	.115***	-.069***	2.080	1.462	.099***	23.545***	.184***
	(.025)	(.631)	(.029)	(.022)	(2.576)	(3.102)	(.031)	(5.737)	(.059)
Control Mean	.82	16.15	.62	.21	12.02	14.58	.54	78.07	-.00
N	934	934	934	934	931	786	934	929	934
T Effect (%)	5.34	9.59	18.51	-32.47	17.31	10.03	18.47	30.16	-

Panel B — Medium Run Labor Market Outcomes

	Retained Post Internship (1)	Internship to Job Transition (2)	Worked Last Month (3)	Days Worked Last Month (4)	Currently Employed (5)	Out of the Labor Force (6)	Earnings Last Month (7)	Earnings Last Month (Cond. Employed) (8)	Career Trajectory Index (9)
MYF Treatment Takeup (3+ Sessions)	.051**	.093**	.008	.347	.008	-.033	7.711*	10.581**	.161**
	(.023)	(.040)	(.047)	(1.171)	(.047)	(.028)	(4.384)	(5.182)	(.066)
Control Mean	.18	.37	.56	12.50	.56	.26	33.48	60.30	.00
N	934	934	923	923	923	923	916	512	844
T Effect (%)	27.96	25.30	1.51	2.78	1.51	-12.48	23.03	17.55	-

Panel C — Willingness to Accept a Job and Job Search Behavior

	Reservation Wage (1)	Would Accept Unpaid Job (2)	Refused Job Offer (3)	Started Job Search (4)	Search Efficacy Index (5)	Search Broadness Index (6)	Search Intensity Index (7)	Search Duration | Searched (8)	Search Behavior Index (9)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (10)
MYF Treatment Takeup (3+ Sessions)	-14.863***	.094**	-.048*	.035**	-.011	.002	-.105	-10.096**	-.035	.333***
	(4.134)	(.038)	(.025)	(.017)	(.080)	(.077)	(.092)	(4.578)	(.089)	(.094)
Control Mean	36.22	.54	.17	.93	-.00	.00	.00	27.73	.00	-.00
N	737	737	934	934	934	934	934	885	934	668
T Effect (%)	-41.04	17.45	-28.39	3.79	-	-	-	-36.41	-	-

Panel D — Beliefs: Earnings Expectations and Accuracy

	Expected Amount (1)	Amount Overestimated (2)	Any Overestimate (3)	Satisfaction (3 Months) (4)	Satisfaction (1 Year) (5)
MYF Treatment Takeup (3+ Sessions)	-13.955	-19.142*	-.077***	-.010	.009
	(8.637)	(10.526)	(.025)	(.162)	(.177)
Control Mean	146.25	112.62	.94	6.22	6.19
N	927	832	832	934	921
T Effect (%)	-9.54	-17.00	-8.18	-.16	.15

Notes: This table reports ATE versions of the short-run labor market outcomes, medium-run labor market outcomes, job search, and beliefs tables, where takeup is defined as concluding 3 or more mentoring sessions.

G.3 Additional Robustness

Table A.23: Treatment Effects by Mentor Types

	Mechanisms		Labor Market Outcomes	
	Search Behavior Index (1)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (2)	Short Run Index (3)	Career Trajectory Index (4)
Panel A — 2SLS				
Entry Conditions	-.09	.59***	.23***	.08
	(.10)	(.09)	(.08)	(.10)
Encouragement	-.04	.27***	.20***	.21***
	(.07)	(.09)	(.06)	(.07)
Search Tips	.05	.02	-.02	-.00
	(.13)	(.14)	(.08)	(.10)
Control Mean	.00	-.00	-.00	.00
N Mentors	158	158	158	157
N	934	668	934	844
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.67	.00	.00	.01
AP Partial F (pval)- Entry Conditions	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Encouragement	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Search Tips	.00	.00	.00	.00
Overidentification test (pval)	.51	.64	.42	.40
Panel B — LIML				
Entry Conditions	-.10	.67***	.24***	.07
	(.11)	(.10)	(.09)	(.11)
Encouragement	-.05	.27***	.20***	.22***
	(.07)	(.10)	(.06)	(.07)
Search Tips	.06	-.06	-.02	-.01
	(.14)	(.16)	(.08)	(.10)
N	934	668	934	844
Panel C — JIVE				
Entry Conditions	-.06	.56***	.23**	.09
	(.09)	(.10)	(.09)	(.10)
Encouragement	-.05	.23***	.18**	.22***
	(.07)	(.08)	(.07)	(.09)
Search Tips	.01	.07	.05	.01
	(.09)	(.12)	(.10)	(.11)
N	934	668	934	844
Panel D — UJIVE				
Entry Conditions	-.08	.76***	.28**	.11
	(.12)	(.14)	(.12)	(.15)
Encouragement	-.06	.28**	.19**	.26***
	(.08)	(.11)	(.08)	(.10)
Search Tips	.03	-.09	.00	-.04
	(.12)	(.17)	(.13)	(.15)
N	934	668	934	844

Notes: For 2SLS and LIML we cluster errors at Strata level. For JIVE and UJIVE we report robust errors.

Table A.24: Treatment Effects by Mentors with 4 or More Mentees

	Mechanisms		Labor Market Outcomes	
	Search Behavior Index (1)	Willingness to Accept Job Index (2)	Short Run Index (3)	Career Trajectory Index (4)
Panel A — 2SLS				
Entry Conditions	-.12	.56***	.20**	.05
	(.11)	(.09)	(.09)	(.11)
Encouragement	-.06	.28***	.21***	.18***
	(.08)	(.09)	(.06)	(.06)
Search Tips	-.00	-.09	-.10	-.09
	(.14)	(.15)	(.09)	(.10)
Control Mean	.00	-.00	-.00	.00
N Mentors	122	122	122	121
N	857	595	857	771
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.64	.00	.00	.02
AP Partial F (pval)- Entry Conditions	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Encouragement	.00	.00	.00	.00
AP Partial F (pval)- Search Tips	.00	.00	.00	.00
Overidentification test (pval)	.51	.60	.58	.39
Panel B — OLS				
Entry Conditions	-.07	.38***	.16*	.07
	(.11)	(.09)	(.09)	(.09)
Encouragement	-.06	.28***	.20***	.15**
	(.08)	(.09)	(.06)	(.06)
Search Tips	-.04	.11	-.08	-.06
	(.12)	(.14)	(.09)	(.09)
N	857	595	857	771
F-Test of joint significance (pval)	.86	.00	.02	.08

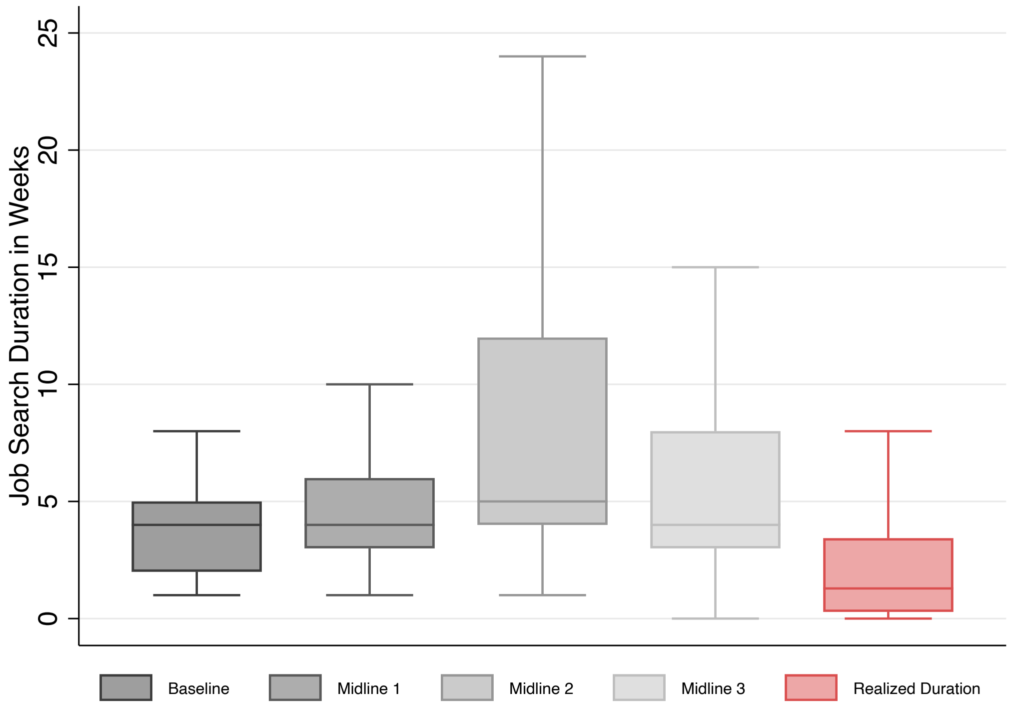
Notes: This table replicates Table 6 for mentors with 4 or more mentees.

Table A.25: Lee Bounds for Earnings at 1 Year

	Earnings		Log Earnings	
	Unconditional (1)	Conditional (2)	Unconditional (3)	Conditional (4)
Panel A — Pooled Treatment				
MYF Treatment Assignment	5.889*	8.382*	.125	.158
	(3.456)	(4.340)	(.158)	(.122)
	[2.399, 6.491]	[5.083, 11.690]	[.061, .164]	[.124, .295]
Panel B — By Treatment Arm				
T1 (MYF)	10.379**	14.336***	.318*	.357**
	(4.010)	(4.189)	(.184)	(.132)
	[9.297, 14.852]	[10.112, 16.233]	[.249, .411]	[.356, .434]
T2 (MYF+Cash)	1.871	2.801	-.047	-.029
	(3.647)	(5.522)	(.162)	(.148)
	[-7.055, 4.007]	[-1.628, 7.217]	[-.258, .087]	[-.087, .157]
Control Mean	33.48	60.30	1.98	3.56
N	916	512	916	512
Pooled Effects (%)	17.59	13.90	6.32	4.43
T1 Effects (%)	31.00	23.77	16.07	10.02
T2 Effects (%)	5.59	4.65	-2.40	-.81
T1=T2	.02	.02	.02	.01

Notes: This table reports ITT estimates of the direct effects of the MYF program on monthly earnings at 1 year (EL2). Columns 1–2 show raw earnings and Columns 3–4 show log-transformed earnings. Below each coefficient estimate, we report strata-level clustered standard errors in parentheses and Lee (2009) bounds in brackets. Underlined bounds indicate that the bound is significantly different from zero at the 5% level. Panel A reports pooled treatment effects, comparing all individuals assigned to MYF (T1 or T2) to the control group. Panel B reports treatment effects separately by assignment to treatment arm; the last row reports the p-value from a test of equality of the two arm-specific coefficients. Columns 1 and 3 show unconditional earnings at 1 year. Columns 2 and 4 show earnings conditional on working. Statistical significance is indicated by *, **, and *** for p-values of .10, .05, and .01, respectively.

Figure A.9: Expected and Realized Job Search Duration



Notes: The figure shows expected and realized job search duration in the control group. In the first four box-and-whisker plots, we plot students' expected job search duration at their first job in all four pre-intervention data points. The fifth plot represents students' realized job search duration, when looking for their first jobs after graduating from the vocational institute. Each plot shows the median and the interquartile range (25th and 75th percentiles). Whiskers extend to the lower and upper adjacent values, defined as the most extreme observations within 1.5 times the interquartile range.